



REAL DOG REHAB

The Behavior Emergency Toolkit

*Brian Ferguson's Field Guide
to the Eight Most Common
Dog Behavior Problems*

BRIAN FERGUSON

*A clinical reference for members of the
Real Dog Rehab community*

W E L C O M E

From Brian

A short note on what this manual is, who it's for, and how I want you to use it.

First — welcome to the Real Dog Rehab community. The fact that you have this manual in your hands means you've made the decision to do real work on your dog, and that decision matters. Most dog owners never get past the surface-level "training tips and tricks" content. You are about to get the protocols I run on the dogs other trainers couldn't help, written out the way I'd explain them to a friend over coffee.

I want to tell you a little about how this manual came to be. After more than two decades of training dogs — pets, working dogs, police canines, rehab cases — and after running the community for the years I've run it, I noticed a pattern. The same eight behavioral problems came up in nearly every consultation, every Q&A call, every member intake. Pulling on leash. Jumping on people. Recall failure. Nuisance barking. Leash reactivity. Resource guarding. Multi-dog household conflict. Separation anxiety. Different dogs, different breeds, different households — same eight problems, over and over.

This manual exists because those eight problems deserve a clinical reference. Something you can pull off the shelf when you need it, run the diagnostic, follow the protocol, and know that you're getting the same approach I'd give you on a Q&A call. You can read it cover-to-cover or you can jump straight to the chapter that matches your dog's most pressing issue. Either way works.

A NOTE ON HOW THIS MANUAL IS STRUCTURED

Chapter Zero is the diagnostic framework — the lens that runs through every chapter that follows. If you read nothing else, read Chapter Zero. The two motivators that drive every dog behavior, the dog-defines-reinforcement principle, the four operant quadrants, the two pillars that structure every protocol — those are the foundations. Every chapter after Chapter Zero assumes you have the lens.

Chapters One through Eight each handle one of the eight behaviors. Each chapter has the same structure: the behavior in plain English, the diagnostic of what's actually happening, what you must have in place before the protocol can land, the two pillars applied to that specific behavior, the protocol in phased steps, common ways the work goes wrong, when to escalate beyond the self-paced protocol, a thirty-sixty-ninety-day diagnostic checkpoint, common questions, and a closing "Working This Chapter" box.

The chapters are designed to be read in any order. Most readers should start with the chapter that matches their most urgent issue, then work through the others as they apply. The chapters cross-reference each other where they overlap.

A NOTE ON THE FOUNDATION

Every chapter in this manual assumes a baseline of foundational training is in place — your markers loaded, real food drive built, leash pressure conditioned as a language the dog understands, a place command that holds, basic obedience across non-trigger distractions, engagement-as-gate practiced. That foundation isn't built in this manual. It's built in the other fast-action bonus that came with this one — the *30-Day Quick Start Guide*.

If you've worked through the 30-Day Guide already, you have what you need. If you haven't, the chapters in this book will still teach you the diagnostic and the protocol, but each one is going to flag the prerequisites that have to be in place before the protocol can land. If those prerequisites aren't there, that's the work to do first. Run the 30-Day Guide. Then come back here.

If you've got a dog with a behavior emergency that genuinely cannot wait for a thirty-day foundation build first — a serious aggression case, a bite incident, a case that's putting somebody at risk — DM me inside the community. We'll talk about interim management while the foundation gets built underneath.

A NOTE ON THE SUPPORT LAYER

Two things are inside the Real Dog Rehab community that aren't inside this manual, and they're worth knowing about as you work through the chapters.

The weekly live Q&A calls are where customization happens. Every dog is different, and the protocols in this manual are templates that get refined for the specific dog in front of you. Bring video. Bring questions. We tune the protocols to your dog in real time on those calls. The "Working This Chapter" boxes at the end of each chapter flag the kinds of questions that benefit most from a Q&A check-in.

The DM-me-inside-the-community channel is where to bring the urgent stuff that can't wait for the next call. Bite incidents. Cases where the protocol is moving fast in the wrong direction. Cases where one of the escalation triggers in a chapter applies to your dog. I'd rather hear from you sooner than later on those.

That's the support layer. The work itself is in your hands and in this manual. Let's get to it.

— *Brian Ferguson, Real Dog Rehab*

ORIENTATION

How to Use This Manual

Quick orientation to the conventions, callouts, and sequences you'll see throughout. Two minutes of reading saves you a lot of confusion later.

THE CHAPTER SEQUENCE — READ OR JUMP

Chapter Zero before anything else. The diagnostic frame is non-negotiable. Every chapter that follows assumes the lens is in place — the two motivators, the dog-defines-reinforcement principle, the four operant quadrants, management versus training, the two pillars that structure every protocol. If those concepts aren't sitting in your head, the protocols will feel mechanical and probably not work the way they should.

After Chapter Zero, you have two reading paths. The first is sequential — work through Chapters One through Eight in order. This is the path I'd recommend if your dog has multiple issues, because the chapters build on each other and the cross-references make more sense when you've read the earlier ones. The second is targeted — go straight to the chapter that matches your most pressing problem and run that protocol. This is appropriate if you have one acute issue and the rest of your dog's training is reasonably solid.

THE CHAPTER STRUCTURE

Every behavior chapter follows the same structure. Once you know the structure, you can navigate any chapter quickly:

The behavior, in plain English. What this looks like in your house — without the technical language, without the moralizing.

What's actually happening. The diagnostic — chemistry, motivators, what the dog is actually getting from the behavior. Run the "what advantage / what discomfort" question every time.

What you must have in place before this protocol can land. The prerequisites. If these aren't built yet, run the 30-Day Quick Start Guide first. The protocol will not land without the foundation.

The two pillars applied. How Pillar One (incompatible behavior, bulletproofed off-trigger) and Pillar Two (rewiring the chemistry of the trigger) apply to this specific behavior.

The protocol. Phased step-by-step with checkpoints between phases. Run the phases in order. Don't stage-jump.

Common ways this goes wrong. The failure modes I see most often. Read this section before you start running the protocol — most of these mistakes are easier to avoid than to recover from.

When this is beyond the protocol — when to escalate. The cases that need professional input rather than self-paced work. If anything here applies to you, DM me in the community before continuing.

The 30 / 60 / 90 day diagnostic checkpoint. Where you should be at each milestone. If you're behind, that's a signal to back up to the previous phase, not to push through.

Common Questions. A sidebar of recurring questions on this chapter's topic.

Working This Chapter. Closing notes — what to focus on, what to bring to a Q&A call, where the chapter graduates to.

THE CALLOUTS

Throughout the manual, certain callouts repeat. Knowing what each means makes the reading faster:

Brian-isms in dark gold blocks are short principles or sayings I come back to repeatedly. If you're going to memorize anything in this manual, memorize the Brian-isms.

Pull quotes with a gold left rule highlight an important sentence from the surrounding text. They're worth re-reading.

Gate boxes marked with a triangle are prerequisite gates — what has to be in place before the protocol can run.

Phase headers in dark gold mark the start of a numbered phase in a protocol. Phases are sequential — finish the current one before moving to the next.

Checkpoint boxes in green appear between phases. They tell you what "clean" looks like at the end of a phase. If the checkpoint isn't met, stay in the current phase.

Escalation boxes in muted red list situations where the chapter's self-paced protocol is not the right fit. Read these. If anything applies, bring the case to me before continuing.

Common Questions sidebars in cream are recurring questions and short answers on the chapter topic.

Working This Chapter boxes in light gold close each chapter with practical orientation — what to focus on, what to bring to a Q&A call, what comes next.

A NOTE ON PACING

The protocols in this manual run on dog-time, not calendar-time. The thirty / sixty / ninety day diagnostic checkpoints are general guidance, not deadlines. Some dogs run through a chapter cleanly in a month; some take six months on the same chapter. Pace yourself to the dog in front of you. The signal to advance is the checkpoint, not the date.

The work compounds. The dog who finishes Chapter One on solid foundations runs through Chapter Five faster than the dog who skipped foundation work and is still trying to get markers loaded. Build the prerequisites. Skip nothing. The slow path turns out to be the fastest path in practice.

And finally — when you hit a moment that doesn't match what's on the page, that's not a flaw in the protocol. That's a customization point. Bring it to a Q&A call. We'll dial it in for your specific dog. The protocols are templates. Your dog is an individual. The community is where the templates get tuned to the individual.

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CHAPTER ZERO

0

The Diagnostic Framework

Read this before anything else. The protocols in the rest of this manual sit on top of this lens — without it, the drills are going to land flat. Spend the time here. The rest gets easier.

I don't care which behavior brought you here. Leash reactivity, jumping on every guest who walks through the door, the dog that won't stop barking at the fence, the dog that loses his mind when you leave the house — whatever the problem is, the chapter that addresses it is later in this manual, and you'll get there. But if you skip this chapter and jump straight to your dog's specific issue, the protocol is going to feel mechanical and probably not work the way it should.

That's not a sales pitch. That's twenty-three years of watching owners run drills they didn't understand and getting frustrated when the drills didn't deliver. The drills work. They work consistently. But they sit on top of a way of thinking about behavior, and if you don't have the way of thinking, the drills are just exercises.

So we spend a few pages here getting that lens in place. Then everything downstream of it gets a lot easier.

THE FIRST THING I WANT YOU TO UNDERSTAND

Most behavior problems are not what they look like.

What they *look* like is a flaw in the dog. *My dog is reactive. My dog is anxious. My dog is dominant. My dog is stubborn.* Owners come to me using language like that constantly, and I get it — when the dog is the one doing the lunging, the barking, the biting, the destroying-the-house-while-you're-at-work, it feels like a fact about the dog.

It almost never is. What you're looking at is a *system* the dog is running. The behavior is the output. The system is the cause. And the system sits across three things: the dog's genetics, the dog's emotional and chemical state in the moment, and — most of all — the patterns the dog has learned about what works.

BRIAN-ISM

Dogs only do what works. If something works, they will choose that path again.

That line is the operating principle of this entire manual. Your dog is not malfunctioning. Your dog is running a strategy that has, in their experience, paid off. Maybe not in a way you'd choose. Maybe not in a way that's good for them long-term. But it has worked enough times that it's now the path their brain reaches for first.

Our job is not to punish the strategy out of them. Our job is to teach a new strategy that pays better, then make the old strategy stop paying. That's the entire game. Every protocol in this manual is a version of that.

BEHAVIOR IS DOWNSTREAM OF CHEMISTRY

Here's the part most owners haven't been told and most trainers don't talk about clearly. Almost every behavior problem you're going to read about in this manual is, at root, a *chemical* event in the dog's brain.

Reactivity isn't disobedience. It's an arousal cascade — the dog's nervous system gets flooded with stress chemistry, and at a certain point in that cascade, the cognitive part of the brain effectively goes offline. The dog couldn't listen to you in that moment if they wanted to. The chemistry has hijacked the system.

Anxiety isn't bad behavior. It's a dog whose brain can't predict what's coming next, so the stress chemistry stays low-grade on at all times. They're not *choosing* to chew the doorframe — they're trying to discharge a chemical state they don't know how to settle.

Separation anxiety isn't a tantrum. It's a chemical dependency. You've been the source of the dog's regulation chemistry their entire life — every time they got nervous, you walked over, stroked their head, calmed the system down. They never had to build the neural pathway to produce those soothing chemicals on their own. So when you leave, they panic. Not because they're spoiled. Because their brain doesn't yet have the wiring to self-regulate.

Food drive isn't a gimmick. It's the most powerful reward chemistry a dog's brain has — wired in over millions of years to keep them alive. When I say "build food drive first," I'm saying *let's leverage the strongest motivational system the dog already owns*.

Once you start seeing behavior through the chemistry, two things happen. One, you stop blaming the dog — because you can see the dog is working with the brain they have, not the brain you wish they had. Two, you start choosing protocols that match the chemistry, not protocols that fight it. The order I teach things in, the proportions of reward to consequence, the pace I move at — none of that is ideology. It's all dictated by what the chemistry of the dog can actually accept and convert into learning.

WHAT I WON'T DO, AND WHY

Before we go further I want to put a stake in the ground about what you're *not* going to find in this manual.

You're not going to find me telling you to *be the alpha* with your dog. The idea that humans should act like another dog asserting hierarchy — rolling the dog, pinning them, dominance-posturing — was scientifically disproven well over a decade ago. Dogs do not experience that kind of treatment as canine communication; they experience it as unfair pressure from another species, and it destroys trust rather than building it. What I'll be talking about throughout this manual is something different and more useful: *leadership*. Being the one who reliably controls behavior in the moment, who dictates the rules of the household, who is the source of access to the things in the dog's life. That's not alpha. That's human leadership, and it operates by different mechanics.

You're also not going to find me telling you all you need is positive reinforcement and patience. I love positive reinforcement — I run more of it than almost any trainer I know. But I also use the other three operant quadrants, deliberately and clearly, because that's how nature actually teaches animals. Any trainer who tells you they only use one quadrant either doesn't understand learning theory or isn't being honest about what they actually do when nobody's watching.

If you've been told that *balanced training* is a euphemism for cruelty, you've been talked at by somebody trying to sell you their methodology by trashing other people's. Balanced just means using all four quadrants, in proportions the dog's chemistry can take. The order and proportions are dictated by the chemistry, not by ideology.

BRIAN - I S M

I always flow in and out of all four quadrants. Animals are not built to learn in a single quadrant. That's not how nature teaches.

WHAT'S ACTUALLY DRIVING EVERY BEHAVIOR — THE TWO MOTIVATORS

Before I show you the four quadrants, I want to put something deeper in front of them — the layer underneath the quadrants, the thing that explains *why* any of those four quadrants work in the first place. This is the part most owners have never been taught, and it changes how you see your dog forever.

Every single behavior your dog exhibits — every one, the good and the bad and the weird and the destructive and the endearing — is driven by one of two things, or sometimes both at once. There is no third option. Once you know what they are, you can read your dog.

Motivator one: creating an advantage

The behavior produces something that *feels good* to the dog. Not feels good in some abstract sense — feels good in the specific neurochemical sense of triggering a release of dopamine or serotonin or some other pleasure-loop chemistry. The dog does the behavior, the brain registers *that felt good*, the brain logs the rep, the behavior gets stronger.

Dog sits, gets a piece of chicken, dopamine fires — sit gets stronger. Dog runs in the yard, exercise endorphins fire — running in the yard gets stronger. Dog nudges your hand, gets petted, oxytocin fires — nudging gets stronger. Dog jumps on a guest, the guest laughs and pets the dog, social-bonding chemistry fires — jumping gets stronger, whether you wanted it to or not.

Every time you see a dog repeating a behavior they don't seem to need to repeat, ask: *what advantage is this creating for them?* What chemistry is firing? Some of it is obvious. Some of it isn't. But the answer is always there.

Motivator two: avoiding discomfort

The behavior reduces, prevents, or moves the dog away from something that doesn't feel good. The discomfort can be physical — pressure, cold, hunger, pain. It can be psychological — fear, uncertainty, social stress, isolation. It can be environmental — noise, weather, crowding. The dog doesn't have to be able to articulate it. The brain just has to register: *that was unpleasant, and this behavior moved me away from it.*

Dog eats food, hunger goes away — eating gets stronger. Dog comes inside from the rain, cold and wet go away — coming inside gets stronger. Dog barks at the approaching stranger, stranger backs off, fear chemistry settles — barking gets stronger. Dog moves into position when the leash applies light pressure, pressure releases, mild discomfort goes away — moving into position gets stronger.

Every time you see a dog repeating a behavior that has no obvious upside, ask: *what discomfort is this avoiding for them?* The discomfort is sometimes invisible to you, but it isn't invisible to the dog.

Some behaviors are doing both at once

Eating is the cleanest example. Eating creates an advantage — dopamine from anticipation, the pleasure of taste, full-belly satisfaction chemistry. Eating also avoids discomfort — hunger goes away, the gnawing in the gut settles. That's why food is such a powerful reinforcer. It's hitting both motivators on the same rep. This is also why food drive isn't a gimmick: when food is functioning the way it's supposed to function, every piece of kibble is paying the dog twice.

The reactive dog at the end of the leash is also doing both at once, by the way. The lunging discharges built-up arousal — that's the advantage side, a chemistry release. The trigger backs off or moves past — that's the discomfort side, the threat going away. Two motivators on one behavior. That's why reactivity is so durable when it goes unaddressed. Every reactive episode pays the dog twice. Behavior practiced grows in strength, and behavior practiced *and* double-paid grows fast.

The diagnostic question

Once you internalize the two motivators, you have a diagnostic that works on every behavior problem in this manual. Every chapter is going to come back to it.

What advantage is this creating for the dog, or what discomfort is this avoiding?

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Your dog jumping on every guest who walks through the door — what advantage is that creating? Almost certainly access to social interaction, plus the social-bonding chemistry of contact. Your dog refusing to come when called — what advantage is sniffing creating, or what discomfort is "stop sniffing and come back to dad" introducing? Your dog destroying the doorframe when you leave — what discomfort is that trying to discharge?

You don't fix a behavior by punishing it without also addressing what it was producing for the dog in the first place. The motivator doesn't go away when you punish the behavior. The motivator just looks for a different behavior to satisfy itself with. This is why suppression alone doesn't hold — you blocked the symptom, but the underlying drive is still there, and it's going to surface somewhere else.

The protocols in this manual all do two things at once: they remove the advantage or the relief that the unwanted behavior was producing, and they install a different behavior that produces the same advantage or relief in a way that works for everyone. That's why the protocols hold — they're not fighting the motivator, they're rerouting it.

THE FOUR QUADRANTS — AND THE PRINCIPLE THAT RUNS THEM

The two motivators — creating advantage, avoiding discomfort — are what's happening inside the dog. The four quadrants are the technical map of what we, the trainers, can do to engage with those motivators. The four quadrants are the levers. The two motivators are the engine.

The framework of the levers is simple. We either *add* something to the dog or we *remove* something from the dog, and the behavior either becomes more likely to happen again or less likely to happen again. Two choices on the action side, two outcomes on the result side. That's four combinations. Those four combinations are the four quadrants.

The words "positive" and "negative" in the names don't mean good and bad. *Positive* means we added something. *Negative* means we removed something. *Reinforcement* means the behavior went up. *Punishment* means the behavior went down. Once you have those four words attached to those four mechanical definitions, the rest is just plugging in examples.

But before I show you the four definitions, I have to lay one more piece of the puzzle in front of them — because it's the bridge between the motivators and the quadrants, and almost every owner I've ever worked with has gotten this part wrong on the way in.

The dog decides what reinforces and what punishes. Not you.

Here's why this principle exists, now that you have the motivators in place. Reinforcement and punishment are not abstract categories the trainer assigns. They are descriptions of what happened inside the dog. A consequence was reinforcing if it landed in the dog's "advantage" column — if it produced chemistry the dog wanted more of. A consequence was punishing if it landed in the dog's "discomfort" column — if it produced something the dog wanted less of. And the dog is the only one with access to those two columns.

Which means: reinforcement and punishment are not defined by what *you* intended. They are defined by what happens to the behavior afterward. If the behavior comes back, the consequence landed in the advantage column for the dog — it was reinforcing. If the behavior diminishes over reps, the consequence landed in the discomfort column for the dog — it was punishing. If nothing changes, you didn't reinforce or punish anything. You just applied a stimulus and the dog filed it under "irrelevant."

BRIAN-ISM

Punishment and reinforcement are in the eye of the beholder. They are in the eye of the animal.

This sounds like a small piece of vocabulary cleanup. It isn't. It cuts in three directions that matter for everything you're going to read in this manual.

One: you don't get to label something a "reward" and assume the dog agrees. A piece of chicken is not "a reward." Chicken *might* land in the advantage column for this dog, in this

moment, in this state. The proof is whether the behavior you paid for shows up again on the next rep. If it does, you reinforced. If it doesn't, the chicken was a non-event and your training session is rehearsing nothing. This is exactly why food drive isn't optional — it's how we make sure food has actually become reinforcing for this specific dog before we lean on it as the engine of every behavior we build.

Two: you don't get to label something a "correction" and assume the dog agrees either. If you pop the leash and the behavior keeps showing up — pop, surge, pop, surge, pop, surge, two hundred times across one walk — you didn't correct the dog. You applied force. There's a difference. Force without change is just force. Watch the next rep. If the behavior didn't change, the consequence didn't land in the discomfort column, and repeating it harder isn't going to make it land. Either the dog isn't perceiving it as punishing or you've trained the dog to absorb the level you're using as background noise.

Three: things you don't intend can be powerfully reinforcing. The dog jumps on the guest. The guest laughs and pets the dog. You didn't reinforce jumping; the guest did. The dog's brain doesn't care what you wanted to teach. The dog's brain logged: *jumping just produced advantage*. Behavior up. Reinforcement just happened. This is why I'll keep coming back to one diagnostic question — *what did the dog learn in this moment?* — every time we look at a real-world scenario in the chapters ahead.

So as you read the four quadrants below, hold this principle alongside them. We're going to define each quadrant by what we did and what happened. But the dog is the one who gets to vote on whether what we did landed in the advantage column, the discomfort column, or neither.

Positive reinforcement (+R)

We *added* something to the dog and the behavior became more likely to happen again. Dog sits. We give a piece of chicken. Sit shows up faster on the next cue, and faster on the one after that. The dog has voted: *chicken in this moment landed in the advantage column*. This is the quadrant most owners are familiar with and comfortable with. It is also, by volume, the dominant quadrant in everything I do — the engine of every behavior I build.

Negative reinforcement (−R)

We *removed* something from the dog and the behavior became more likely to happen again. Light leash pressure on. Dog moves into position. Pressure off. Over reps, the dog moves into position faster when pressure starts. The dog has voted: *moving made the pressure go away, and that release was worth working for*. That's negative reinforcement, and it's the foundation of how every leash-trained dog in history has learned what the leash means.

Most owners have been told negative reinforcement is harsh. It isn't. It's the most natural form of communication two organisms have — a small amount of pressure, a clear release when the dog gives the right answer, and a learned response that turns the pressure off. We use it with each other constantly without naming it. It's not punishment. It's a conversation.

Positive punishment (+P)

We *added* something to the dog and the behavior became less likely to happen again. Dog jumps the counter, finds a sizzling pan. Counter-jumping shows up less and less over the next several days. The dog has voted: *that landed in the discomfort column hard*. Notice that the consequence came from the *behavior itself*, not from the handler — that's a huge distinction we'll come back to several times in this manual. And notice that we know the pan worked as a punisher only because the behavior diminished. If the dog kept hitting the counter every chance they got, the pan wasn't punishing. It was just heat.

Negative punishment (–P)

We *removed* something from the dog and the behavior became less likely to happen again. Dog jumps on a guest. We turn and walk out of the room — the social interaction the dog had just been in is gone. Over reps, jumping diminishes. The dog has voted: *losing access to the human landed in the discomfort column hard enough to drop the behavior*. Used well, this is one of the cleanest, most relationship-safe consequences in the toolkit. Most owners under-use it because they don't realize they're holding a tool the dog cares about — and the only way they'll find out is to try it and watch what the next rep tells them.

BRIAN-ISM

Any trainer that eliminates one set or multiple sets of these quadrants clearly does not understand how an animal learns.

REWARD VERSUS CONSEQUENCE — THE DEEPEST PRINCIPLE IN THIS WORK

Here's something I want you to understand because it shapes the ethics of everything I teach.

There are only two ways to train a dog. Reward, or consequence. There is no third thing. Whatever else you call it, every interaction with the dog either makes a behavior more likely or less likely, and it does that through some flavor of those two mechanisms.

I use both. But the amount of consequence a dog ever needs over the course of their lifetime is a direct function of how strong the reinforcer is. A dog with a strong, well-built food drive needs almost no consequence — the reward is doing the heavy lifting. A dog with a weak reinforcer needs heavy consequence to get the same change in behavior, because there's nothing on the other side of the scale.

Building a strong food drive isn't a gimmick. It isn't optional. It's the kind path. The alternative is a lifetime of heavier corrections, because there's nothing strong enough on the reward side to compete.

We do the hard stuff up front so we can have more fun through training as we go.

BRIAN FERGUSON

If you ever feel like the methodology is asking too much of you in the foundation phase — too much focus on engagement, too much rationing food, too much patience while the dog figures out the marker — come back to this principle. The work you do up front is what lets the rest of training happen with a light touch. Skip the foundation and you'll be using a heavier touch for the next ten years.

MANAGEMENT VERSUS TRAINING — THE DISTINCTION THAT SAVES OWNERS FROM THEMSELVES

This is one of the most important distinctions in the manual, and one of the most consistently missed.

Management is what you do to prevent the dog from rehearsing a behavior. The crate. The baby gate. The leash on the slip lead inside the house. The closed bedroom door when guests arrive. The muzzle on the reactive dog at the vet. None of those things are *training* the dog out of the behavior. They are *preventing the practice* of the behavior while training is happening somewhere else.

Training is what changes the behavior. The drill. The repetition. The marker, the reward, the consequence, the new pattern getting built. Training rewires the dog. Management buys you the runway to do the rewiring.

Both are required. Neither is sufficient on its own. The owner who only manages — closes the dog in the bedroom every time guests arrive, never trains the door behavior — has a dog that will react every time they forget to close the bedroom for the next twelve years. The owner

who only trains — runs drills with no management, and lets the dog rehearse the bad behavior fifty times between sessions — is fighting their own training.

BRIAN-ISM

Every time he practices that behavior, it grows in strength. Period.

Read that line again. It applies to every chapter in this manual. The reactive dog who lunges at every dog on the walk is not just having bad walks — he's getting a training session, every walk, in being reactive. The dog who barks at the fence for forty-five minutes a day is rehearsing fence-barking forty-five minutes a day. Behavior practiced grows in strength. So the first job, every time, is to *stop the practice while we build the alternative*.

That's management. Management is not optional. Management is the runway.

THE TWO PILLARS — THE SPINE OF EVERY CHAPTER

Here is the structure that runs through every chapter. If you take one thing from this manual besides "behavior is chemistry," take this.

Every protocol in this book — for every one of the eight behaviors — has the same two-pillar shape:

PILLAR ONE

Build the incompatible behavior. Then bulletproof it.

An *incompatible behavior* is a trained behavior that is, by its own mechanics, impossible for the dog to perform at the same time as the unwanted one. A dog properly holding a down cannot simultaneously be at the end of the leash lunging. A dog in a proper heel cannot simultaneously be jumping on a guest. A dog engaged with you cannot simultaneously be locked on a trigger across the street. The incompatible behavior physically blocks the unwanted one — they can't coexist.

The core set is small: *sit*, *down*, *place*, *heel*, and above all, *engagement*. Those are your tools. Every protocol in this manual leans on some subset of them.

The work of Pillar One has two halves. First, build the behavior. Loaded marker, food drive, classical conditioning of leash pressure, shaping the position, layering the cue — the standard

foundation. Second, *bulletproof* the behavior — make it durable enough that it holds under distraction, under handler movement, under environmental change. We teach the dog to actively fight to maintain position when something tries to pull them out of it. We pay them, hard, every time they choose to stay rather than break. Over time the position becomes *theirs*. Not a thing they do because you told them to. A thing they do because they've decided it pays.

Pillar One is built *off-trigger*. Away from the thing that sets the dog off. We don't try to teach a dog to hold a down at the dog park while another dog is twenty feet away. We teach the down in the kitchen, then the yard, then the quiet street, then the busier street. By the time we bring the trigger into the picture, the dog has hundreds — sometimes thousands — of reps of the right answer. They know what the right answer is. They've been paid for it many times.

This is non-skippable. If you try to fix the behavior before the dog has a real, paid, bulletproofed alternative to offer — you're correcting a wrong answer without ever having taught the right one. That's unfair to the dog and it produces brittle results that fall apart the moment you stop enforcing.

PILLAR TWO

Change the emotional connection to the cue.

Once the incompatible behavior is solid off-trigger, we bring the trigger into the picture — at distance — and we start changing how the dog *feels* about it.

This is counter-conditioning. It's the second pillar and it's the part most handlers either rush, skip, or fundamentally misunderstand.

The principle: *the trigger has been a predictor of bad chemistry for a long time*. See the dog → arousal climbs → reaction. See the doorbell → arousal climbs → barking storm. See the suitcase come out → panic chemistry → destroy the doorframe. The trigger fires the chemistry, and the chemistry drives the behavior.

What we do in Pillar Two: we work below the threshold where the chemistry fires, and we make the trigger predict *good* things instead. Dog sees the other dog at one hundred yards, doesn't react, returns focus to me — gets paid, hard. Doorbell rings, dog stays on place, gets paid. Over reps the dog's brain reassigns: *this thing that used to mean trouble now means good things*. The chemistry shifts.

This is what I mean when I say you cannot correct an emotion. You can *suppress* a behavior with correction. You cannot *change the underlying chemical state* with correction. If you skip Pillar Two, you get a dog who looks calm because they've learned to fear the consequence, but the underlying state is still firing — and the moment your enforcement leaves the picture, or the chemistry gets strong enough to override the fear, the behavior comes right back.

BRIAN-ISM

If we just stick with a physical change and we suppress the emotions, they are always going to come back up later, somewhere else.

Pillar Two is done by walking the dog up the distance ladder. Far enough away that the dog can still cognitively function — take food, respond to the cue, choose to engage with you instead of the trigger. Then incrementally closer, only as the dog earns it, only as the dog stays under threshold and continues to choose engagement. The endpoint isn't *my dog loves the trigger*. The endpoint is *the trigger doesn't matter to my dog anymore*. Neutrality. Just another lamp post.

You will see these two pillars in every chapter that follows. The specific behaviors change. The triggers change. The timeline changes. The two-pillar shape doesn't.

TWO DIAGNOSTIC QUESTIONS TO KEEP WITH YOU

I'll close this chapter with the two questions I run on autopilot every time I'm working with a dog. They're the same two questions I want you running in your head every time you interact with yours, from the moment you finish this chapter.

"What did the dog learn in this moment?"

Every interaction your dog has with you, with another person, with another dog, with the environment — your dog is learning something. Not might be learning. Is learning. Their brain is logging the rep and adjusting its predictions about what works.

Most owners only ask "what did the dog learn?" after something has gone wrong. The dog bit. The dog reacted. The dog peed in the house. *What just happened?* By then the rep is already logged. The lesson the owner didn't intend has already been recorded.

The fix is to ask the question *during*, not after. Dog jumped on the guest. The guest laughed and petted them. *What did the dog learn in this moment?* Jumping pays. Dog barked at the fence. The neighbor walked away. *What did the dog learn in this moment?* Barking makes scary humans go away. Dog sat quietly on place while you cooked dinner. You walked over and dropped a piece of chicken. *What did the dog learn in this moment?* Calm pays.

You become a much better trainer the day you start asking that question constantly. Most of behavior modification is about *controlling what gets learned*, not about teaching a list of cues.

"Is this a management problem or a training problem?"

You'll catch yourself making this mistake constantly. The dog is rehearsing a behavior; you try to train your way out of it without first managing the practice. Or the dog is rehearsing a behavior; you manage it forever and never actually train the alternative.

Every time the unwanted behavior shows up, ask: *am I in a position to train through this right now, or do I need to manage out of it?* If you can't follow through — if the foundation isn't built, if the dog is over threshold, if you don't have the right tool, if your hands are full of groceries — manage. Get the dog out of the situation. Don't issue a command you can't enforce. Don't run a rep you can't win. Live to train another day.

BRIAN-ISM

I don't ever issue a command I can't follow through on.

Manage when you can't train. Train when you can. Both are honorable. The shame is in conflating them.

WHERE TO GO FROM HERE

The rest of this manual is built for jumping. Each of the next eight chapters takes one specific behavior problem, runs it through the diagnostic frame you just learned, and gives you the full protocol — diagnostic, prerequisites, phased step-by-step, common failure modes, when to escalate, and a 30/60/90 day self-assessment. Everything you need to actually run the work on your dog lives between these covers.

Read the chapter that matches your dog's most pressing issue first. If multiple chapters apply — and they often do; pulling on leash and reactivity travel together, jumping and recall failure travel together — start with the most universal one and work through the others in order. The chapters cross-reference each other, because most of these problems share the same foundations.

A note on the foundation work

Every chapter in this manual assumes a few foundational pieces are in place — your markers loaded and the dog responsive to them, real food drive built so we have something to work with, leash pressure conditioned as a language the dog understands rather than a thing they brace against, and a baseline of engagement and functional obedience. Those foundations

aren't built in this manual. They're built in the other fast-action bonus that came with this one — the 30-Day Quick Start Guide.

If you've worked through the 30-Day Guide already, you have what you need. If you haven't, the chapters in this book will still teach you the diagnostic and the protocol, but each one is going to flag the prerequisites that have to be in place before the protocol can land — and if those prerequisites aren't there, that's the work to do first. Run the 30-Day Guide. Then come back here.

If you've got a dog with a behavior emergency that genuinely cannot wait for a thirty-day foundation build first — a serious aggression case, a bite incident, a reactivity case that's putting somebody at risk — DM me inside the community. We'll talk about interim management while the foundation gets built underneath.

A note on the support layer

The protocols in this manual are field-tested. They are the same protocols I run at the facility on the dogs other trainers couldn't help, the same protocols my members run inside the Real Dog Rehab community every day. They work. They take the time they take, and they assume real follow-through, but they work.

If you hit something that doesn't quite match your dog — and you will, because dogs are individuals and protocols are templates — that's not a flaw in the protocol. That's a customization point. The weekly live Q&A calls inside the Real Dog Rehab community exist exactly for that. Bring video. Ask the question. We'll tune the protocol to your specific dog in real time. And if something is moving fast or feels off in a way you can't wait for the call, DM me in the community.

The work itself is in your hands and in this manual. Let's get to it.

BEFORE YOU MOVE ON

Sit with these ideas before you jump to a chapter. The two-pillar shape, the dog-defines-reinforcement principle, the management-versus-training distinction, the "what did the dog learn in this moment?" question — these are the lenses every chapter assumes. If they aren't sitting in your head yet, re-read the section that's still slippery.

If you haven't worked the 30-Day Quick Start Guide yet: consider doing that first, especially if your dog's behavior emergency isn't acute. The foundations the 30-Day Guide builds are what every protocol in this book stands on.

If something here genuinely doesn't make sense, bring it to a live Q&A call. Getting the conceptual frame solid now will save you weeks of false starts later.

CHAPTER ONE

1

Pulling on the Leash

The dog drags you down the street and you spend the whole walk wishing it was over. This is where most owners start. It's also where most owners learn that "the only problem" usually isn't the only problem.

THE BEHAVIOR, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

You clip the leash on. The dog hits the end of it within ten feet of the front door. From there it's forty-five minutes of being towed — shoulder hurts, arm extended, dog's collar pinching into the front of their throat, you trying to hold a coffee in the other hand without spilling it. The dog isn't *walking with you*. The dog is going somewhere, and you're attached to it.

Sometimes it's softer than that. The dog isn't pulling like a sled team but the leash is always under tension, the dog is always slightly ahead, and there's a constant low-grade negotiation about pace. Sometimes there's pulling plus zigzagging — every smell, every blade of grass, every fire hydrant is a course correction.

The owner's narration is almost always the same: *the only problem he has is pulling. Otherwise he's a great dog.*

I want to address that framing directly, because it shows up in almost every consultation I do.

WHAT'S ACTUALLY HAPPENING

Pulling is never the only problem

I've been training dogs professionally for over two decades. I have never — not once — met a dog whose *only* issue was pulling on the leash. Every time an owner has told me that, I've found, within ten minutes of meeting the dog, that engagement is broken, that the dog ignores the recall, that the dog has zero impulse control around food on the floor, that obedience cues work in the kitchen and don't work in the yard, or some combination of the above.

That doesn't mean the owner is lying. It means the owner has only flagged the issue that's painful enough to notice. Pulling shows up as a pain point because it ruins the walk. The other gaps don't show up as pain points because the owner has quietly built their life around them — they don't take the dog places where recall would matter, they don't run a sit-stay anywhere outside the kitchen, they've stopped expecting the dog to listen with distractions present.

Pulling is the symptom you noticed. It is rarely the only symptom that exists.

BRIAN FERGUSON

Why this matters: if you treat pulling as a standalone problem and try to fix it with a tool — a no-pull harness, a head halter, a different leash — you'll get a brief honeymoon and then it'll

come back, because you didn't fix the underlying gap. The underlying gap is that *the dog isn't paying attention to you on walks*. Every other symptom of that gap, including pulling, is downstream.

The chemistry of pulling

Here's what's happening in the dog's brain when they pull. They're outside, the environment is loaded with information — smells, sounds, movement — and their arousal system is up. Not over-the-top reactive arousal, just *walk arousal*, baseline elevated. In that state, the dog's cognitive bandwidth is being spent reading the environment, not the handler. You're behind them. They're processing the world. The leash is just the thing that's slowing them down.

Then there's the leash itself. The leash is, in most pulling dogs, a *tension cue*. The dog has learned that leash pressure means something is about to happen — usually a yank, a pop, a correction. So when the leash gets tight, the dog's body braces. Their shoulders set, their weight goes forward, they lean into the pressure. This is a reflex. It's hardwired into mammals. We call it the oppositional reflex — push against me and my body pushes back. Pull on me and my body pulls forward.

Most owners are unwittingly training the oppositional reflex into the dog every walk. The dog hits the end of the leash, the owner pulls back, the dog leans into the pull, the owner pulls harder, the dog leans harder. Both parties are now in a tug of war, and the dog is winning, because dogs are stronger than humans pound for pound. The behavior — pulling — gets practiced, the brain logs the reps, and pulling grows in strength.

The leash is supposed to be a language, not a tether

This is the conceptual move that fixes pulling. The leash is not a containment tool. The leash is a *communication tool*. It applies pressure, then releases it, and the release is what teaches the dog what we want.

If you've never heard pressure-and-release described as a two-way conversation, here's the basic shape. I apply light pressure in a direction. The dog moves into that direction. The pressure releases. The dog has learned: *moving in this direction makes the pressure go away*. Repeat that a few hundred times across positions and directions, and the dog has a vocabulary. Pressure forward = move forward. Pressure backward = move backward. Pressure up = sit. Pressure down = down. Pressure to the side = come into heel position.

That's negative reinforcement and it's the entire foundation of leash work. It is not punishment. The dog isn't reacting to the pressure because it hurts; the dog is learning to *read* the pressure because the release is reliable and predictable. Every time the release comes the moment the dog gives the right answer, the dog gets a small dopamine hit and the answer gets reinforced.

The dog you want — the dog who walks beside you on a slack leash, mimicking your movement, slowing when you slow, stopping when you stop — is a dog who has learned this language. Pulling, in that frame, isn't a discipline problem. It's a dog who hasn't yet been taught what the leash means.

BRIAN-ISM

If the leash is tight when you're in the right position, you are tethering your dog to you. Your dog is not choosing to walk beside you. Those are two very different things.

The three qualifications of proper leash skills

Before we get to the protocol, let me give you the diagnostic standard you're working toward. Any time you want to assess where your dog's leash skills actually are, run them against these three criteria.

One: proper position. The dog's shoulder is aligned with your lower leg. Where exactly on the leg depends on the dog's height — shoulder by the knee for taller dogs, by the shin or ankle for shorter dogs, by the hip for very tall ones. Not in front. Not behind. Not off to the side.

Two: slack in the leash. When the dog is in the correct position, the leash is loose. There's a smile in it. If the leash is taut, the dog is being held — they aren't choosing to be there.

Three: the dog mimics your movement. You slow, the dog slows. You speed up, the dog speeds up. You stop, the dog stops. You turn, the dog turns. *And all of that happens before the dog reaches the end of the leash.* If the leash has to go tight before the dog adjusts, the dog wasn't paying attention to you. They were on their own trajectory and you happened to be holding the line.

A check-in — the dog glancing back at you for a second to confirm "what are we doing, mom?" — is healthy and expected. We pay every check-in we get.

WHAT YOU MUST HAVE IN PLACE BEFORE THIS PROTOCOL CAN LAND

This is the section most owners want to skip. Don't.

► BEFORE YOU RUN THIS PROTOCOL

If the items below aren't in place, no leash protocol you run is going to stick. The protocol assumes the dog has the underlying language. If the language isn't there, build it first.

- **Loaded markers.** The dog understands "yes" or your clicker as the signal that food is coming. They've been conditioned to expect it. They orient when they hear it. If you're not sure, run the test: walk into the kitchen, say your marker, deliver food. Do that ten times across a couple of sessions. By rep five the dog should be turning to you on the marker before the food appears.
- **Food drive built.** The dog will work for kibble, in the yard, when distractions are present. If your dog will only take food in the kitchen with no one else around, food drive isn't built yet — and without it, none of the engagement work below is going to fire.
- **Leash pressure conditioned.** The dog understands that light leash pressure is a cue to move toward the paycheck, not a thing to brace against. This is Phase 2 work — pressure starts, dog moves into it, pressure releases, dog gets paid.
- **Static heel before motion heel.** The dog can hold position beside you — without moving — across distractions, before you ever ask for movement.

If any of those four items are not in place, the rest of this chapter is going to feel like trying to build the second floor of a house before the foundation has cured. You'll get something that looks like a house. It won't hold weight.

The 30-Day Quick Start Guide that came with this one — your other fast-action bonus — walks through every one of those prerequisites in sequence, day by day, with the build for each. If you're missing one, that's where to go. Build it. Then come back here. The protocol will land cleanly when the foundation is in place.

THE TWO PILLARS APPLIED TO PULLING

Pillar One for pulling on the leash is the heel position itself, bulletproofed off-walk. Pillar Two is changing what the leash and the outdoor environment *mean* to the dog — from tension and tug-of-war to engagement and paycheck.

That's the structure. The protocol below is how it actually runs.

THE PROTOCOL

PHASE ONE

Static heel, indoors, no motion.

1 | Set up in the lowest-distraction environment you have.

Living room, kitchen, an empty hallway. Slip lead on the dog (not a flat collar, not a harness, not a head halter). Treats in the pouch on your hip. Marker loaded.

2 | Help the dog into heel position beside you with light leash pressure.

Pressure on. The instant the dog moves toward your side, pressure off. Mark, pay *in position* — food delivered directly from your hand to the dog's mouth, while the dog's shoulder is by your leg. Do not toss the food away. Tossing trains the dog to look away from you for the reward. We are training the dog to look *to* you for it.

3 | Repay before the dog leaves position.

Dog is in heel. Mark, pay. One second later, mark, pay. Two seconds, mark, pay. We are paying the *hold*, not the act of getting into position. The dog learns: standing here next to dad pays. Repeatedly. Right now.

4 | If the dog leaves position, no pay, calm "no," pressure back.

Dog drifts forward or to the side — flat, neutral "no," not loud, not angry. Light leash pressure into the heel position. Pressure releases when the dog is back in. *Do not mark and do not pay the recovery itself*. The pay comes on the next clean rep, after a beat of clean hold. If you pay the recovery, you'll teach a high-drive dog the chain: leave, get told no, get pressured back, get paid. They'll start leaving on purpose to run the chain. Pay clean reps only.

5 | Build duration in place.

Five seconds of clean hold paid. Then ten. Then twenty. Move slowly. You are training the dog that the position itself is the paycheck.

✓ PHASE ONE CHECKPOINT

The dog can hold static heel beside you, leash slack, for 30 seconds, in the living room, with no distractions. You can mark and pay in position three times in that thirty seconds without the dog moving. If you cannot get this clean indoors, do not move outdoors. Stay here.

PHASE TWO

Add motion. One step at a time.

1 | Take one step.

Dog beside you in static heel. Take a single step forward. If the dog stays in position — mark, pay in position. If the dog drifts — calm "no," pressure back into position, no pay on the recovery. Re-set, take another step.

2 | Two steps. Three. Five.

Build by single-step increments, paying in position constantly. We are teaching the dog: position holds during motion. The motion is just a thing the handler is doing; my job is the same.

3 | Add direction changes.

Once the dog is reliably mimicking forward motion, start mixing in slow turns — a quarter turn left, a quarter turn right, a slow about-face. The dog should be tracking your lower leg and turning with it. Pay each clean turn.

4 | Add pace changes.

Slow your pace, then speed up. The dog should match. If the dog falls behind or forges ahead, the leash will tell you — slack vanishes. Calm "no," pressure back into position, no pay on the recovery. Continue.

5 | Add distractions, in the same environment.

Heel around food on the ground. Toss a handful of kibble in a corner of the room — heel the dog past it without letting them dive for it. If they break for the food, calm "no," pressure back to heel, no pay on the recovery. The next clean pass is what gets the click and the chicken. Win small distractions before you ever step outside.

✓ PHASE TWO CHECKPOINT

The dog holds heel through ten paces, two direction changes, one pace change, and one food-on-the-floor distraction. Indoors. Slack leash throughout. If you can't get this clean, you are not ready for the front yard. Stay here.

PHASE THREE

Take it outside, in the climbing-distraction order.

1 | **Backyard first.**

Same drills, same standard, your own backyard. Distractions are different — outdoor smells, outdoor sounds — but you have control of the environment. Run the same Phase Two repertoire. Do not advance until clean.

2 | **Front yard.**

Now there are passersby — joggers, neighbors, dogs across the street. You have ground to retreat to if the dog goes over threshold. Run the same drills. Pay clean engagement constantly. If a person walks by and the dog stays in heel and offers a check-in to you, that gets a jackpot — multiple pieces, hand to mouth, while the dog is still in position.

3 | **Quiet sidewalk, off-peak.**

Pick a time and a route where the variables are low. Early Sunday morning, weekday mid-afternoon — whatever your neighborhood's quiet window is. Walk for ten minutes, not forty-five. Short, clean, paid. End the walk before the dog has a chance to rehearse anything you don't want.

4 | **Climb the environmental ladder.**

Quiet sidewalk → moderate sidewalk → busier sidewalk → light commercial area → busy commercial area. Each rung is a separate proofing pass. Do not assume because the dog is clean on the quiet sidewalk that they'll be clean at the brewery. Dogs are contextual learners. Each environment is a new generalization step.

COMMON WAYS THIS GOES WRONG

Trying to fix it on the walk itself

This is the single most common failure mode. The owner notices the pulling, decides today is the day, clips on the leash, takes the dog out, and tries to enforce a heel that the dog has never been taught indoors. The dog has no idea what the cue means in that environment. The owner gets frustrated, starts correcting, the dog gets confused, both parties have a bad walk, the next day is the same.

The fix: *do not train the heel on the walk*. Train it indoors, train it in the backyard, train it in the front yard. The walk is where you *test* heel, not where you *teach* it. If the heel isn't there yet, the walk is a maintenance walk on a slip lead with the goal of just not making it worse — which sometimes means not walking at all for a few weeks while the foundation gets built. That's fine. We'll come back to that.

Paying the recovery instead of the clean rep

Dog leaves position, you cue them back in, dog comes back in, you mark and pay. This feels right — they did what you asked. But what you've actually trained is the chain: *leaving position is part of how I get paid*. A high-drive dog will start leaving on purpose to run the chain.

The fix: pay the clean reps, not the recoveries. Dog leaves, calm "no," pressure back in, no pay. The dog stays clean for the next several seconds, and *then* a fresh rep — handler initiates motion or marks the held position — earns the click and the food. Make the clean version the only version that pays.

Tossing the reward instead of paying from the hand

This is a small mechanical detail with a big effect. When you mark a behavior and then toss the food a few feet away, you're inadvertently training the dog to disengage from you to get paid. Their head goes away from you to the food. The eye contact, the engagement, the mental orientation toward the handler — all broken at the moment of payment.

The fix: pay from the hand, in position. The food comes from your hand to the dog's mouth, while the dog is still in the position you marked. If you want a reset toss for the next rep, that's a separate cued event — say "get it" or whatever your release word is, then toss. The pay comes from the hand. The toss is a release, not a pay.

Mixing sniffing and walking

The other clarity-breaker. The owner's rule has been "the dog can sniff if it's not pulling too hard," or "the dog can sniff during the walk as long as he keeps up with me." Now the dog has two modes — heel and free — but no clear cue for which mode is which. Every walk is a negotiation. The dog gets confused, the owner gets frustrated, the work doesn't stick.

The fix: handler moving, dog heels. Handler stopped, dog can be released to sniff. Movement equals obedience. Stopped equals freedom. Two clean modes with a sharp boundary between them. Dogs cannot live in gray areas — they need the line drawn clearly. Once the rule is sharp, the dog stops trying to negotiate it.

BRIAN - I S M

Dogs live in the land of always and never. Sniffing on walks is always or never, not "sometimes when I feel like it."

Reaching for the wrong tool

No-pull harnesses, head halters, gentle leaders. These are sold as solutions. They aren't. They're suppression tools — they make the pulling physically harder for the dog, but they don't teach the dog anything about what we want instead. The moment you take the suppression tool off, the pulling comes back, because the dog never learned the alternative.

What I run on a foundation dog is a slip lead. Six feet, three-eighths inch diameter, simple loop. The slip rides high on the neck, just behind the ears, where the dog's perception of pressure is most precise. It applies clean directional pressure when needed and releases cleanly when the dog gives the right answer. It's a communication tool, not a containment tool. That's the entire point.

WHEN THIS IS BEYOND THE PROTOCOL — WHEN TO ESCALATE

ESCALATION TRIGGERS

Most pulling cases are not escalation cases. They are foundation cases. But there are situations where the protocol above is not the right place to start. Bring these to a Q&A call or DM in the community before continuing.

- The dog is so physically strong that you cannot safely hold them on the slip lead without risking your own injury. Get to a Q&A call to discuss interim management — a back-tie setup, a different starting environment — before you try to train.
- The dog goes into reactive lunging the moment the leash clips on. That is not a pulling problem; that's the leash itself functioning as a trigger, and you'll want to read Chapter 5 (Leash Reactivity) before this one.
- The dog shuts down or panics under any leash pressure. That's a fearful dog, not a strong puller, and the down-and-dirty corrective methods in any other resource will damage the dog. Bring video to a Q&A call. We'll diagnose and adjust.

THE 30 / 60 / 90 DAY DIAGNOSTIC CHECKPOINT

Use this to assess whether the protocol is taking. If you're behind these markers, that's not failure — most at-home work runs slower than facility work, because we have unlimited training time and you don't. But it's a signal to back up to the previous phase and clean it before continuing.

Day 30

Static heel and short-motion heel are clean indoors and in your backyard. The dog is reliably orienting to you on the marker. Slack leash in position. Pay-in-position habit is built. You haven't started serious outdoor walks yet — that's intentional.

Day 60

Front-yard heel is clean. Quiet sidewalk heel is clean for at least ten-minute walks. The dog is checking in with you regularly during walks without being prompted. You have proofed against at least one moderate distraction (food on ground, a passing person, a stationary dog at distance) and the heel held.

Day 90

You can take the dog on a real-world walk through your usual neighborhood and the leash is slack the entire time. You can change pace, change direction, stop, and the dog mimics. You're paying intermittently — not every step, but on every clean check-in and every distraction held. The walk has stopped being a fight. It's an activity you actually enjoy.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: Should I just stop walking the dog while we build the foundation?

A: *For a non-reactive puller, no — keep up short, low-distraction walks for exercise, but treat them as maintenance walks on a slip lead, not training walks. Don't try to enforce heel out there yet. For a reactive dog who pulls, the answer is more often yes; see Chapter 5.*

Q: My dog is fine on a flat collar — do I really need a slip lead?

A: *A slip lead applies clean directional pressure that releases cleanly. A flat collar applies sustained pressure that the dog learns to lean into. The slip is the right teaching tool. After the heel is fully built, you can transfer the language to a flat collar if you want.*

Q: What if my dog will not take food on a walk?

A: *Two issues stacked. One, food drive isn't fully built. Two, you're probably working over the dog's threshold for the environment — they're too aroused to eat. Back up. Build food drive in the kitchen, then yard, then front yard. Quiet sidewalk is later.*

Q: How long should each session be?

A: *Short. Five to ten minutes of focused work, multiple times a day, beats one long session. The dog's brain encodes better in short reps. Quit while it's still going well.*

Q: My family member doesn't follow the protocol when they walk the dog. Now what?

A: *The dog is going to be inconsistent until the household is consistent. Either get the family member onboard or take over the walks yourself for the duration of the build. Mixed signals from different handlers will stretch this out badly.*

WORKING THIS CHAPTER

If your foundation isn't yet built: the protocol above assumes the prerequisites at the top of this chapter — markers, food drive, leash pressure as language. If any of those aren't in place, the 30-Day Quick Start Guide that came with this manual is where they get built. Run that first. Most readers who skip it end up coming back to it after a frustrating week of trying to layer the heel build on top of nothing.

If you're starting from a solid foundation: plan on Phase One taking a couple of weeks before you even step outside. That feels slow. It's not slow — it's the difference between a dog who learns the heel and a dog who fakes it indoors and falls apart on the sidewalk. Stay inside until the static heel and short-motion heel are clean.

If you also have reactivity: work this chapter and Chapter 5 in parallel, but lead with foundation. A solid heel is one of the incompatible behaviors Chapter 5 will lean on. Don't try to start reactivity work until the foundation built here is in place.

If something is getting stuck: bring it to the next weekly live Q&A call inside the Real Dog Rehab community. Bring video — the timing of your release, the position of your slip lead, the pace of your distance work are all things that are much easier to calibrate when I can see them. Or DM me in the community if it's something that can't wait for the call.

CHAPTER TWO

2

Jumping on People

The dog goes nuclear every time someone walks through the door. You've tried turning your back, kneeing in the chest, yelling "off." Nothing's holding. Here's why — and what to do instead.

THE BEHAVIOR, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Doorbell rings. Dog detonates. By the time the guest is two steps inside, the dog is up on their hind legs, paws on chest, face right in the visitor's face — sometimes licking, sometimes mouthing, sometimes barking, all of it loud and uncontrolled. Or maybe it's not guests. Maybe it's you, every time you come home from work — the dog meets you at the door at full speed, lands on you, and you spend the first thirty seconds of being home defending yourself.

For some owners it stays at "annoying but mostly harmless." For others it's escalated to the point where they don't have people over anymore, the dog has knocked down a child, the older relative is afraid to visit, and the relationship between the household and the rest of the world has quietly contracted around the problem.

Either way: the dog isn't mean. The dog is overwhelmed and untrained. We can fix this.

WHAT'S ACTUALLY HAPPENING

The chemistry of the greeting explosion

Let's run the diagnostic question first. *What advantage is the dog creating, or what discomfort is the dog avoiding, when they jump on people?*

This one is almost always pure advantage. The dog is going up because going up *works*. Every previous greeting has paid the dog with a chemistry release — social interaction, attention, eye contact, voice, sometimes physical petting — and the dog's brain has logged hundreds of reps of that pattern. Person enters → I jump → I get social-bonding chemistry. Behavior up. Reinforcement keeps happening. Behavior grows.

And here's the part most owners don't see clearly until I point it out: the visitor's reactions are often what's reinforcing the behavior, even when the visitor thinks they're discouraging it. The guest who pushes the dog off and laughs while doing it has just paid the dog with attention plus contact. The friend who says "oh, he's fine, I love dogs" while letting the dog mouth at their hands has just told the dog this strategy is working. The grandparent who shrieks and backs up has given the dog a fun reaction. Every one of those moments is the guest reinforcing the jump.

BRIAN-ISM

Every time he practices that behavior, it grows in strength. Period.

So the first reframe: jumping isn't a flaw in the dog. Jumping is a strategy that has paid the dog reliably, sometimes for years. Asking the dog to "just stop" without changing what the strategy produces is asking them to walk away from a paycheck.

The deeper layer — zero practice at delayed gratification

Underneath the specific jumping problem is almost always a broader issue: the dog has never practiced delaying anything. They look at the door, the door opens. They look at the food bowl, food appears. They look at you, you talk to them or pet them. The whole environment runs on dog's-terms timing. Every impulse the dog has ever had has been satisfied, immediately, without any pause to check in with the human.

So when the doorbell rings and the dog's brain fires *person, social access, run go now*, there's no apparatus in the dog's head for restraint. The impulse and the execution are the same event. The dog isn't being defiant. The dog has never been required to *not* execute on an impulse. The muscle was never built.

This matters because it tells you what the actual fix has to be. We're not just stopping the jumping. We're installing the mental apparatus underneath that lets the dog pause, check in with you, and offer a different behavior in the moment of high arousal. Once that's installed, the jumping isn't the only thing that gets fixed. A dozen other rough edges in your day-to-day life with the dog improve at the same time, because they're all downstream of the same gap.

Why "ignore the jump" doesn't work for most dogs

Almost every owner I work with has been told to turn their back, fold their arms, and ignore the jumping until the dog learns it doesn't work. Sometimes that protocol does work — for a small subset of dogs. For most dogs it produces six weeks of frustration followed by an owner who concludes their dog is uniquely broken.

Here's why ignoring fails for most dogs: ignoring works only if attention is the *only* reinforcer the dog is getting from the jump. For most dogs it's not. The physical contact is reinforcing. The sound and movement of the human reacting is reinforcing. The discharge of the arousal energy through jumping itself is reinforcing — the dog gets a chemistry release just from the act of leaping. Even a turned back doesn't remove all of that. So the dog keeps jumping, the

owner keeps ignoring, and the behavior never extinguishes because it never actually stopped paying.

Ignoring also assumes the dog has alternative behaviors to offer. They don't, in most cases. If the only behavior in the dog's repertoire for greeting is the jump, the dog is going to keep jumping while you turn your back, because they have no other tool to reach for. Telling a dog to stop doing the only thing they know how to do is unfair without giving them something else to do instead.

WHAT YOU MUST HAVE IN PLACE BEFORE THIS PROTOCOL CAN LAND

► BEFORE YOU RUN THIS PROTOCOL

The protocol below leans on a specific incompatible behavior — a clean, paid, durable down on place. If that's not in place, the rest of this chapter won't work, and the work to do first is the place build.

- **A loaded marker.** The dog turns to you on the marker word and expects food. Tested across at least three environments.
- **Real food drive.** The dog will work for kibble in the kitchen, the yard, and at least one mildly distracting environment.
- **A clean down on cue.** Verbal "down" produces a down, on a flat collar or slip lead, in low-distraction environments. Not just in the kitchen with food in your hand — in at least the yard too.
- **Place fluency.** The dog goes to a designated place bed on cue, downs on it, and holds for at least sixty seconds across moderate distraction. This is the single most important prerequisite. The whole greeting protocol is built around the place.

If you don't have those four pieces in place, go work the 30-Day Quick Start Guide that came with this manual. The place build, the marker conditioning, the food drive work — all of it is sequenced there. Build it. Then come back. The protocol below will land cleanly when the foundation is in place. It will not land if you try to layer it on top of nothing.

THE TWO PILLARS APPLIED TO JUMPING

Pillar One is the place command, bulletproofed off-trigger. Place is the behavior that's physically and mentally incompatible with jumping on a guest — the dog cannot simultaneously be in a clean down on a cot and also up on someone's chest. We build place to functional level *before* any guest is involved. By the time we add a person to the picture, the dog has hundreds of paid reps of place behind them.

Pillar Two is the rewiring of what the doorbell, the door, and the visitor *mean* to the dog. Right now, those are predictors of social-access chemistry — they fire the arousal cascade that ends in the jump. We're going to change that prediction. By the end of the protocol, the doorbell will be a predictor of "go to place, hold, get paid." The visitor coming through the door will be a predictor of "stay calm to gain access." The chemistry shifts. The default behavior shifts with it.

THE PROTOCOL

PHASE ONE

Build the impulse-control foundation off-greeting.

The first phase doesn't involve guests, doorbells, or doors. We are training the dog to value engagement with you more than they value access to a resource — using a controlled drill that builds the underlying mental apparatus the rest of the protocol will rely on.

1 | The place-bed kibble drill.

Dog on place, leashed to it so they can't break. Toss a handful of kibble on the floor two or three feet away. Don't say anything. Don't cue anything.

The dog's brain will run through the obvious moves. *There's the kibble. There's the kibble. Why am I not getting the kibble?* Eventually — sometimes after thirty seconds, sometimes after three minutes — the dog gives up trying to mentally reach for the floor and looks at you. *Hey, what's going on?* The instant the dog disengages from the food and engages with you, mark and pay *from your hand*. Not from the floor. The food on the floor stays on the floor — it's the bait, not the paycheck.

Repeat. Each rep, the check-in comes faster. The dog is learning: *engagement with the handler, not fixation on the resource, is what produces reward.*

2 | **Run the drill until the check-in is automatic.**

You're looking for the moment the dog stops staring at the floor and starts watching you the second the kibble lands. That's the muscle being built. When that pattern is reliable across three sessions, you're ready to scale up.

3 | **Scale up to a higher-value resource.**

Same setup, but now the bait is something significantly higher value — a bowl of kibble with a little bacon grease over it, two feet away from the place bed, accessible in theory, blocked by the leash in practice. The dog drools. The dog's brain redlines. Wait it out. Eventually the same pivot — the dog gives up direct access and looks at you. Mark, pay from your hand.

Then, *only* when the dog has stopped trying entirely and is locked on you, release them with your release word and let them go to the bowl. The access to the high-value resource goes through engagement. Engagement is the gate.

4 | **Generalize to people coming and going.**

Same setup. Dog on place, leashed. A familiar household member walks through the room. Don't cue anything. The dog will want to break and greet — they always do. The leash prevents the break. Wait for the check-in. Mark, pay.

Build it up across reps. Family member walks through, family member stops, family member walks past. The dog learns to hold place while people move around them. Same engagement-as-gate pattern, but now the resource is social access instead of food.

✓ **PHASE ONE CHECKPOINT**

The dog can hold place with food on the floor two feet away, with a high-value resource just out of reach, and with familiar people walking through the room. They check in with you autonomously and don't try to break. You can pay engagement, hold for a stretch, then release them to the resource through your release word. Without this phase clean, the greeting protocol below will not work. Stay here until it is.

PHASE TWO

Isolate the door variables. Add the visitor last.

Most owners try to fix jumping by inviting a friend over and "practicing." The problem is that all the variables — doorbell, door opening, footsteps, voice, body, motion, scent — hit the dog at once, the dog blows over threshold, and the rep is wasted. We isolate the variables. The visitor is the last thing we add.

1 | Stop pre-announcing visitors.

Whatever your current habit is — "we have a visitor!" "go see who's at the door!" — stop. You are priming the dog into an elevated state of arousal before the trigger ever fires. The dog doesn't need help getting amped up. From now on, the doorbell ringing is just a sound. You don't celebrate it. You don't narrate it. You just respond to it.

2 | Run the doorbell with no visitor.

Dog on place. You walk to the door. Ring the bell yourself. Walk back. If the dog held place — pay. If the dog broke — leash pressure back into place, no pay on the recovery, run a fresh rep. Repeat until the doorbell is just a sound the dog has heard a hundred times without anyone being there.

3 | Add the door opening, with no visitor.

Dog on place. You walk to the door. Open the door. Close the door. Walk back. Same rule — if place held, pay. If it broke, pressure back, no pay on the recovery. The door opening becomes a non-event.

4 | Add a knock, then footsteps, then a voice — all without anyone actually entering.

Have a household member stand on the porch. They knock. They say "hello." They wait outside. You go to the door, open it, talk briefly, close it. Dog stays on place throughout.

By the time you've worked through all of these one at a time, every variable except the actual visitor coming inside has been desensitized. The doorbell isn't a trigger anymore. The door isn't a trigger anymore. A voice isn't a trigger anymore. The only variable left is the person walking in.

I would isolate out all the other activators all the way down to just this person's voice. That way, when we add the person, that's the only thing left.

BRIAN FERGUSON

PHASE THREE

The calm-for-attention protocol — the dog earns the greeting.

This is the centerpiece of the chapter. It's the same protocol every dog goes through on their way out of my facility, on go-home day with their owners. The dog has to deliver a calm down on place before they get to greet anyone. The mechanic is elegant: *the visitor is both the reward and the punishment*.

The visitor's forward motion is the reward — they're getting closer to the dog the dog wants to greet. The visitor stopping or retreating is the punishment — the desired thing is going away. The dog regulates their own access to the reward through their own behavior. You don't have to do anything except hold the leash and stay quiet.

1 | Set up the room.

Dog tethered or held on leash on place. You stand beside the dog, holding the leash. The visitor — a family member or friend who has been briefed on the drill — stands across the room, facing the dog.

2 | The visitor starts walking. Slowly.

The pace I want is what I call "walking down the aisle in a wedding." Not normal walking pace. Deliberate, slow, ceremonial. The visitor walks toward the dog as long as the dog stays in a clean down on place.

3 | The instant the dog comes out of the down — the visitor stops moving.

Doesn't say anything. Doesn't react. Just stops. Frozen in place. The dog is now in the silence, with the visitor not closing the gap any further.

4 | Stay quiet. Don't cue the down again.

The drill works because the dog has to figure out the puzzle. If you cue the down, you're doing the cognitive work for them and they learn "wait for the human to tell me what to do" — which is the opposite of what we're installing. Hold the leash. Stay silent. Wait.

5 | If the dog breaks off place entirely, leash pressure back. No verbal feedback.

The leash is the only handler input. Pressure into a down on the place. Pressure releases when the dog is back in. Don't mark. Don't pay. Just reset the position and go back to waiting.

6 | When the dog returns to the down, the visitor resumes walking — slowly.

Same rule. Forward motion is the reward. The dog's clean down keeps the motion coming.

7 | As the visitor closes the gap, the dog will try to stretch their head out.

The visitor takes a step back. Now the dog can't reach. The dog learns: *head out, body forward, body up — the person retreats. Head back, body still, calm down — the person comes closer.*

8 | When the visitor can stand directly at the place bed and the dog is holding a calm down — the visitor reaches down and pets the dog under the chin.

No talking. Talking pumps the arousal back up. Just calm contact. Under the chin, not over the head — over the head is socially loaded for many dogs and can fire the arousal you're trying to keep settled.

9 | If the dog gets over-excited mid-petting, the visitor stops petting and steps back.

Reset. Wait for the dog to settle. Visitor approaches again. Same rules.

Most dogs work through this drill in five to ten minutes the first time. The longest I've ever had to run it was about an hour and a half — that was a working-line dog with very high arousal, very little impulse control, and a lifetime of being rewarded for every leap. Even that dog got it. The drill works on every dog, eventually, because the mechanic is fair and the dog is the one driving the outcome.

Subsequent reps drop dramatically. Fifteen minutes, then five, then under a minute. By the time you've run the drill with three different visitors, the dog has generalized — they understand "this is how I greet humans" as a category, not "this is the specific trick I learned with mom's friend Sarah."

COMMON WAYS THIS GOES WRONG

Talking during the calm-for-attention drill

The single most common failure. The handler narrates — "good boy, good down, stay there, no, stay" — every time the dog flickers. The drill collapses, because the dog is now waiting for verbal cues instead of figuring out the puzzle on their own. The verbal input also pumps the arousal back up, which makes the down harder to hold.

The fix: zero verbal input from the handler. The leash is the only correction, and only when the dog leaves the place entirely. The mark and pay are reserved for sustained clean reps. Otherwise, total silence. Let the dog work it out.

Releasing the dog to the visitor too early

The handler sees the dog hold the down for ten seconds, gets excited, and releases them to the visitor. The dog learns: *down for ten seconds = access to the human*. Now the dog can do exactly ten seconds of down. Try to make them hold thirty and the protocol falls apart, because the rule the dog learned was "ten seconds is enough."

The fix: don't release on a number. Release on the dog's mental state. We're paying calm, not duration. Wait until the dog has truly settled — body relaxed, eyes soft, no muscular tension in the down — and then release. Some sessions that's twenty seconds. Some sessions that's two minutes. The variable timing is what teaches the dog to hold for as long as the calm requires, not for a number they can game.

Skipping Phase Two

The handler gets impatient and brings a real visitor over before the door variables have been desensitized. Now the doorbell, the knock, the door opening, the voice, and the visitor all hit at once. The dog blows over threshold. Phase Three never even gets a chance to start because the dog is already at maximum arousal.

The fix: do Phase Two. Boring as it is, every variable has to be a non-event before the visitor walks in. The five-minute investment in running solo doorbells across a few sessions saves you weeks of failed reps later.

Inconsistency across the household

You're running the protocol; the kids let the dog jump because "he loves saying hi to me." The grandparent comes over once a week and lets the dog jump and feeds them treats from their hand. The neighbor on walks lets the dog jump because "he's fine, I love dogs." Every one of those people is undoing the protocol, in real time, while you're trying to install it.

The fix: get the household and the close circle aligned before you start, not after. Brief the people who come over often. The protocol is "this is how you'll greet our dog when you visit." If somebody won't follow it, they don't get to be the test visitor — they're a maintenance problem, not a training partner. For people you can't control — random dog-loving strangers on walks — manage the situation rather than trying to train through it. Move out of the way, pop the dog into a sit at distance, let the moment pass.

Treating the cot like a magic spot

Some handlers come away from this protocol thinking the place bed itself does the work. It doesn't. The work is the impulse-control wiring underneath. Take the dog to grandma's house with no place bed and the dog falls apart, because the cot was the only context the behavior was attached to.

The fix: once the protocol is solid at home, generalize. Run it in a friend's living room. Run it in the front yard. Run it at the brewery patio. The skill is "calm down, hold, earn access." The cot is a useful tool but not the actual lesson.

WHEN THIS IS BEYOND THE PROTOCOL — WHEN TO ESCALATE

ESCALATION TRIGGERS

Most jumping cases work cleanly through this protocol with the foundation in place. Bring these to a Q&A call or DM in the community before continuing.

- The dog has knocked down a child or an elderly visitor and the impact has caused real injury. Until the protocol is solid, manage these visits aggressively — dog crated or behind a baby gate during arrivals — rather than continuing to expose the high-risk individual.
- The dog is mouthing or nipping during the jump, with pressure that's leaving marks on people's hands or arms. That's no longer a manners problem; that's bite inhibition gap, and the protocol needs to be paired with additional work. Bring it to a call with video.
- The dog goes over threshold the moment the doorbell rings and won't come down even with management — pacing, panting, vocalizing for an hour after a visitor leaves. That's a deeper arousal-regulation issue and needs to be addressed alongside the greeting work. DM in the community.

THE 30 / 60 / 90 DAY DIAGNOSTIC CHECKPOINT

Day 30

Phase One is solid. The dog holds place with food on the floor, with high-value resources nearby, and with familiar household members walking through the room. Engagement is autonomous. You haven't yet started door-variable work or visitor work.

Day 60

Phase Two is clean. Every door variable — bell, knock, opening, footsteps, voice — is a non-event. You have run the calm-for-attention protocol with at least one cooperating family member, and the dog has worked through it. Real visitors are still managed (crate or baby gate) until the protocol generalizes further.

Day 90

You can have a visitor over and run the calm-for-attention protocol live. The dog earns access through calm, the visitor follows the rules, and the greeting ends with a settled dog under the chin. You've generalized to two or three different visitor types, and the dog is starting to default to the place when the doorbell rings without being told. The greeting has become a calm event in your house, not the explosion it used to be.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog only jumps on guests, not on me. Do I still need to do this?

A: *Yes. The behavior the visitor sees is the same behavior the dog runs whenever they're highly aroused — you're just used to it with you and not with them. Running the protocol fixes the underlying gap, not just the visible symptom.*

Q: What if my dog won't take food during Phase One? Too excited.

A: *Two issues. One, food drive isn't fully built yet — back up to the 30-Day Quick Start Guide. Two, you may be working over the dog's threshold for the environment. Move to a quieter setting and try again. Quiet kitchen, no household members moving around, no other dogs. Win there first.*

Q: My dog has a cot but won't stay on it. Where do I start?

A: *Place isn't actually built yet. Don't try to layer the greeting protocol on top — go work the place build in the 30-Day Quick Start Guide first. A real place command — held under distraction, with cued release — is the prerequisite that makes the rest of this chapter run.*

Q: Can I just put the dog in the crate when guests come?

A: *As management, yes — and that's a perfectly reasonable interim move while you build the protocol. Crate during arrivals, then bring the dog out on leash for the calm-for-attention rep once the visitor has settled in. That's how I have many of my members run it for the first month or two.*

Q: My dog jumps on me when I come home from work. Same protocol?

A: *Same principle, slightly different application. Don't engage with the dog when you walk in. Cue them to place. Wait for calm. Then greet — under the chin, not over the head, no high-pitched voice. You are the visitor in this version of the drill. Run it the same way.*

Q: How do I handle dog-loving strangers on walks who let my dog jump?

A: *You don't train through it; you manage around it. Polite version: "Thanks, we're working on greetings — could you let him sit first?" Most people will adjust. People who won't adjust, you don't let them greet your dog. Move on, pop the dog into heel, walk past. Random uncoached greetings will undo your protocol.*

WORKING THIS CHAPTER

If your foundation isn't yet built: markers loaded, food drive built, place command solid. Without those, the protocol won't land. The 30-Day Quick Start Guide that came with this manual installs all of them. Run it first.

The hardest part of this chapter is the silence. The calm-for-attention drill works because the dog has to figure it out. The handler who narrates kills the protocol, every time. Practice staying quiet. Practice trusting the leash. Practice trusting the dog's brain to do the work.

Brief your visitors. Send them the rules before they come over: walk slow, freeze if the dog breaks, no eye contact, no high-pitched voice, pet under the chin only. A two-minute text exchange before they arrive is the difference between a clean rep and a wasted one.

If you're getting stuck: bring video to the next live Q&A call inside the Real Dog Rehab community. Greeting drills are easy to misread on your own — handler position, leash tension, visitor pace are all things that benefit from a second pair of eyes.

CHAPTER THREE

3

Recall Failure

Your dog will come when called — sometimes. When the squirrel runs, when the door opens at the wrong moment, when something more interesting than you appears, the recall is gone. This is the most consequential gap in your training, and it's also the most fixable.

THE BEHAVIOR, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

You call the dog. The dog looks at you, considers, decides whatever else they're doing is more interesting, and continues. Sometimes you get them eventually — after multiple calls, escalating tone, finally sounding mad. Sometimes you don't. Sometimes a deer breaks across the yard or the front door blows open and the dog is gone, ignoring every "come" you scream after them, and you spend the next forty minutes driving the neighborhood in the dark with the leash in your hand.

I want to be direct about why this chapter matters more than most owners think it does.

Recall is the number-one lifesaving command we put on a dog.

BRIAN FERGUSON

This isn't melodrama. The dog who blows the recall when a car is coming, when the front gate is open, when a coyote crosses the trail, when a child is in the road — that dog can die. I've seen it. So I do not treat recall the way most pet trainers treat recall. I build it like the foundation of the house, because in the moments that matter most, it's the only thing standing between your dog and a permanent loss.

This chapter is about how to actually build it — and the rules that have to surround it for the rest of your dog's life.

WHAT'S ACTUALLY HAPPENING

Why your dog is choosing not to come

Run the diagnostic question. *What advantage is the dog creating, or what discomfort is the dog avoiding, by not coming when called?*

Most recall failures break down into one of two stories.

Story one: whatever's keeping the dog away is paying better than coming back to you.

The dog is sniffing something interesting, exploring a new environment, watching a squirrel, playing with another dog. That activity is firing dopamine, exploration chemistry, prey-drive chemistry, social-bonding chemistry — depending on what's happening. Coming back to the handler offers the dog... what, exactly? A pat on the head and a treat from your pocket. The dog is doing the math, and the math says the current activity is worth more than what's being

offered for the recall. The dog isn't being defiant. The dog is making a rational economic decision about which behavior pays better, and you're losing.

Story two: coming back to the handler has, somewhere along the way, started predicting something the dog files in the discomfort column. The classic version: every time the dog comes back, the leash goes on, and the off-leash time ends. The dog has now been classically conditioned — recall predicts loss of freedom. So when the dog hears "come," the discomfort prediction fires, the dog hesitates, the dog drifts, the dog blows you off. You're not just competing with the squirrel. You're competing with the leash that's about to clip on.

Or the worse version of story two: the dog comes back, you're frustrated by how long it took, and you correct them — verbally, with a sharp tone, sometimes physically. The dog has learned: *coming back to dad sometimes pays in scolding*. Now coming back is a coin flip the dog doesn't want to make.

BRIAN-ISM

What's the dog going to do? They're going to go: I hear you calling me, but also I really want \$100.

The framing I want you to hold here is this: recall is not a lesson the dog learns once. Recall is a competing-motivators problem the dog solves every single time. Every recall is the dog choosing between you and the rest of the environment. Your job is to make sure the dog's math, every time, lands on coming back.

The two non-negotiable rules of recall

Before we touch any drill, I want to put two rules on the table that govern every recall you will ever issue for the rest of your dog's life. Owners who don't follow these rules cannot have a reliable recall. There is no protocol that gets around these rules. They are the protocol.

Rule one: Every recall is paid more than it's not paid. The dog needs to be reinforced for coming back significantly more often than they're not. Not always — variable reward is what keeps the recall sharp — but reliably enough that the dog is always anticipating something good when they hear the cue. The day you decide "the dog should know the recall by now, I don't have to pay for it anymore" is the day the recall starts dying. We never phase food out. Not on recall, not on anything.

Rule two: You never issue a recall you cannot enforce. If the dog is off-leash with no long line, no E-collar, and no fence, and you don't know whether the recall is going to fire — *do not*

say *the word*. Every time you call the dog and they choose not to come, the dog has just gotten a successful rep of blowing you off. The behavior of ignoring you grew in strength. Behavior practiced grows. The recall got weaker, not stronger. So either you have a way to enforce it — the long line, the E-collar after foundation, the closed yard — or you don't say the word.

BRIAN-ISM

I don't ever issue a command I can't follow through on. If I don't have a leash on the dog or an E-collar on the dog, I don't issue a recall.

Most owners I work with have been issuing weak recalls for years. The dog has logged hundreds of reps of "I heard 'come' and ignored it and nothing happened." Every one of those reps trained the dog to ignore the cue. If your dog is in this category — and most are — the protocol below will work, but you need to understand that we may need to *change the cue word* partway through, because the old word has been so heavily classically conditioned to "I don't have to come" that it would take longer to rebuild than to start fresh with a clean word.

WHAT YOU MUST HAVE IN PLACE BEFORE THIS PROTOCOL CAN LAND

► BEFORE YOU RUN THIS PROTOCOL

Recall sits on a specific foundation. The protocol assumes the basics are clean. If any of these aren't in place, the recall build will not stick, and the work to do first is the foundation.

- **Loaded markers.** The dog turns to you on the marker word and expects food. Reliably.
- **Real food drive — and food perceived by the dog as a finite resource.** This one matters more here than in any other chapter. If the dog is over-satiated, recall is going to be hard to build because there's no chemistry behind the paycheck. We feed once a day, ten minutes to eat, food disappears for twenty-four hours if they don't take it. By the time the recall protocol starts, the dog should be working hard for a single piece of kibble.
- **Engagement built.** The dog autonomously orients to you in increasingly distracting environments. They check in with you because checking in pays.
- **A long line.** Twenty feet, thirty feet, fifty feet — depending on your training environment.

Light, drag-along, cotton or biothane. Not a flexi-leash. Not a traffic leash. A long line is a non-optional piece of equipment for this work.

If those pieces aren't all in place, run the 30-Day Quick Start Guide first. The food drive build, the marker work, the engagement-as-gate drills — all of it is sequenced there. Build the foundation, then come back. The recall protocol below is precisely calibrated to land on top of those foundations, and it will not land without them.

THE TWO PILLARS APPLIED TO RECALL

Pillar One is the recall behavior itself, built and paid heavily off-distraction first, then bulletproofed across the environmental ladder. The dog gets hundreds of reps of "I heard the cue, I came back, the paycheck was overwhelming" before we ever introduce a competing motivator they have to choose against.

Pillar Two is the rewiring of what the recall cue *predicts* for the dog. Right now, in many cases, the cue predicts boredom, leash, end-of-fun. We're going to change that prediction. The cue is going to predict *jackpots* — sometimes a piece of kibble, sometimes nothing visible, sometimes a handful of hamburger meat the dog has never tasted before. The cue becomes a lottery ticket. The dog's brain is going to come to associate the recall word with the kind of anticipation that makes them break off whatever they're doing and come tearing back, because *they don't know what's about to happen but they know it might be incredible*.

THE PROTOCOL

PHASE ONE

Pick the right word. Build the foundation indoors.

1 | Decide whether you need a new word.

Be honest with yourself. How many times in the past year has your dog heard "come" or "here" and not come? If the answer is "a lot," the word is poisoned. The dog has learned that the word is optional. You will rebuild faster on a clean word than you will trying to rehabilitate a poisoned one.

Pick a word the dog has not heard in this context before. "Front." "Hier." "Yo."

Whatever you want. It doesn't matter what the word is — it matters that the dog has no prior history with it. From this point forward, that's the word. The old word is retired.

2 | Charge the new word in the kitchen.

Dog two feet away. You say the word. Mark, pay. Dog one step away. You say the word. Mark, pay. Across the kitchen. You say the word. Dog comes, mark, pay heavy. The dog is learning that the word predicts food, every time, in a low-distraction environment.

Run dozens of these reps across multiple short sessions. The word should become a Pavlovian trigger — the dog hears it, the dog's head whips around, the dog moves toward you, expecting food.

3 | Add distance, still indoors.

Dog at the other end of the hallway. Word. They come. Mark, pay. Dog upstairs. Word. They come down. Mark, pay *big* when they come from a distance — the longer the run, the bigger the paycheck. We are teaching the dog that *far recalls pay better than close recalls*.

4 | Take it to the backyard, on the long line.

Long line clipped to the dog's collar. Drop the line on the ground. Let the dog wander, sniff, do what dogs do in a yard. Wait for a moment when the dog is paying attention to something other than you. Word.

If the dog turns and comes — mark, pay heavy. If the dog hesitates or ignores — pick up the long line and gently reel them in. As they're coming, your tone stays warm, encouraging. When they reach you — mark, pay, and pay *well*. Even if you had to reel them in. The dog needs to know that arriving at you is the paycheck, every time.

Critical detail: do not say the word twice. You said it once. If the dog doesn't respond, you reel them in. You don't beg, you don't plead, you don't repeat. The cue gets said one time. Multiple repetitions teach the dog that the first one is optional and only the third one matters.

BRIAN-ISM

Brian does not beg.

✓ PHASE ONE CHECKPOINT

The dog responds to the new recall word reliably indoors and in the yard on a long line. They come from any distance in those environments. They orient to the word the moment they hear it. The recall is being paid every time, with variable amounts — sometimes one piece of kibble, sometimes a handful, sometimes the entire bowl.

PHASE TWO

Add the lottery. Add the competing motivators.

1 | Introduce the hamburger jackpot.

Once or twice a week, when you run a recall, you have a small handful of cooked hamburger meat in your pocket. Just a small piece. The dog comes back. You don't mark with anything special. You just put that piece of meat in their mouth.

The first time you do this, the dog is going to register that you have something different. Their brain is going to log: *oh. The recall sometimes produces meat.* That single moment changes their relationship to the word forever. Every subsequent recall now carries the possibility — never the guarantee — of a jackpot. The dog's anticipation builds. The recall sharpens.

Don't do it every time. The whole mechanism depends on unpredictability. Some recalls pay one piece of kibble. Some pay nothing visible — the dog comes back, you say "good," nothing else. Some pay the hamburger jackpot. Some pay the entire bowl of food on the ground in a pile. The dog never knows. The brain stays primed.

2 | Run the protocol in environments with mild competing motivators.

Long line still on. Take the dog to a park at off-peak hours. Let them sniff. Wait until they're engaged with something — a particular smell, an interesting object, a distant person. Word.

Same rules. If they come, pay heavy. If they don't, reel them in calmly. No second cue. As they arrive, treat their arrival like the best news of the day. Sometimes it's a kibble. Sometimes it's the meat.

3 | **Climb the competing-motivator ladder.**

Empty park → park with one or two distant dogs → park with people walking by → park with another dog at moderate distance → trail with wildlife scent. Each rung is a separate proofing pass. Each rung gets cleaned up before the next.

If the dog blows a recall at any rung, that rung is too hard for the current foundation. Back up. Do not just keep trying. Every blown recall is a rep of "I heard the word and didn't come." We are not paying for those reps with our most important command.

4 | **Build the no-second-call discipline.**

Throughout this entire phase, watch your own behavior. Are you saying the word twice? Three times? Are you adding the dog's name in front of it ten times because they're not responding? If you are, you're undoing the protocol. The cue gets said once. Period. If the dog doesn't respond, you reel them in. If you find yourself wanting to repeat the word, that's a sign you weren't ready to issue the recall in the first place — the variable was too hard, the foundation wasn't there for that environment, the long line wasn't on. The discipline is yours, not the dog's.

PHASE THREE

Off-leash reliability — and what off-leash actually means.

Honest moment. Off-leash reliability is not "the dog comes back ninety percent of the time." Off-leash reliability is "the dog comes back reliably enough that I would bet their life on it" — because that's what off-leash actually is. Every time you take the leash off in an unfenced environment, you are betting your dog's life on the recall.

For most pet dogs, real off-leash reliability is a multi-year project. It involves layering an E-collar onto the foundation you've built — not as a punishment tool, but as a motivational gas pedal that lets the recall cue still be enforceable at one hundred yards in unpredictable environments. That's the work the E-Collar as a Gas Pedal track in the community covers in depth. It's where this chapter graduates to.

For the purposes of this chapter, the bar is this: you have a recall that works reliably on a long line, across competing motivators, in real-world environments. The dog responds to the cue the first time. You're paying with the lottery system. You're following the no-second-call rule. You have a dog whose recall you can trust on a thirty-foot line. That is a foundation any further reliability work can build on.

COMMON WAYS THIS GOES WRONG

Repeating the cue

Single biggest failure mode in recall work. The owner says "come," the dog doesn't come, the owner says "come... come... come on... come!" By the third repetition, the dog has been trained that "come" said once means "ignore me, I'll say it again." Now the cue requires three reps before it fires. Add a high-arousal moment and even three doesn't work.

The fix: the cue is said once. If the dog doesn't respond, you reel in. You do not say the word again. The next time the cue is said, the dog needs to be in a setup where they are likely to respond — closer in, less distraction, or with the long line ready to enforce. Discipline yourself out of the repetition habit and the cue gets sharper fast.

Calling the dog only to end the fun

Owner takes the dog to the park, dog has a great time, owner calls the dog, leash goes on, they go home. After a few weeks of this, the dog has classically conditioned: *recall = end of fun*. The dog starts blowing the recall at the park because the recall predicts loss.

The fix: most of your recalls — even at the park — should end with the dog being released back into the environment, not leashed up and removed. Recall the dog, mark, pay, then say your release word. The dog goes back to playing. Run the recall five or six times during a session, with most of them ending in a release back to fun. Only one out of every several recalls ends the session. Now the recall predicts a paycheck plus continued fun, not removal.

Punishing the recall

Dog runs off, owner is scared and angry, dog finally comes back, owner scolds. Dog has now learned: *coming back to dad pays in scolding*. The next recall is harder, because the dog's prediction has shifted toward discomfort.

The fix: when the dog finally comes back, no matter how long it took, no matter how scared you were, no matter how mad you are — the dog gets paid. Period. You can be furious internally. You can resolve to never put yourself in that situation again. But the dog who arrives at you gets a paycheck, every time, because the alternative is that the next recall is even harder. Punish the moment after they come back and you've made the next failure more likely.

Issuing the recall when you can't enforce it

The dog is loose in an unfenced area, no long line, no E-collar, dog is interested in a deer across the yard. Owner panics and yells "come!" The dog ignores. Now the cue has been weakened. The owner just trained the dog that the cue is optional in high-arousal moments — which are exactly the moments the cue needs to work.

The fix: in those moments, you don't issue the recall. You go get the dog. You walk over, calm, and put a hand on their collar. Save the cue for moments you can enforce. Yes, this is harder than yelling. Yes, you'll feel like an idiot walking across the yard while the dog ignores you. Do it anyway. The cue you protect is the cue that works when it counts.

Pulling the long line off too early

The dog has run six clean recalls on the long line in the yard. The owner thinks the dog is ready and drops the line. Next session, no long line. Dog blows the recall on the seventh rep. Now the dog has logged a rep of "I ignored the cue and got away with it" — and the foundation just took a hit.

The fix: the long line stays on for far longer than your gut tells you it needs to. Months, not weeks. Every environment is a separate generalization step, and each new environment requires the long line. The pattern is: long line on, build clean reps, drag the line for a while as a transition, then off — but only in environments where you've banked many clean reps and you're confident the dog's recall is automatic. Off-leash reliability is the destination. The long line is the vehicle.

WHEN THIS IS BEYOND THE PROTOCOL — WHEN TO ESCALATE

ESCALATION TRIGGERS

Most recall failures work cleanly through the protocol above with the foundation in place and the discipline of the two non-negotiable rules. A few situations need additional support before continuing.

- The dog has a history of running into traffic or has been hit by a car previously. Until the recall is bulletproof, off-leash exposure in unfenced areas is not a risk worth running. Stay on the long line in fenced or controlled environments only.
- The dog has a serious prey-drive issue and has chased livestock, wildlife, or other dogs in a sustained, focused way. Recall on top of high prey drive is a multi-year build, and it almost always benefits from a layered E-collar foundation. The E-Collar as a Gas Pedal track in the community is the path. DM in the community before running unsupervised off-leash.
- The dog has been off-leash for years already and you're trying to repair a broken recall after multiple lost-dog incidents. The repair is real but slow. Bring video to a Q&A call to get a custom plan.

THE 30 / 60 / 90 DAY DIAGNOSTIC CHECKPOINT

Day 30

Phase One is solid. The dog responds to the new recall word reliably indoors and in the yard on a long line. They come from any distance in those environments. The lottery system is in place — kibble, jackpots, occasional nothing. Variable rewards, never zero rewards.

Day 60

Phase Two is clean. The recall holds across moderate competing motivators on the long line — a quiet park, a trail with mild distractions, the front yard with people walking by. You are not repeating the cue. You are reeling in calmly when needed. The hamburger jackpot has fired several times and the dog is visibly more eager when they hear the cue.

Day 90

The recall is reliable on the long line in environments with real competing motivators — other dogs at moderate distance, wildlife scent, busier public spaces. The dog responds the first time, every time. You are ready to begin the off-leash transition work — which is its own multi-month project, and where the E-Collar track inside the community picks up.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog comes when called at home. Why do I need to do this?

A: *Because "comes when called at home" is not the same skill as "comes when called when something interesting is happening." Most owners overestimate their dog's recall because they've only ever tested it under low-distraction conditions. The protocol exists to build the recall that works when it actually matters.*

Q: Can I just use the E-collar?

A: *Not as a shortcut. The E-collar is a powerful tool but it's a layer that goes on top of a clean foundation, not a substitute for one. The E-Collar as a Gas Pedal track in the community is built specifically as the off-leash extension of the work in this chapter. Run this chapter first. Then layer the collar on a real foundation.*

Q: What if my dog won't take food during recall practice?

A: *Two issues stacked. One, food drive isn't where it needs to be — they're either over-satiated or food isn't yet perceived as a finite resource. Run the food drive protocol from the 30-Day Quick Start Guide. Two, you may be working over the dog's threshold for the environment. Move to a quieter setting and rebuild from there.*

Q: My dog comes ninety percent of the time. Is that good enough?

A: *For pet life, off-leash, in an unfenced area? No. The ten percent the dog blows is going to be the high-arousal moment — squirrel, deer, open gate, bicycle. That's the moment the recall has to work. Ninety percent reliable is the same as not having the recall when it matters. Keep building.*

Q: When do I phase out the food rewards?

A: *Never. We never phase food out — we move from continuous reward to variable reward, but we don't go to zero. The day you decide the dog "should know the recall by now" and stop paying, the recall starts dying. Variable, not phased.*

Q: My dog has selective hearing — comes for the kids but not for me. What gives?

A: *The kids have inadvertently been paying better. They greet the dog with a more exciting voice, more contact, more chemistry release. You've been the boring recall — paid in routine kibble and a flat "good." Increase the chemistry your recall produces. Match the kids' energy. Add the lottery. Pay heavy.*

Q: How long should the long line stay on?

A: *Months, not weeks. The transition off the long line happens after many clean reps in many environments. Most owners pull the long line off too early because they want to "see if the dog will do it without it." Don't test the foundation by removing it. Build the foundation so deep that by the time the long line comes off, the recall fires automatically.*

WORKING THIS CHAPTER

If your foundation isn't yet built: food drive built and food perceived as finite, markers loaded, engagement-as-gate solid. The 30-Day Quick Start Guide installs all of those. Without them, recall work won't take.

The two rules are everything. Pay every recall — variably, generously, sometimes with the lottery. Never issue a recall you cannot enforce. Print those two rules out and put them on the fridge if you have to. They govern every recall you will issue for the rest of your dog's life.

For real off-leash work: the E-Collar as a Gas Pedal track inside the community is where this chapter graduates to. The collar is not a punishment tool in that protocol — it's a motivational layer that makes the recall enforceable at distance. Run this chapter first. Build the foundation. Then layer the collar on top.

If something's getting stuck: bring video to the next live Q&A call. Recall mechanics — your tone, your timing, your reel-in technique, your release back to fun — are easy to misread on yourself. A second pair of eyes will calibrate fast.

CHAPTER FOUR

4

Nuisance Barking

The doorbell, the fence, the crows, the mailman, the wind. Some dogs find a hundred reasons to bark every day, and none of them require it. Here's the diagnostic, the protocol, and the rule that has to govern barking for the rest of your dog's life.

THE BEHAVIOR, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

It comes in different flavors. Some dogs lose their minds at the doorbell. Some bark at every person walking past the fence. Some sit at the back window and bark at squirrels for three hours a day. Some bark at you for attention, for food, for a walk, for the toy, for the door to open. Some go nuclear at every car that pulls into the driveway, including yours.

Whatever the flavor, the experience is the same: the household is loud. The neighbors have started giving you looks. You've tried yelling at the dog to stop, which has the opposite of the intended effect. You've tried treats, you've tried distraction, you've tried tiring the dog out. Some of it works for a day or two. None of it has actually fixed it.

The reason none of it has fixed it is that you've been treating barking as one problem when it's actually three or four different problems wearing the same costume. We're going to diagnose first. Then we'll match the protocol to the diagnosis.

WHAT'S ACTUALLY HAPPENING

Run the diagnostic question first

Before you touch the protocol, sit with this. *What advantage is the dog creating, or what discomfort is the dog avoiding, by barking?*

Different barks answer that question differently, and the answer determines what you do.

Demand barking — the dog who barks at you for food, for a walk, for the door, for attention — is creating an advantage. The bark works. They've barked, you've responded, the bark has paid. Behavior up. Advantage column.

Door and visitor barking — the dog who detonates at the doorbell — is usually a mix. There's a discharge of arousal in the bark itself (advantage), and there's a fear or territorial response that's trying to drive the perceived threat away (avoiding discomfort). When the visitor turns out not to be a threat and the dog gets to greet them, the dog also gets paid in social-bonding chemistry — third reinforcer stacked. Door barking gets really durable really fast for that reason.

Fence and yard barking — the dog who barks at every passerby through the fence — is usually pure avoiding-discomfort, with a side of self-reinforcing predator drive. The dog perceives a thing on the other side of the fence. The dog barks. The thing always moves on,

because that's what people walking by do. The dog's brain logs: *I barked, the threat went away, barking works*. Every passerby is a paid rep. Behavior grows.

Crow and squirrel barking — the dog at the back fence going nuts at wildlife — is genetics-meets-self-reinforcement. The prey-drive chemistry fires every time the dog spots something to chase. The dog can't catch the crow, but the chase response is its own reward. Some breeds — alert breeds, working breeds, herders — go from "interested in the bird" to "obsessive about the bird" in days, not weeks.

BRIAN-ISM

Genetics take over when leadership isn't present.

That line is the deepest principle in this chapter. The dog in the yard, alone, with no handler present, defaults to whatever their genetics tell them to do. For working and alert breeds, that means alarm-bark at anything that moves. For prey-drive breeds, it means engage with anything that runs. Leadership doesn't follow the dog into the yard when you're not standing there. So the protocol either has to be one you can run from a distance, or one that operates without you present.

The "always or never" rule

This is the rule that governs barking for the rest of your dog's life. It's a rule about clarity, and it's the principle most owners get wrong.

Dogs cannot live in the gray area. They cannot understand "barking is fine sometimes and not fine other times." Barking-at-the-doorbell-but-not-at-the-fence is incoherent to a dog — to the dog, both are the same behavior, the same arousal, the same response. If you allow it in one context and forbid it in another, the dog doesn't learn the rule. They just learn that the rule sometimes applies and sometimes doesn't, which is fundamentally unfair and produces a stressed, conflicted dog who's always uncertain about what's allowed.

Your dog lives in the land of always and never. Sometimes and maybe stresses them out.

BRIAN FERGUSON

So before you run any protocol, decide your rule. Pick one. Either:

Option A: My dog is allowed to alarm-bark. Doorbell, person at the gate, real disturbance — yes, the dog can announce. Then we settle on cue. This works fine for healthy dogs in stable mental states, but it requires you to be able to interrupt and settle reliably, which means foundation work has to be in place.

Option B: My dog does not bark for nuisance reasons. Period. No fence barking, no demand barking, no crow barking. The few times you might want them to alert — there are bigger issues than your dog's vocal cords doing the alerting, and we'll discuss that in a minute. Most clinical cases I see end up here.

What you cannot do is mix them. You cannot have "barking at the fence is fine but barking at the door is not" or "barking at strangers is great but barking at family members is bad." Pick a rule. Apply it consistently. The dog will learn it.

A note on the protection-dog fantasy

I want to say something here that's going to land hard for some of you. Many owners want to keep some barking around because they think the dog is "protection" — that a barking dog will deter break-ins or actual threats. Almost always, the dog they're describing is not a protection dog. They're a fearful, reactive pet who alarms at noises.

A real protection dog is a years-long build with a foundation most pet dogs never get and most owners can't manage. Your nervous, fearful pet is not protection. They're a noise machine. A meth-head looking to grab your TV will be deterred by the noise. An actual person who means you harm is not going to be stopped by the dog — that person will simply hurt or kill the dog and proceed. I do not crate my dogs at night because I want the bark to scare off intruders. I crate my dogs at night to keep them safe and I run a real home alarm system for the security function.

If you want the dog to do "alarm" duty, that's fine — but it's a real and limited function, not a substitute for actual home security. And if your dog's "alarm" barking is rooted in fear rather than confident announcing, all you're keeping around is rehearsal of the underlying fear. The fearful, reactive bark gets stronger every time it gets practiced. The dog gets more anxious, not less. You're not preserving a useful function. You're letting an unhealthy state grow.

WHAT YOU MUST HAVE IN PLACE BEFORE THIS PROTOCOL CAN LAND

► BEFORE YOU RUN THIS PROTOCOL

The barking protocols vary by type, but every one of them assumes the basic foundation is in place. Without these, no anti-barking work will hold.

- **Markers loaded, food drive built.** Every protocol below uses the marker and food at some point.
- **A clean place command.** The wait-out-the-bark protocol depends on the dog holding place. The greeting and door variants depend on it too.
- **Engagement-as-gate established.** The dog has practiced the "look at handler instead of fixating on the resource" pattern from the impulse-control work.
- **For yard barking specifically: a fenced yard the dog can be in alone.** This is the case where the fix involves automation, not handler-presence training, so the environment matters.

If those foundations aren't in place, the 30-Day Quick Start Guide that came with this manual installs them. Run it first. Then come back to this chapter with a real foundation underneath. The protocols below assume the dog has the underlying skills.

THE TWO PILLARS APPLIED TO BARKING

Pillar One is the incompatible behavior — usually a calm down on place — bulletproofed off-trigger. The dog cannot be barking and also doing a clean down on a cot. We build the down to functional level before the trigger ever enters the picture.

Pillar Two is the rewiring of what the trigger means to the dog. The doorbell predicts place, not detonation. The visitor approaching the gate predicts paychecks for calm, not threat-driving-away. The crow on the fence predicts the bark collar ramping, not free predator-drive engagement. We're changing what the dog's nervous system fires when the trigger appears, and the new prediction is calm-pays.

THE PROTOCOL

The protocol breaks into three tracks, depending on which type of barking you're dealing with. Run the track that matches your dog's pattern. Most dogs need only one. Some dogs need two — for example, a dog who barks at the door and barks at the fence will need both Track A and Track C.

TRACK A

Door and visitor barking — the wait-out protocol.

This is the protocol for the dog who detonates at the doorbell, at visitors arriving at the gate, at the front door opening. You may recognize the structure from Chapter 2 — the door variables get isolated, the dog earns the greeting, the visitor's behavior reinforces calm. The wait-out version is the deeper drill for dogs whose barking has become particularly entrenched.

1 | Set up the back-tied place protocol.

Dog on place, on a leash, attached to a fixed point so they cannot break the place no matter what. The leash should be a slip lead or, for stronger dogs, a prong with a safety tie to a flat collar — never a harness. Harnesses let the dog throw their full body weight into the bark indefinitely. We want the equipment to introduce a small amount of physical friction the moment the dog tries to leave place.

2 | Position the trigger.

A volunteer — friend, family member, neighbor who has been briefed — stands at the gate or just outside the front door. They don't approach. They don't engage. They just stand there.

3 | The dog will bark. You will do nothing.

No verbal correction. No leash correction. No engagement at all. The handler stays mostly silent. The only handler input is: if the dog leaves the place entirely, you reset them back. That's it.

The dog is going to bark for a long time the first session. Ten minutes. Twenty. Thirty. Sometimes longer. They're going to spin, slobber, throw their voice, cycle through every variation of "this should be working." It isn't going to be working. The volunteer doesn't move. The handler doesn't react. Nothing the dog tries produces an outcome.

4 | Wait for the somatic shift.

Eventually — and this can take a while the first time — the dog runs out. The bark slows. The body settles. The dog drops into a down, sometimes with an audible sigh. The eyes come back to the handler. *That* is the moment. The instant the dog stops barking *and* mentally settles, mark and pay.

Critically, the volunteer at the gate *also* walks away at that moment. The dog now sees: *calm produced two things — a paycheck from dad, and the trigger going away.* Both reinforcers stack on the calm.

5 | End the session.

Don't push for a second rep. Don't try to reset and run it again immediately. The dog has just had a major learning moment. End there. Run another session later in the day or the next day.

6 | Watch the curve.

Session one: the bark might run thirty to forty-five minutes before the dog settles.

Session two: usually five to ten minutes. Session three: thirty seconds, or sometimes the dog just looks at the handler instead of barking at all. The curve is sharp because the dog is making a real cognitive shift. Once the lesson lands, the lesson lands.

It's a powerful learning tool when they realize they're wasting their energy and it's not getting them anything. Once they discover what does work — calm gets the paycheck and the visitor goes away — that changes the metric for them.

BRIAN FERGUSON

Once the wait-out has worked across several sessions, you can lift the back-tie and run the same protocol on a regular leash held by the handler. Eventually you can run it with the dog on place and not tethered. The pattern transfers because the dog has internalized the rule, not just complied with the equipment.

TRACK B

Demand barking — the hard part is the human discipline.

The dog who barks at you for food, for a walk, for the door, for attention, for a toy. This is the easiest pattern to fix and the hardest pattern to fix at the same time — easy because the protocol is mechanically simple, hard because every member of your household has to follow it perfectly or the dog re-runs the cycle.

1 | Identify what the bark is asking for.

Is the dog barking at you for food? At the door for outside? At the toy box for play? At the couch for permission to come up? Make a list. The protocol applies to each one separately.

2 | **For each thing the dog barks for: that thing now never comes when the dog is barking.**

The bowl does not get filled while the dog is barking at the bowl. The door does not open while the dog is barking at the door. Attention does not come while the dog is barking for attention. Period. Always or never. The dog has to learn that *barking does not produce the resource*.

The corollary: when the dog is calm and quiet, you can offer the resource. The bowl gets filled. The door opens. The attention happens. *Quiet produces the thing. Bark does not.*

3 | **When the dog barks at you, you become a wall.**

No engagement. No talking. No looking at them. Don't even make eye contact. You are no longer a responsive presence — you are inert. The dog has to figure out that the bark is no longer connected to anything happening.

Some dogs get this fast. Some dogs escalate first — they bark louder, they bark longer, they get up in your face about it. That's an extinction burst. Behavior goes up briefly before it goes down. Hold the line. Do not respond. Eventually the bark drops. The instant there's a beat of silence — mark, pay, and offer the thing they were asking for, if it's appropriate.

4 | **The household rule: nobody breaks.**

This is the hardest part. Every member of the household has to follow the protocol. The kid who slips the dog a treat to make the barking stop, the partner who lets the dog out because "she's just going to keep barking otherwise," the grandparent who picks the dog up and coos at her — every one of those interactions is a rep that the bark works. The protocol fails if the household isn't aligned.

Have a family meeting. Explain the rule. Get everybody onboard. If somebody won't follow it, the protocol won't work and that's just the truth. Get aligned, then start.

TRACK C

Yard, fence, and crow barking — the case for automation.

This is the track most owners hate to hear about. For yard barking specifically, the most reliable, most humane fix I have for most dogs is a good bark collar — not because correction is the only tool, but because the dog is in the yard alone, the handler isn't there to interrupt, and

genetics are running the show. Handler-driven training cannot fix a behavior that happens when no handler is present.

Before you skip past this section because the words "bark collar" trigger you, understand what the right tool is and how it works. Most owners have only ever encountered bad bark collars — cheap units that hammer the dog at a high level on the first bark, produce a stim-squeal-stim feedback loop, and traumatize the dog without solving anything. That is not the tool I'm describing.

1 | **Get a real bark collar with learning mode.**

The product I recommend is the Barkless Pro from E-Collar Technologies. Two features matter. **One:** it detects vibration in the dog's vocal cords matched to sound, which means in a multi-dog household, one dog's bark cannot trigger another dog's collar. Critical safety feature. **Two:** it runs a learning mode that starts every correction session at level one and ramps gradually — first bark, level one. Second bark within five seconds, level two. Quiet for thirty seconds, the collar resets back to one. The dog gets to learn cause-and-effect at the lowest possible level for them.

2 | **Start in learning mode. Watch the curve.**

Run learning mode for the first several sessions in the yard. Observe the dog. Most dogs reach a personal threshold — for many pets it's around level four; for working breeds it's frequently a seven. The dog will bark up the levels until they hit their threshold, and at that level they stop. That number is your dog's level.

3 | **Switch to fixed-level mode at the dog's threshold.**

Once you know the level, set the collar to it. Now the first bark gets the level the dog actually responds to, instead of the dog cycling through six warning levels every time. Fewer total stimulations, faster response, cleaner outcome. This is what a humane correction looks like — the lowest level that produces lasting change, applied consistently.

4 | **Always or never. The collar is on every yard trip.**

This is non-negotiable. The collar comes on the moment the dog goes outside, every time, no exceptions. Half-implementation — sometimes on, sometimes not — is worse than not using the collar at all, because the dog can't learn the rule. If you're not willing to put the collar on every single time, don't use it. Run a different protocol or accept the barking.

5 | The collar is for the bark itself, not for predator drive.

Note that for true high-prey dogs — dogs that don't just bark at the squirrel but stalk and chase — the bark collar is treating a symptom. The deeper work is the impulse-control build from the foundation phase, which you should pair with the collar. The collar interrupts the bark in real time. The impulse-control work changes the underlying drive over months. Both at once.

✓ TRACK CHECKPOINTS

Track A: the dog can be back-tied on place with a visitor at the gate, barks for thirty seconds or less, settles into a calm down, gets paid and the visitor walks away. Three clean sessions in a row. Then progress to non-tethered place, then real visitors.

Track B: the dog has stopped barking at you for resources. The household has held the line. When the dog wants something, they offer calm — sit, place, eye contact — instead of barking, and the calm gets paid.

Track C: the bark collar is on every yard trip. The dog barks once, hits their threshold, settles. Frequency drops dramatically over the first week. By week two, most dogs barely activate the collar at all because they've reassigned the yard from "bark zone" to "settled zone."

COMMON WAYS THIS GOES WRONG

Mixing the always-or-never rule

The owner allows alarm barking at the door but corrects fence barking. The dog barks at both contexts because both feel the same internally. The owner gets frustrated that the rule "isn't sticking." The rule isn't sticking because there isn't a rule — there's a contradiction, and the dog can't parse contradictions.

The fix: pick a rule and apply it consistently. The way most of my members end up running it is "no bark unless cued." If the dog wants to alarm, the owner cues a sit and a quiet, and any barking outside that cue is corrected. The rule is unambiguous and the dog learns it.

Pre-announcing visitors

The owner gets excited when a visitor is coming, hypes the dog up — "we have a visitor!" "go see who's at the door!" — and then is surprised when the dog detonates at the doorbell. The owner has been training the dog to be amped up for visitors. The dog doesn't need help getting

amped. From now on, the doorbell is just a sound. You don't celebrate it, you don't narrate it, you just respond to it.

Talking during the wait-out drill

The dog is barking at the gate, the owner says "no, no, quiet, no" the entire time. Now the bark is intermittently being paired with handler engagement, which is reinforcing for many dogs. The drill collapses. The fix is total silence. The handler is a wall. The dog has to figure out the puzzle without help.

Releasing the dog while still mentally locked on the trigger

The owner sees the dog pause for a second mid-bark and tries to mark the pause. But the dog's body is still pointed at the gate, the eyes are still locked, the mind is still on the visitor. Marking that moment reinforces the locked-on state, not the calm. The bark cycles right back. The fix is the same as the reactivity work in Chapter 5 — pay the mental shift, not the body position. Wait until the dog's eyes come back to you, the body relaxes, the mind has actually disengaged. Then mark.

Cheap bark collars

The owner buys a twenty-dollar bark collar from the big-box store, sets it on max, puts it on the dog. The dog barks once, gets hammered, squeals, the squeal triggers another stim, the squeal triggers another stim, the dog enters a stim-squeal loop that doesn't end until the dog learns to suppress squealing too. It is gut-wrenching to watch and it does not produce the lesson you wanted. It produces a traumatized dog. Spend the money on a real tool with learning mode and vibration-matching. The cheaper version isn't a savings — it's a different problem.

Suppressing alarm barking that's actually fear

The dog barks at every visitor, every passerby, every shadow. The owner installs a bark collar and the barking stops. The owner thinks the problem is fixed. But the underlying state — the fear, the territorial reactivity — is still firing. The dog is just no longer venting it through the bark. Now the dog is internalizing the same chemistry without an outlet, and you'll often see the next thing get worse: tension at the gate, redirected aggression onto another household dog, increased pacing, fearful body language even when "calm." If your dog's barking is rooted in fear, the bark collar alone is not the fix. You need to be running the reactivity work from Chapter 5 in parallel, and possibly the resource guarding or aggression chapters depending on how the underlying state expresses itself elsewhere.

WHEN THIS IS BEYOND THE PROTOCOL — WHEN TO ESCALATE

ESCALATION TRIGGERS

Most barking cases work cleanly through one of the three tracks above. A few situations need additional support before continuing.

- The barking has produced a neighbor complaint, an HOA citation, or a landlord notice and you have a hard deadline to fix it. Don't try to wait out a thirty-day protocol if you have a seven-day eviction warning. Bring it to the next live Q&A call for an emergency-paced plan that combines management and training.
- The dog's barking is paired with self-harm — bloody paws from scratching at doors, pacing to exhaustion, weight loss from agitation. That's a deeper anxiety pattern that needs to be addressed as anxiety, not as barking. Read Chapter 8 (Separation Anxiety) for related framing and DM in the community.
- The barking is at a household member specifically, paired with body language that suggests fear or aggression rather than nuisance. That's not a barking problem; that's a relationship problem with that handler. Different protocol — bring it to a Q&A call.

THE 30 / 60 / 90 DAY DIAGNOSTIC CHECKPOINT

Day 30

You've identified the barking type, picked your rule (always or never), and run the appropriate track for two to three weeks. The first sessions of the wait-out have produced clear curve data — session-one bark times have already dropped by half. Demand barking has cycled through the extinction burst and is fading. The bark collar is consistently on every yard trip and the dog has identified their threshold.

Day 60

The barking has reduced by at least seventy-five percent across the contexts you targeted. The dog defaults to place when the doorbell rings. The dog has stopped demand-barking at meals because the rule has held. The yard barking has dropped to occasional rare events instead of constant.

Day 90

The household sounds different. The dog responds to the doorbell with calm. The yard is quiet most of the time. The dog has internalized the always-or-never rule and isn't testing it. You've generalized to new visitors, new contexts, new triggers. Maintenance is intermittent — occasional reminders rather than active retraining.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: Can my dog still alarm-bark if I install a bark collar?

A: *If you want any barking allowed, the bark collar is the wrong tool — it can't tell the difference between alarm and nuisance. Either pick the always-or-never rule and accept the collar's blanket effect, or run handler-driven protocols for the door-and-visitor barking and skip the collar.*

Q: My dog only barks when I leave. Is this a barking problem or a separation problem?

A: *Almost certainly separation. Read Chapter 8. The protocols in this chapter address barking when the dog is in a baseline emotional state. Bark-when-alone is a different chemistry and a different fix.*

Q: Will the bark collar damage my dog's neck or larynx?

A: *A real bark collar with learning mode, fitted properly and used at the dog's actual threshold, will not. The damage cases come from cheap collars set too high, dogs left in the stim-squeal loop, or dogs left in collars they're physically reacting against. The Barkless Pro at the dog's identified level isn't doing what owners imagine — it's a brief, low-level interruption that the dog learns to predict and avoid.*

Q: My partner thinks bark collars are cruel. How do I have this conversation?

A: *Honestly. Show them this chapter. The collar with learning mode used at the dog's threshold is genuinely less invasive than thirty days of the dog being yelled at, anxious about whether the rule applies, and rehearsing the bark hundreds of times. Force without change is just force, and a household where everyone is yelling at the dog all day is producing more aversive moments than a properly-used collar ever does. If your partner still won't run the collar, run handler-driven protocols only and accept that the yard barking will be slower to fix.*

Q: My dog only barks when somebody is at the gate. Should I use a collar for that?

A: *No — that's Track A territory, not Track C. A bark collar in that context is a blunt tool for a problem that has a precise tool. Run the wait-out protocol with a handler-and-volunteer setup. The collar is for genuinely remote behaviors — the dog alone in the yard barking at things you can't be present to interrupt.*

Q: How long should I wait out the bark in session one?

A: *As long as it takes. The longest I've personally had to wait out a barking dog was about an hour and a half. Most dogs settle inside thirty to forty-five minutes the first session. If you bail early because it's uncomfortable to listen to, you've taught the dog that the bark eventually breaks the protocol — and the next session is going to be longer, not shorter. Hold the line.*

WORKING THIS CHAPTER

Pick your always-or-never rule first. Sit with it for a day if you need to. Decide whether your dog will be allowed any barking at all and, if so, under what cue. Then write the rule down, brief the household, and start the protocol. Mixed rules are the single biggest reason barking protocols fail.

If you go the bark collar route: get the right tool. The Barkless Pro from E-Collar Technologies is what I recommend for the multi-dog vibration-matching and the learning-mode ramp. The cheap big-box collars produce more harm than any benefit they deliver. If the budget is the limiting factor, run handler-driven protocols only until you can afford the right tool.

The wait-out protocol is hard the first time. Listening to a dog bark for thirty or forty-five minutes while you do nothing tests every parental instinct you have. Hold the line. The curve is sharp on the back end — sessions two and three are dramatically shorter. The protocol works because the dog has to discover for themselves that the bark is no longer producing anything.

If you're getting stuck: bring video to the next live Q&A call inside the Real Dog Rehab community. The hardest part of barking protocols is reading whether the dog is genuinely settling or just briefly pausing — that read is much easier with a second pair of eyes.

CHAPTER FIVE

5

Leash Reactivity

The lunging, the barking, the embarrassment, the dread of the next walk. This is the deepest chapter in the manual, because reactivity is the deepest case of the two-pillar shape — and the one most owners get wrong on the second pillar.

THE BEHAVIOR, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

You're walking the dog. Another dog appears at the end of the block. Your dog sees it, the body changes — tail up or tail tucked, depending on the dog, but everything tightens. You feel the leash go heavy. You start trying to manage it: shorten the leash, change direction, talk to the dog in a soothing voice. None of it lands. The other dog gets closer. Your dog explodes — barking, lunging, sometimes spinning, sometimes screaming, the whole show. You drag your dog past, apologize to the other owner, walk home shaken.

Then you wonder, again, whether you're walking the dog right at all. Whether you've broken something. Whether it's going to be like this forever.

It isn't going to be like this forever. But it's going to take real work, and the work is not what most owners assume it is. So let's get the diagnostic right before we touch the protocol.

WHAT'S ACTUALLY HAPPENING

Reactivity is not aggression

This is the first distinction I want to draw, because owners conflate them constantly, and the conflation produces a lot of unnecessary fear.

Reactivity is an emotional explosion without the motivation to do damage. A reactive dog is not trying to fight. They're trying to do *something* with a flood of chemistry their brain doesn't know how to discharge any other way. If you removed the leash and let the dog go to the trigger, in the vast majority of cases, the explosion would burn out within seconds and the dog would either de-escalate or look around for an exit. The lunging and barking is a chemical event — not an attack plan.

Aggression is different. Aggression has intent. The dog is trying to make contact, do damage, drive the threat off, or assert position. The body language is different — slower, more deliberate, more sustained. Most dogs labeled "aggressive" by their owners are actually reactive. Most dogs labeled "reactive" are actually reactive. The terminology problem is real and it shapes how owners feel about their own dog. If your dog is reactive — lunging, barking, putting on the show — they are almost certainly not aggressive. The protocol is different. The fear should be less.

BRIAN-ISM

Reactivity is an emotional overload. It is not disobedience.

The chemistry: arousal cascade

Here's what's happening physically when your dog reacts. The dog notices the trigger. Adrenaline starts firing. The sympathetic nervous system — the fight-or-flight branch — activates. Heart rate climbs, pupils dilate, blood pressure rises, cognitive processing narrows. As the cascade builds, the part of the brain that does *thinking* starts going offline. By the time the explosion happens, the dog is not in a thinking state. They are in a chemistry state. The behavior is the discharge of the chemistry.

This matters operationally. When a dog is over threshold — meaning the chemistry has already cascaded past the point of no return — they cannot listen to you. Not won't. *Cannot*. The neural pathways that would let them respond to a cue are not the pathways currently running. People yelling at their dog in the middle of a reactive blow-up are yelling at a brain that is not present. That's why correction during a reactive display rarely changes anything — you're trying to communicate with a system that isn't online.

You can't correct an emotion.

BRIAN FERGUSON

You can correct a *behavior*. You can correct a *position*. You can interrupt, redirect, manage. But the underlying emotional state — the arousal cascade — is not something correction touches. If all you do is suppress the display, the chemistry keeps firing under the surface, and the moment the suppression isn't there, the display comes right back.

This is why so much "reactivity training" produces dogs who look fine for six months and then unravel. The handler suppressed the display without ever addressing the chemistry. The first pillar is incomplete and the second pillar was skipped entirely.

The four flavors of reactivity

Reactivity isn't one thing. It's a category of responses driven by one of four underlying motivations. The motivation determines a few details of how you'll work the protocol — though the core two-pillar shape is the same across all four.

Fear-based reactivity. The dog learned that an aggressive display either drove the uncomfortable thing away, or got the handler to remove them from the situation. Body

language: tail tucked or low, body lowered, weight back, a strung-together bark — not clean separated barks but a continuous string, which is itself a stress signal. Most reactivity is this kind. The dog isn't confident; the display is a coping attempt.

Overstimulation-based reactivity. The dog has been over-socialized into high-value-proposition play with other dogs. Now, on leash, every other dog is the most exciting thing on Earth. The leash creates tension, tension creates frustration, frustration erupts as reactivity. Body language: tail up, chest forward, energy climbing visibly, sometimes spinning or orbiting behind the handler. This is the dog who, paradoxically, was the dog-park graduate.

Prey-based reactivity. The dog views the target as something chaseable. Usually directed at small animals — squirrels, rabbits, cats. Body language: locked-in stare, stalking posture, sudden lunge with focused intent. Less common than the first two; harder to fully eliminate, because the underlying drive is genetic. Best realistic outcome is impulse control over the desire, not the desire's removal.

Social dominance-based reactivity. Almost always same-sex — males to males, females to females. The dog feels driven to establish position over other dogs. Rare in pet dogs. Diagnostic: the dog reacts only to specific dogs (often based on the other dog's body posture), not all dogs. This is the rarest of the four.

Most of what you're dealing with, if you have a reactive dog, is overstimulation-based or fear-based. They often look the same to a frustrated owner; the body language is the diagnostic.

The over-socialization trap

Here's a counterintuitive piece of this puzzle that most owners aren't told. *Over-socialization is one of the most common causes of leash reactivity I see.*

The story usually goes: well-meaning owner gets a puppy, hears that puppies need to be socialized, takes the puppy to dog daycare, dog parks, group play. Puppy has the best time of their life. Puppy associates other dogs with massive endorphin releases — the chemistry of group play is a flood. Puppy grows up thinking other dogs are the best thing on Earth.

Now, on leash, that adult dog sees another dog and the chemistry says *I have to get to that*. The leash creates restraint. Restraint creates frustration. Frustration produces reactivity.

BRIAN - I S M

The number one way you'll get reactive responses or aggression out of dogs is through frustration.

The fix is not *more socialization*. The fix is *neutrality training*. The endpoint we want is not a dog who loves other dogs and not a dog who fears them. The endpoint is a dog who treats other dogs as background — another lamp post, another chair. Neutral. Not exciting, not scary, not worth reacting to.

If your dog came up through a heavy daycare or dog-park history and is now leash reactive, this is probably most of what you're working with. The protocol is the same as for any reactive dog, but the framing matters: we are not trying to make your dog "love" other dogs. We are trying to make other dogs *not matter*.

The "stop walking the dog" piece — yes, really

Owners hate this part. I'm going to say it anyway because it's the single most important thing in this chapter.

If your dog has been reactive on walks for any length of time, every reactive walk has been a training session in being reactive. The dog has been rehearsing the behavior — getting flooded with chemistry, exploding, getting the relief of the trigger going away — for however many walks it's been. Behavior practiced grows in strength. Period.

So before any protocol can land, you have to *stop the practice*. That usually means: *stop walking the dog in any environment where they are going to react*, for the duration of the foundation phase.

I know how that lands. The dog needs exercise. The dog "loves" walks. The household has a routine. None of that changes the math. Every reactive walk is making the next one harder.

Owners often push back: *but won't keeping him inside make him more fearful?* The answer is no — what produces the fearfulness is constant. Keeping him inside doesn't make it bigger. What it does do is stop the rehearsal of the reactive response. The buildup feels worse to the owner because the relief loop has been broken — the dog isn't getting their daily discharge. But that's the discharge we're trying to extinguish.

For exercise during this phase, the easiest single substitute is treadmill work. A used human treadmill from Facebook Marketplace runs seventy-five to a couple hundred bucks. Most dogs can be conditioned onto one in a few sessions. You burn the energy without rehearsing the bad pattern. The treadmill is a tool a lot of my members lean on heavily during the early phase of reactivity rehab and it makes the rest of the protocol much easier.

WHAT YOU MUST HAVE IN PLACE BEFORE THIS PROTOCOL CAN LAND

► BEFORE YOU RUN THIS PROTOCOL

Reactivity rehab assumes a substantial foundation already in place. If you're missing pieces of the foundation, the rest of this chapter will not produce the results it should. Build the missing pieces first. There is no shortcut.

- **Markers loaded.** Yes, no, free, and ideally a clicker. The dog responds to the conditioned signal across environments.
- **Food drive built and intact.** The dog will work for food at distance, in non-trigger outdoor environments. If your dog won't take food outside, food drive isn't yet where it needs to be — and without it, threshold work cannot run.
- **Leash pressure conditioned as negative reinforcement.** The dog reads pressure as a cue, not a thing to brace against.
- **Functional engagement.** Engagement is the number one item on this list — the rest of the foundation rests on it. Your dog can offer eye contact and orient to you, autonomously, in increasingly distracting environments. Not on a "watch me" cue — autonomously, because they have learned that engagement is the gate to everything good.
- **Functional obedience off-trigger.** Sit, down, place, and heel hold up under non-trigger distractions. The dog can hold a sit while you toss a piece of pizza on the floor. The dog holds place when the doorbell rings. None of those are reactivity triggers — they're *distraction* proofing, off-trigger. That has to be solid before we add triggers to the picture.

If any of those are missing — if you came to this chapter first because reactivity is your loudest problem, but the foundation isn't there yet — go work the 30-Day Quick Start Guide first. That's the other fast-action bonus that came with this manual, and it's specifically built to install those foundations in sequence. Yes, that means more weeks before you start touching the reactivity directly. The work is the work. Skipping it produces a protocol that goes nowhere.

THE TWO PILLARS APPLIED TO LEASH REACTIVITY

Pillar One for reactivity is a set of incompatible behaviors built solid off-trigger. Sit, down, place, heel, and engagement — bulletproofed in environments that are not the trigger. The dog has hundreds of paid reps of "right answer" before we ever bring the trigger into the picture.

Pillar Two is the threshold-based counter-conditioning that changes how the dog *feels* about the trigger. We work below the threshold where the chemistry fires, we make the trigger

predict good things, and we close the distance by yards over weeks until the dog is emotionally disconnected from the trigger at close range.

The protocol below runs as a 90-day arc — 30 days per phase. You will run it longer than 90 days at home; that's normal and not a failure. We run it in 30 days at the facility because we have unlimited training time, unlimited setup dogs, back-tie locations, and full-time focus. You don't. Plan for 90 days. Plan for 120 if life gets in the way. The dog is the clock, not the calendar.

BRIAN-ISM

Obedience first 30 days, emotion second 30 days, and then we combine those for the third 30 days. This is not a short process.

THE PROTOCOL

DAYS 0-30

Build the incompatible behaviors. Off-trigger only.

1 | Stop the reactive walks for the duration of this phase.

Maintenance walks only, in environments where you are confident the dog will not encounter triggers. Five-thirty in the morning routes. Backyard work. Treadmill for exercise. We are starving the reactivity of practice while we build the alternative.

2 | Build engagement first.

Of all the behaviors we'll layer in, engagement is the number one priority. Pay every offered eye contact, anywhere, anytime — autonomously, not on cue. The dog learns that orienting to you is the always-paying behavior. This is the keystone. Without it, none of the rest holds.

3 | Layer in the incompatible behaviors: sit, down, place, heel.

Each one built to functional level — meaning it works across distractions, across environments, with the dog's full repertoire under verbal cue and tactile (leash-pressure) cue. These are the behaviors that, by their mechanics, cannot coexist with a reactive display. A dog properly holding a down cannot be at the end of the leash lunging. A dog in heel cannot be lunging. A dog engaged with you cannot be locked on a trigger.

4 | Bulletproof the obedience under non-trigger distractions.

Toss kibble on the floor — does the sit hold? Ring the doorbell — does place hold? Have a family member walk past with a tennis ball — does the heel hold? Run the environmental ladder: living room, backyard, front yard, quiet street, light commercial area. Each rung is a separate proofing pass. Each rung gets paid clean reps until it's solid.

✓ DAY 30 CHECKPOINT

The dog can hold sit, down, place, and heel across a real range of *non-trigger* distractions, in at least three different environments. Engagement is autonomous — the dog is offering you eye contact without being cued. Food drive is intact in those same environments. **The dog has not yet been worked around triggers.** If you cannot pass this checkpoint, do not move into Days 30–60. Stay here and finish the foundation. Stage-jumping is the single biggest cause of failed at-home reactivity rehab.

DAYS 30–60

Threshold work. Counter-condition the trigger at distance.

This is the phase where we bring the trigger back into the picture — but only at distances where the dog is still cognitively functional. The drill below is the operational core of reactivity rehab. Run it correctly and the chemistry shifts. Run it wrong — too close, too fast, too long — and you'll set yourself back.

1 | Pick a location with a controlled trigger source.

Dog parks are the gold standard for dog-reactive dogs — there's a fence, the trigger dogs are real, the distance is adjustable, you have a safety barrier. For human-reactive dogs, a quiet park where you can choose your distance from a path works. The non-negotiable: you must be able to control the distance.

2 | Find the dog's threshold.

Walk in toward the trigger and watch the dog. Threshold is the distance at which the dog begins to *respond to their arousal* — the body changes, the focus locks, the cognitive part of the brain is starting to come offline. *Back up further than that.* The starting distance is whatever distance the dog can still notice the trigger and stay cognitively functional — taking food, responding to known cues, capable of disengaging back to you. If that distance is one hundred yards, it's one hundred yards. If it's a quarter mile, it's a quarter mile. The dog sets it.

3 | Run the full obedience repertoire at that distance.

Dog on place. Run sit, down, place, recall, heel — the same behaviors you bulletproofed in Phase One. Pay every clean engagement back to you. Pay every check-in. Pay heavy. The dog is learning: *trigger present, doing obedience with handler, getting paid.* Over reps the chemistry of the trigger reassigns — what used to predict bad things now predicts paychecks.

4 | Pay the mental shift, not just the body position.

This is the most important detail in the entire phase. When the dog is in the incompatible behavior — say, holding a down at the working distance — but is still *mentally locked on the trigger*, do not pay. Wait. Watch for the dog to disengage from the trigger and refocus on you. *Then* mark and pay. If you pay while the dog is locked on, you reinforce the locked-on state of mind. Body in position is not enough. Mind re-engaged is the marker.

5 | Close the distance one rung at a time.

100 yards → 75 → 50 → 25 → 10 → 5 → fence line. Each rung gets fully proven before the next. You move closer only after the full obedience repertoire is clean at the current distance. If at 80 yards the dog starts responding to arousal, back up to 82. Work there. Try the close-in again later. The numbers are arbitrary; the dog dictates.

6 | If the dog goes over threshold, calmly correct, reset.

Reactive blow-up happens. Calm leash correction to interrupt the display — you are correcting the *behavior*, not the emotion. Put the dog back into the incompatible position. Wait. Do not pay until the mental shift comes. When the mind comes back to you, mark and pay. Then back up the distance ladder for the next rep — you crossed threshold, so the next rep starts at a longer distance.

7 | End every session on a clean rung.

Not on the rep that went sideways. Find a distance where the dog is succeeding. Run a clean rep there. End. The last rep of the session is the one that gets logged hardest in the dog's brain — make it a paid clean rep, every time.

BRIAN-ISM

The biggest mistake I see people make in counter-conditioning is simply moving too fast.

✓ DAY 60 CHECKPOINT

The dog can run the full obedience repertoire at your current working distance, consistently, across multiple sessions. The working distance has measurably shortened from where you started. The dog is offering autonomous engagement to you in the trigger context, not just on cue. Reactive blow-ups are rare and recoverable when they happen. **You are nowhere near the fence yet, and that's fine.** The pace is set by the dog.

DAYS 60-90

Side-by-side with the trigger. Maintain behavior. Generalize.

1 | Close to the fence (or the equivalent close-range trigger).

By this phase the ladder has been worked down to feet, not yards. The dog can stand at the fence, go into a down, and hold it with the trigger dogs on the other side of the barrier. Eye contact on the handler. Body relaxed. Emotionally disconnected from the dogs across the fence. That is the endpoint state.

2 | Bring in the incompatible behaviors at close range as the default response.

Once close-range engagement is reliable, start teaching the dog that *seeing a trigger automatically means moving into heel / going to place / sitting*. The trigger becomes a cue for the incompatible behavior. The dog's brain stops asking "what should I do about this dog?" and starts running "trigger appears → my job is to engage with my handler."

3 | Generalize to new contexts.

Dogs are contextual learners. The dog who's bombproof at the dog park fence is not yet bombproof on your neighborhood walk. They are different contexts. The ladder has to be re-run, in compressed form, in each new environment the dog will be expected to work in. New context, restart the ladder — usually shorter and faster than the original, but a real pass.

4 | Slowly reintroduce neighborhood walks.

Pick a quiet route, off-peak. Run the protocol on the walk: pay engagement, hold heel, work below threshold. If a trigger appears, you have a trained playbook — move to the side, sit or down, pay engagement, let the trigger pass. The walk is now a working session, not a free-for-all.

✓ DAY 90 CHECKPOINT

The dog can be side-by-side with the trigger and maintain behavior. Engagement is on the handler, not on the trigger. The endpoint is *neutrality* — not affection, not fear, just unremarkable. Other dogs are part of the environment. Real-world walks are runnable with the protocol playbook in place. Generalization is happening across contexts, with the understanding that each new context may need its own short ladder run.

COMMON WAYS THIS GOES WRONG

Skipping the foundation

Owners come to this chapter first because reactivity is loud and embarrassing. They want to start at Phase Two — go straight to the dog park fence. The foundation isn't built. The dog can't hold a down with a piece of pizza on the floor, much less with another dog twenty yards away. The protocol fails, the owner concludes the protocol doesn't work. The protocol works. The protocol assumes the foundation is there.

The fix: do the foundation. There's no version of this where you can skip it.

Working too close

The handler picks a distance that *feels* reasonable — fifty yards, thirty yards, twenty yards. The dog is borderline over-threshold the whole session. Some reps go sideways, some are clean but tight. The handler is rehearsing the dog at a distance the chemistry can't actually handle yet. Progress is slow or negative.

The fix: *start outside threshold*. If the threshold is half a mile, the starting distance is half a mile. The numbers are arbitrary — the dog dictates. Trust the dog. Back up further than feels reasonable, and let the dog earn the close.

Paying while the dog is still locked on

The dog is in the position you cued — sit, down, place, heel — but their head and eyes are still locked on the trigger. The handler, wanting to reward the position, marks and pays. The dog interprets this as *staring intensely at the trigger from a held position is what pays*. The reactivity gets coiled tighter rather than dissolved.

The fix: pay the mental shift, not the body position. Wait until the dog disengages from the trigger and refocuses on you. *Then* mark. Then pay. If the dog never disengages at the current distance, the distance is wrong — back up.

Treating the dog park as therapy

The owner whose dog became reactive after dog-park exposure decides that the cure is to *go back to the dog park*. More socialization, the thinking goes. We'll fix it by exposure.

This usually makes the dog worse. The dog park is the cause, not the cure. Unstructured exposure is rehearsal, not training. What the dog needs is structured threshold work outside the fence — neutrality training, paid engagement, controlled distance — not more chaos inside it.

Switching protocols every two weeks

The owner reads about reactivity online, runs one method for ten days, doesn't see immediate results, switches to another method, runs that for ten days, switches again. The dog never gets a clean run at any single approach long enough for it to take.

The fix: pick a protocol and run it. The 90-day arc takes 90 days at the fastest. Real-world at-home work usually takes longer. Trust the timeline. The gains in this work are largely *under the surface* — the chemistry is shifting before the external display shifts. Stay the course.

Letting friends and family undermine the work

The household is doing the protocol. A well-meaning friend, neighbor, or family member starts feeding the dog from the table during the day, lets the dog rush guests at the door, takes the dog to the dog park "just once" while you're at work. The training has rules. The non-training has none. The dog is getting two different signals. The reactivity hangs on.

The fix: get the household and the close circle aligned before you start the protocol, not after. If the alignment isn't there, you're better off waiting to start until it is than starting and getting undermined.

WHEN THIS IS BEYOND THE PROTOCOL — WHEN TO ESCALATE

ESCALATION TRIGGERS

Most reactive dogs work cleanly through this protocol with the right foundation and the right pace. A few situations call for direct support before continuing.

- **Bite history with broken skin.** If your dog has bitten a person or another dog and broken skin, this is no longer purely a reactivity case. Bring it to a Q&A call before running the protocol. We'll diagnose and may layer in additional safety protocols (muzzle conditioning, back-tie setups) before the rehab work proceeds.
- **Reactivity that escalates to redirected aggression.** If your dog has, in the middle of a reactive blow-up, redirected onto you or another household member, that's a different category of case. Pause the protocol. Bring video and context to the community.
- **Dog showing signs of true generalized anxiety, not just trigger-specific reactivity.** If the dog is in a low-grade aroused state nearly all the time, the reactivity protocol alone won't be enough — there's foundation work on the anxiety side that has to come first. Read Chapter 8 (Separation Anxiety) for related framing, then bring it to a call.
- **Predatory drift.** If your dog has shown sustained predatory behavior toward small animals or small dogs (not reactive lunging — focused, sustained stalking with intent), that needs a different workup. Bring it to the community.

THE 30 / 60 / 90 DAY DIAGNOSTIC CHECKPOINT

The phase checkpoints are above. Use them as the diagnostic. If you're behind any of them, that is not failure — most at-home work runs slower than facility work. But it is a signal to stop, back up to the previous phase, and clean it before continuing. Most failed reactivity rehab is not a protocol failure. It's a stage-jumping failure.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: Should I really stop walking my dog completely during Phase One?

A: *If your normal walks have triggers in them, yes — stop the reactive walks for the duration of the foundation phase. Maintenance walks in trigger-free environments only. Treadmill or backyard work for exercise. Every reactive walk is rehearsing the behavior we're trying to extinguish.*

Q: Won't keeping my dog inside make her more fearful?

A: No. The fearfulness is constant. What stops is the rehearsal of the reactive response. The buildup feels like worsening because the daily relief loop has been broken. That's actually what we want — we're starving the pattern of practice.

Q: My dog is reactive on walks but fine at the dog park. What gives?

A: Almost certainly overstimulation-based reactivity from over-socialization. The dog has learned that other dogs equal massive endorphin release; the leash creates frustration; the frustration erupts as reactivity. The dog park is the cause, not the cure. Stop going. Run the protocol.

Q: Should I correct my dog mid-blow-up?

A: A calm leash correction to interrupt the behavioral display, yes — you're correcting the behavior, not the emotion. But you can't correct the underlying chemistry. The real work is below threshold, not on top of the explosion. Most blow-ups during the protocol mean the distance is wrong; back up rather than crank up corrections.

Q: What about scatter feeding to redirect the dog?

A: Scatter feeding works before threshold, not during reaction. If you see the trigger before the dog does and scatter food immediately, the dog redirects to ground-sniffing and the trigger passes without rehearsal. If you wait until the dog is already locked on, you're reinforcing the locked-on state. Useful as a window-buyer in early Phase Two work; not a substitute for the protocol.

Q: My dog is fine at one hundred yards but explodes at fifty. Is this normal?

A: Yes. That is exactly what threshold work reveals. Your job is to find the longest distance at which the dog can still cognitively function and start there. Then close by yards. Eighty yards is a real distance. Fifty is a distance you haven't earned yet.

Q: How long is this really going to take?

A: Plan for ninety days at the fastest, with daily short sessions. Plan for one hundred twenty if life interrupts. Dogs with deeper histories of rehearsal — dogs who've been reactive for years — often take longer. The dog is the clock. The work is the work. There is no shortcut that doesn't sacrifice the result.

WORKING THIS CHAPTER

This is the longest of the eight chapters because reactivity is the deepest application of the two-pillar shape. Don't be intimidated by the timeline. The dogs I see succeed are not the ones who run the protocol fastest — they're the ones who don't skip phases. Day 30 has to be clean before Day 30–60 starts, and Day 60 has to be clean before Day 60–90 starts. That's the whole game.

If your foundation isn't yet in place: the prerequisites at the top of this chapter are non-negotiable. Engagement, food drive, leash pressure as language, functional obedience off-trigger. If those aren't built yet, run the 30-Day Quick Start Guide first — it's the other fast-action bonus that came with this manual, and it's specifically the build for the foundations every protocol in this book stands on. There is no version of reactivity rehab that lands without those pieces underneath it.

Threshold calibration is the single thing that's hardest to do alone. When you're standing in a dog park parking lot trying to read whether your dog is at threshold or just under it, that's a judgment call that benefits enormously from a second pair of eyes. Bring video to the next live Q&A call. We'll watch the body language together and dial the distance in.

If your dog has a bite history or you're seeing the escalation triggers above: DM me inside the community before running this protocol. Reactivity rehab in the presence of a real bite history needs additional safety scaffolding that isn't covered in this chapter, and I'd rather we get that in place than have you running the protocol blind.

CHAPTER SIX

6

Resource Guarding

The dog stiffens over the food bowl. Growls when somebody walks past the bone. Snaps at the other dog who gets too close to the toy. This chapter is about why guarding starts, why it grows, and how to dismantle it without making it worse.

THE BEHAVIOR, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

It usually starts small. The dog goes still over their food bowl when somebody walks through the kitchen. A quiet stiffness, a hard look, a held breath. Most owners don't even notice the first time. Then later — the growl over the bone. Later still — the snap at the housemate dog who walked too close. Later still — the bite that broke skin.

Resource guarding can be over food, toys, bones, the couch, the bed, a specific spot on the rug, sometimes a person. The resource isn't the diagnostic — the pattern is. The dog has decided this thing is theirs and they will defend it from threats they perceive against it. What started as a held-breath warning turns, over reps, into the real thing.

A few things up front. Guarding is not your dog being dominant. Guarding is not your dog being mean. Guarding is one of the most natural behaviors a dog can run, evolutionarily — every wild canid in history that survived did so partly because they could hold onto food when something else came near. The wiring is in there. What we're working with is how that wiring expresses inside the home, and whether it grows or shrinks with practice.

WHAT'S ACTUALLY HAPPENING

Run the diagnostic question

Same question we run on every behavior. *What advantage is the dog creating, or what discomfort is the dog avoiding, by guarding?*

This one is almost pure avoiding-discomfort. The dog perceives something approaching the resource as a threat to that resource. Stiffness, growl, snap — those are graduated attempts to make the threat go away. *The threat goes away.* The dog's brain logs: *my display worked.* Behavior up. Avoidance just paid off.

And here's why guarding is so reliable as a behavior — it almost always works, in the dog's experience. The owner walks toward the bowl, the dog stiffens, the owner says "okay, easy," and walks past instead of taking the bowl. The dog has just gotten paid. The other dog walks toward the bone, the guarding dog growls, the other dog veers off. Paid. Each rep is a paid rep, sometimes thousands of paid reps over years, and the behavior compounds.

BRIAN-ISM

Every time he practices that behavior, it grows in strength. Period.

That's why guarding tends to escalate. The first growl works, so the dog doesn't need a second growl. Then a year later, the grandkid reaches into the bowl and the dog skips the warning and goes straight to the bite, because the warning has worked so reliably for so long it's become unnecessary. The bite is not a sudden change in the dog. It's the same behavior pattern, finally optimized.

Why "trade up" alone often doesn't work

Most owners I see have tried some version of the "trade up" protocol — walk toward the bowl with a higher-value treat, drop it in, dog associates approach with good things. It's a real protocol, it has its place, and for some dogs it works. For most resource-guarding dogs I see, it doesn't fully resolve the issue, and I want to be honest with you about why.

Trade-up protocols work on the chemistry side — Pillar Two work, on its own. They change what the approach to the resource *predicts* for the dog. But they don't address the underlying belief that the dog is the one in charge of who gets near the resource. So the dog gets calmer about you specifically, with the trade in your hand, in the kitchen, with the bowl you specifically use, in the moments you specifically run the protocol — and then the kid runs by while the dog has a bone, no trade in anyone's hand, and the dog goes straight back to the original wiring.

What we're going to do in this chapter is run trade-up alongside a deeper Pillar One foundation. The dog is going to learn that *you* are the gate to every resource in the house, and that the resources flow from your hand on your terms. That changes the dog's belief structure, not just the chemistry of one specific approach.

The leadership reframe

I'm going to talk about leadership in this chapter, and I want to be clear about what I mean and what I don't. I do not mean rolling your dog, pinning them, alpha-posturing, or any of the other methods that came out of the old dominance-theory framing for human-to-dog communication. That framing was scientifically disproven well over a decade ago, and it was never how I worked anyway. Dogs do not experience humans as another dog asserting hierarchy, and trying to act like one breaks the relationship rather than building it.

What I mean by leadership is something different and more practical: *you are the source of access to the things in the dog's life*. Food doesn't appear by magic — food comes from you, on your timing, after the dog has done something for it. Toys aren't lying around the house all day — toys come out, you play, toys get put away. Affection doesn't flow whenever the dog demands — affection flows when the dog is calm and you've decided to give it. The dog's relationship with the resources in their life runs *through you*, not around you.

When that frame is in place, the dog's belief structure shifts. The bowl is not their resource that they have to defend. The bowl is your resource that they get to access on your terms. There is nothing to guard — because nothing is theirs to guard in the first place. The resource is yours, and the dog gets to participate in it because you've allowed it. That's the deeper fix that separates dogs who superficially calm down from dogs who actually stop guarding.

WHAT YOU MUST HAVE IN PLACE BEFORE THIS PROTOCOL CAN LAND

► BEFORE YOU RUN THIS PROTOCOL

Resource guarding work assumes a substantial foundation. If you are missing pieces of it, building the protocol on top of nothing is going to produce surface compliance that collapses the moment your guard slips.

- **Markers loaded, food drive built.** The dog will work for food in environments outside the kitchen. If the dog won't take food when the bowl isn't right there, food drive isn't where it needs to be — go work the 30-Day Quick Start Guide first.
- **A solid place command.** Place is one of the primary tools in this chapter. The dog goes to a designated cot on cue, downs, holds for at least sixty seconds across moderate distraction.
- **Engagement-as-gate practiced.** The dog has done the place-bed kibble drill or its equivalent and has learned that engagement with the handler is the route to the resource, not direct access.
- **For severe cases — a muzzle conditioned and accepted.** If your dog has a bite history, you do not run hands-on guarding work without a muzzle. Muzzle conditioning is its own short build that the 30-Day Guide covers. Run that first if it applies.

If the foundation isn't in place, the protocol below will not land. Build the foundation. Then come back. There are no shortcuts on this one because the consequences of getting it wrong include people getting bitten.

THE TWO PILLARS APPLIED TO RESOURCE GUARDING

Pillar One is the leadership and impulse-control foundation that makes *every* resource in the house run through you. The bowl, the bone, the toy, the spot on the couch — all of it flows on your terms, gated by engagement with you. The dog is not learning a specific drill for "don't guard the bowl." The dog is learning that they don't have personal resources to guard in the first place, because the resources belong to the human and the dog's job is to earn access.

Pillar Two is the rewiring of what an approaching person or dog *predicts* when the dog is near a resource. Right now, in a guarding dog, the approach predicts threat — chemistry fires, body stiffens, behavior escalates. We're going to change that prediction so the approach predicts something good. Trade-up work, paid in the moment, layered carefully, builds a different chemical association.

The two pillars run in parallel for the first phase, then the rewiring moves into the foreground for the second.

THE PROTOCOL

PHASE ONE

Install the leadership-and-resource frame for the entire household.

This phase happens before you ever touch the specific guarding behavior. You're building the operating system the rest of the protocol runs on. Every resource in the dog's life starts going through you. This is not punitive. It's clarity.

1 | Pick up every chew, bone, and high-value toy in the house.

Right now, today. Not because the dog can never have them again — because they cannot have them lying around accessible at all times. From this point forward, those items come out when you decide, the dog gets them through engagement with you, and they go away when you decide. The dog is not going to be deprived of bones forever. They're going to start earning bones, and the bone arrives from your hand, on your timing.

2 | Switch to handler-gated meals.

The bowl no longer goes down on a schedule with the dog deciding to eat or not. You get the bowl. You ask for a sit. You wait until the dog is calm and offering you eye contact. Then you lower the bowl. If the dog breaks the sit before the bowl reaches the floor, the bowl comes back up. Reset. The food doesn't reach the floor until the dog has demonstrated calm engagement with you.

Once the bowl is on the floor, the dog gets to eat. They have ten minutes. After ten minutes, the bowl goes away whether food is left or not. Food is now perceived as a resource that comes from you, on your timing, in exchange for calm engagement. This is the existential shift the chapter rests on.

3 | Run the place-bed kibble drill if you haven't already.

From the impulse-control work in the 30-Day Guide. Dog on place, food on the floor, dog can't reach it through the leash. Wait for the check-in. Mark, pay from your hand. The drill builds the underlying wiring for "engagement, not fixation, is what produces access." That wiring is the foundation everything else in this chapter sits on.

4 | Couch and bed access goes through invitation.

If your dog has access to furniture, that access happens on your terms. The dog gets up when invited, gets off when cued. Not because furniture is bad — because in a guarding household, every resource the dog can access independently is a resource they can develop ownership over. We pull all of that back through you for the duration of the rehab.

5 | Affection through calm.

The dog who shoves their head under your hand, demands petting, climbs into your lap unbidden — that's not love, in the way most owners read it. That's the dog running social-access on their terms. Affection still flows in the household, but on your timing. The dog who wants attention has to offer calm first — sit, place, eye contact. Then the affection comes. Calm produces attention. Demanding does not.

✓ PHASE ONE CHECKPOINT

For two weeks straight, every resource in the dog's life has flowed through you. Meals, toys, bones, affection, furniture access. The dog has practiced offering calm in exchange for resources, hundreds of times across the day. There is no resource the dog can claim independent of you. **If this phase isn't solid, the rest of the protocol won't land.** The leadership frame is what makes the chemistry work in Phase Two stick.

PHASE TWO

Counter-condition the approach. Trade up systematically.

Now we work directly on the chemistry of the guarding moment. The dog is going to learn that the approach to a resource predicts something better than the resource itself. We do this slowly, below threshold, with safety in mind.

1 | Start with the lowest-value resource the dog guards.

Not the bone. Not the bowl. The thing the dog mildly stiffens over but doesn't yet snap at — maybe a chew toy, maybe a spot on the rug. We work the protocol on the easy version first to install the pattern, then graduate to the harder versions.

2 | Identify the dog's threshold distance.

The dog has the resource. You walk toward them. At what distance does the body start to tighten — even slightly? That's threshold. We start outside it. If the dog tightens at six feet, the protocol starts at eight feet.

3 | Walk toward the resource, throw a higher-value treat past the dog, walk away.

From outside threshold. You walk in the direction of the resource, you throw a piece of cooked chicken past the dog so it lands a couple of feet on the far side of them, and you walk away without ever reaching the resource. The dog gets to eat the chicken in their own time. You did not engage with the resource. You did not approach close enough to threaten.

Repeat. Across reps the dog's brain logs: *person walking toward my resource means chicken appears*. The chemistry of the approach starts to shift. Approach predicts paycheck, not threat.

4 | Watch for the somatic shift.

Over a few sessions you'll see it — the dog's body language toward your approach starts changing. Where they used to tighten at six feet, they now stay loose. Where they used to give you a hard stare, they now look at you with anticipation. *You're about to throw the chicken, aren't you?* That's the conditioning landing. The dog's brain has reassigned the prediction.

5 | Close the distance, slowly.

Eight feet becomes seven. Then six. Then five. Each rung gets cleaned up before the next. The standard is the same as the reactivity ladder — only advance when the dog is consistently relaxed at the current distance. If the body tightens at the new distance, you crossed threshold; back up to the last clean distance, work there, try the close-in again later.

6 | Eventually, you can approach the resource itself and trade up.

This is the last phase, and only after distance work has been clean for weeks. Now you can walk all the way up, drop the high-value treat near the dog, and walk away. Or — eventually — pick up the resource for a moment, replace it with the higher-value treat, and walk away. You're showing the dog: *my approach to the resource doesn't take the resource away. My approach often produces something better.*

7 | Generalize across resources, locations, and people.

What you build with one resource doesn't automatically transfer. Run the same protocol with the bowl. With the bone. With the favorite toy. With the rug spot. Then run it in different locations — kitchen, living room, yard. Then run it with different family members, one at a time, with you supervising. Each generalization is its own short ladder. Plan for it.

PHASE THREE

The Auto-Pushed Place — turn the approach into an upgrade.

Phase Two changes how the dog feels about somebody approaching the resource. Phase Three changes what the dog *does* when somebody approaches. We're going to install a default behavior — the dog voluntarily leaves the resource and moves to place the moment they perceive a person closing in — and we're going to make that voluntary leaving pay a paycheck so much bigger than the resource itself that the brain reassigns the entire framing.

This is the deepest move in the chapter and it's also the one with the highest prerequisite gate. Read this carefully before deciding whether you're ready for it.

► PREREQUISITES FOR THE AUTO-PUSHED PLACE

This protocol is gated behind two foundations, not just one. Both have to be solid before you run it.

One: a strong, generalized place command. The dog goes to place on a single verbal cue, holds across distractions, in multiple environments. This is the foundation work installed in the 30-Day Quick Start Guide.

Two: the entire E-collar methodology, layered on top of leash pressure, conditioned cleanly. The dog understands E-collar tap as the same language as leash pressure they already know how to respond to — a cue to move, not a punishment. That layer lives in the E-Collar as a Gas Pedal track inside the Real Dog Rehab community. If you have not run that work, the Auto-Pushed Place is not the protocol for you yet — run the trade-up work in Phase Two on its own, generalize it, and come back to this phase after the E-collar foundation is built.

1 | Set up the resource on the ground.

Dog has the bowl, the bone, or whatever the guarded resource is. Dog is consuming or possessing it normally. The dog is wearing their E-collar (already conditioned through the foundation work) and a leash drags from a flat collar — the leash is there as a backup if needed in step 4. You have a much higher-value paycheck ready in your hand or close by — the entire bowl jackpotted, a piece of cooked meat, something the dog rates higher than what is on the ground.

2 | Approach the dog. Issue place. Tap the E-collar to drive the dog to place.

Walk toward the dog. As you close the distance, issue your verbal place cue. Begin tapping the E-collar at the level the dog has been conditioned to respond to — the same way they have already learned to respond through the obedience work. The tap is communication, not punishment. It is the same language as the leash pressure they already know.

The dog should leave the resource and move to place. They are not being yelled at, not being corrected for guarding — they are being asked to do a behavior they already know how to do, with a cue language they already understand.

3 | **When the dog arrives at place, jackpot — bigger than what they left.**

The instant the dog gets to place and holds the down, the paycheck arrives. And the paycheck has to be *exponentially* bigger than what was on the floor. If they left a half-eaten bowl of kibble, you're presenting them with the entire rest of the bowl plus something extra, or a high-value protein they don't usually get, or whatever the household equivalent is of "this is the best thing that's ever happened on this couch." The volume and quality of the paycheck does the heavy lifting in this protocol — if it is not significantly bigger than what was left, the conditioning won't take.

The dog gets to consume the upgrade in place. You are paying the voluntary leaving and the move to place. You are not paying the original resource. The original resource stays where it was — the dog can return to finish it later if you decide, or it gets picked up and managed.

4 | **If the dog does not move to place, the E-collar pressure rises slightly to keep motivation high.**

Most dogs at this stage will move to place readily, because they already know the cue and the language. But sometimes the value of what's on the floor in front of them temporarily competes. If the dog hesitates rather than moving, the E-collar level rises a notch — enough to keep the motivation up, not enough to overwhelm. The pressure is communication, the same pressure-as-language we have used throughout this manual. We are saying *the cue stands; come on, move*.

If the dog still does not move — if the resource value is winning the moment — you do not escalate the E-collar further. You walk over, calmly, pick up the leash that is dragging, and guide the dog to place. You are showing them the answer. The instant they arrive at place, the paycheck still happens. The lesson the dog needs to log is not "I got pressured into leaving." The lesson is "leaving paid better than staying." Even when you had to guide them, the leaving still pays.

5 | Repeat. Watch the brain reassign the framing.

Over reps, something specific happens in the dog's brain through classical conditioning. The pattern installs. *Person approaching me while I have a resource — if I voluntarily leave and go to place, the upgrade is exponentially bigger than what I left.* The dog's nervous system stops reading the approach as a threat to the resource. The approach now predicts an opportunity for a much bigger payout, conditioned on a behavior the dog already knows how to perform.

Within several sessions, most dogs start offering the move to place before you even cue it. They see you walking toward them with food on the ground, and they get up and head to place on their own — because the prediction has installed and they are running toward the upgrade.

6 | Generalize the same way you generalized Phase Two.

Different resources. Different rooms. Different family members approaching. Each generalization is its own short ladder. The Auto-Pushed Place transfers more cleanly than Phase Two distance work because the behavior the dog is performing — go to place — is already generalized. But each new resource type still needs to be run through the protocol so the prediction installs across contexts.

Approach to my resource means I voluntarily leave and the upgrade is exponentially bigger than what I left.

THE CLASSICAL-CONDITIONING INSTALLATION

What this protocol gives you, when it lands, is a dog whose default response to the previously-guarded scenario is now *active engagement with the handler*. Not tolerating the approach. Not stiffly holding still while the chemistry boils. Actively moving away from the resource and toward you, because that's where the paycheck is. That is a fundamentally different state of mind than what the dog had at the start of the chapter, and it is the most durable resolution this chapter can produce.

PHASE FOUR

Live integration. The rules for the rest of the dog's life.

Resource guarding is rarely "cured" in the way a heel build is finished. It's a tendency the dog will always have, to some degree. What we install in Phases One through Three is a different default, but the underlying wiring remains. So Phase Four is about the rules that govern the dog's life going forward to keep that default holding.

1 | High-value resources stay handler-gated permanently.

Bones, chews, raw food, bully sticks — these come out when you decide, the dog earns them through engagement, and they go away when you decide. They don't lie around the house unsupervised. Not because the dog can never have them. Because removing the conditions for guarding from daily life is part of management.

2 | Meals stay handler-gated.

The bowl coming down through engagement, on your terms, becomes the lifelong default. It takes thirty seconds at meal times. It pays back every single day in maintaining the leadership-and-resource frame.

3 | Children never approach the dog while the dog has a resource.

Period. This is non-negotiable for the rest of the dog's life. Even after you've done all the rehab work and the dog seems perfectly fine — children do not approach a dog with a resource. The risk-to-reward ratio of a single bite incident with a child is not worth the small convenience of letting them pet the dog while the dog has a bone.

Brief every child in the household. Brief visiting children. If you cannot control this — visiting kids who don't follow the rule, household kids too young to understand — the dog is crated or behind a baby gate when the kids are around. Management for the lifetime of the dog. This is not a failure of training. This is responsible household design around a dog with a known tendency.

4 | Watch your own behavior. Don't drift back into old patterns.

The most common cause of regression I see is the owner who's done six months of solid work, sees the dog looking great, and quietly stops gating the meals because it feels unnecessary now. Three months later, the guarding starts creeping back in. The frame holds the work. Don't drop the frame.

COMMON WAYS THIS GOES WRONG

Going too close, too fast

The handler reads about counter-conditioning, gets excited, and starts the protocol four feet from the dog instead of eight. The dog goes over threshold. Now the rep was negative — the dog rehearsed the guarding response while the handler approached. The handler concludes the protocol doesn't work. The protocol works. The handler crossed threshold.

The fix: start outside threshold. Always. If you're not sure where threshold is, start further than you think you need to. You can always close the distance later. You can't undo a rep that crossed threshold without doing extra repair work.

Reaching for the resource during trade-up

The handler is doing trade-up correctly, then makes the mistake of also reaching for the resource. *Just one time, to see how the dog responds.* The dog's threat-prediction reactivates. The chemistry of the approach gets re-paired with the loss of the resource. The protocol gets set back weeks.

The fix: in Phase Two, you do not reach for the resource. You toss the higher-value treat past the dog. You walk away. The resource stays with the dog. Many sessions of "approach predicts treat, never loss" have to bank before you can ever start picking up the resource — and even then, you replace it with something better, you don't just take it.

Trying to "test" the dog

The handler has done eight weeks of clean work. They want to know if it's holding. They reach into the bowl while the dog is eating, just to see. The dog snaps. The handler is shocked.

The dog hasn't regressed. The handler ran a rep that wasn't part of the protocol — an unannounced direct take from the resource — and the dog ran the wiring they had before this all started. Tests like that are not training. They're rehearsals of the original behavior with extra stakes. Don't do them. Trust the protocol. The work is happening underneath whether you can see it on a stress test or not.

Confusing guarding with food drive

The dog eats fast and intensely, focuses on the bowl, doesn't want to be interrupted. The handler reads this as guarding. It might not be — for a dog with strong food drive, intense focus on eating is normal and not a precursor to guarding. The diagnostic is whether the dog tightens, gives a hard stare, or escalates when something approaches. If they're just absorbed in eating without the body changing, that's not guarding, that's a hungry dog. Don't run guarding protocols on something that isn't guarding.

Skipping Phase One because it feels unrelated

The handler reads the chapter, decides Phase One is "just leadership stuff" and not really about the guarding, and skips to Phase Two. Trade-up work alone produces some short-term progress and then plateaus. The handler gets frustrated. The plateau is because the underlying belief structure — *this is my resource and I defend it* — was never addressed. Trade-up alone retrains

the chemistry of one specific approach. Phase One retrains the dog's whole relationship with resources. Both are needed.

WHEN THIS IS BEYOND THE PROTOCOL — WHEN TO ESCALATE

ESCALATION TRIGGERS

Many resource-guarding cases work cleanly through the two-pillar protocol with the foundation in place. A subset of cases need additional support and should not be run unsupervised.

- **Bite history with broken skin, on a person.** If your dog has bitten a person and broken skin in a guarding context, this is no longer a self-help protocol. DM me inside the community before continuing. We'll layer additional safety scaffolding — muzzle work, controlled environments, structured supervision — and customize the rehab plan.
- **Bite history with another dog, especially a household dog.** Inter-dog guarding that has produced injury is its own case and benefits enormously from professional input. The protocol below isn't wrong for those cases, but the safety setup needs more than this chapter covers.
- **Children in the household with no possibility of perfect supervision.** If you have small children who cannot be reliably kept from approaching the dog with a resource, the household has to be set up for permanent management — crating during meals and treat times, baby gates, no shared spaces during feeding. If those structures cannot be put in place, that's a serious conversation about whether the household is the right environment for this dog.
- **Guarding that includes the dog's own person.** Dog growling at others who approach the human the dog has decided is "theirs." This is a different category — it's relational guarding rather than resource guarding — and it follows different rules. Bring it to a Q&A call.

THE 30 / 60 / 90 DAY DIAGNOSTIC CHECKPOINT

Day 30

Phase One is solid. Every resource in the household is handler-gated. Meals come down through calm engagement. The dog has practiced the place-bed kibble drill and engagement-

as-gate is internalized. You haven't started direct counter-conditioning on the guarding yet — that's intentional.

Day 60

Phase Two is in motion. You've identified the dog's threshold for the lowest-value guarded resource and you're working below it. The dog is showing the somatic shift — body relaxed at the working distance, anticipation rather than threat when you approach. Distance is closing in measured rungs. Higher-value resources are still being held back; you're working easy first.

Day 90

You can approach the dog at moderate distance with a low-to-moderate-value resource and the dog stays loose. You've started generalizing — different rooms, different family members, different resources. The household has internalized the lifetime rules: handler-gated meals, no children near a resourced dog, high-value items handler-controlled. The work continues, but the household is quiet, the bites have stopped, and the dog is no longer running the original wiring as a daily default.

For readers with the E-collar foundation in place from the E-Collar as a Gas Pedal track: Day 90 is also when the Auto-Pushed Place protocol becomes appropriate to layer in. The trade-up work in Phase Two has installed the chemistry shift; the Auto-Pushed Place takes the next step and installs an active default behavior — the dog voluntarily moving to place when somebody approaches the resource. That installation typically happens cleanly within a few weeks once the prerequisite foundation is solid.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog only guards from the other dog, not from people. Same protocol?

A: *Same Phase One — the handler-gated resource frame applies whether the threat is human or canine. Phase Two is run with another dog as the approaching agent rather than a person, which means you'll need a calm helper dog and structured setups. Bring video to a Q&A call to design the specific setup safely.*

Q: Can I just teach a "drop it" command?

A: *A reliable drop-it is great to have, and you can build it on top of this protocol. But drop-it alone doesn't fix guarding — it teaches the dog to release on cue. The underlying defense response is still there. Build drop-it as a useful tool, but don't mistake it for resolving the guarding.*

Q: My dog only guards specific things — bones, not the bowl. Why?

A: *Different resources fire different chemistry. Bones are a high-value, slow-consumption resource — the dog has to hold the bone for an extended period, which gives the brain time to register threat and build defense. The bowl is fast — the food is gone in two minutes, so there's less time for guarding chemistry to fire. Doesn't mean the bowl is "safe" — it just means you may see the pattern more clearly with bones than with food. Run the protocol on the bones first.*

Q: If I take everything away, won't my dog feel deprived?

A: *No. The dog still gets all the same things. The dog gets bones, toys, food, affection, couch time — exactly the same amount. What changes is the gating mechanism. Now the dog earns those things through calm engagement with you instead of accessing them on demand. The total amount of good stuff in the dog's life doesn't decrease — the dog's experience of how to get that good stuff changes.*

Q: Do I have to run the Auto-Pushed Place to fix this?

A: *No. The trade-up work in Phase Two will resolve guarding for most dogs, and the Phase Four lifetime rules will keep it resolved. The Auto-Pushed Place is the deepest move available — it installs an active default behavior on top of the chemistry shift — but it requires the E-collar foundation as a prerequisite, and not every reader has that yet. If you don't have the E-collar work in place, run Phases One, Two, and Four; the protocol is complete without Phase Three. If you do have the E-collar foundation, Phase Three is where the resolution becomes most durable.*

Q: My dog has bitten me. Should I keep working with them?

A: *Depends entirely on the bite. A single warning bite — broken skin from a snap, no sustained engagement — in the context of a clear trigger is workable for most owners with the right protocol and the right safety setup. A sustained bite, multiple bites, or a bite to a child shifts this into territory where you should be talking with me directly before continuing. DM in the community.*

Q: How long does this really take?

A: *Plan for ninety days at a minimum to get through Phase Two with one or two resources, longer to generalize across the full household. Resource guarding is rehab, not a quick fix. The dogs I see succeed are the ones who run the leadership frame as a permanent change to how the household operates, not as a thirty-day project that ends. The work isn't over at Day 90 — it's just running on a sustainable rhythm by then.*

WORKING THIS CHAPTER

If your foundation isn't yet built: markers, food drive, place command, engagement-as-gate. Without those, the protocol won't take. The 30-Day Quick Start Guide installs them in sequence. If your dog has a bite history, also work the muzzle conditioning protocol from the Quick Start before doing hands-on work.

Phase One is the work most owners want to skip. It feels unrelated to the actual guarding. It's the most important part. The leadership-and-resource frame is what makes the counter-conditioning in Phase Two actually stick rather than just produce surface compliance. Run Phase One for the full thirty days before you touch the guarding directly.

Safety first, always. If your dog has any bite history, run a conditioned muzzle during Phase Two work. Not punishment. Insurance. The muzzle lets you run the protocol without putting yourself or anyone else at risk during the early reps. As the dog's response clearly shifts, you can phase the muzzle out — but it stays on for the early sessions, every time.

If something feels off: bring it to the next live Q&A call. Resource guarding is the chapter where reading the dog's body language correctly matters most, and where the cost of a misread is highest. Bring video. We'll watch the body language together and dial in the threshold distance, the timing of your treat throws, and the pace of your distance work.

CHAPTER SEVEN

7

Multi-Dog Household Aggression

Two dogs in the same house, fighting. The fights are getting more frequent and more serious. You're sleeping with one eye open. This chapter is about why pack chaos happens, why managing it alone never holds, and how to actually rebuild it.

THE BEHAVIOR, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

You have two dogs, or more. They live together. At some point, something shifted — maybe slowly, maybe all at once. Two of them stopped getting along. The fights started. At first you could break them up easily, but they got bigger. You started managing — keeping the dogs separated, rotating them through the house, locking one in a bedroom while the other has run of the place. Your phone calls happen behind closed doors. Doing laundry requires choreography. Friends don't come over because the dogs have to be moved before anyone walks in.

You've gotten bitten breaking up a fight. Maybe more than once. The vet bills have started. You feel like you're failing your dogs and you can't see a way through it.

I want to start by telling you something most owners in this situation don't hear: *this is fixable*. I see this case all the time. The fix is not fast and it is not gentle on the household, but it works, and the principles behind it are clean once you can see them. Read this chapter carefully. The escalation triggers at the end matter more in this chapter than in any other — multi-dog aggression with a serious bite history needs more than this manual can give you in a self-paced format. But for the typical case, the protocol is real and the work lands.

WHAT'S ACTUALLY HAPPENING

Run the diagnostic question — for both dogs

What advantage is being created, what discomfort avoided, in the fights between your two dogs? The answer is darker than most owners want to hear.

Fights produce a massive endorphin release. The chemistry of physical conflict — the adrenaline cascade, the endorphin dump on the back end — is biologically pleasurable for the dogs involved. Each fight lays down dopamine pathways the same way any reinforced behavior does. The dog that "wins" the fight gets paid in both endorphin chemistry and in the practical outcome — they got the resource, they made the other dog defer, they controlled the situation. Behavior up. The dog that "loses" still got the chemistry, and often gets more dialed in for next time, looking for a different outcome.

BRIAN-ISM

Dogs thrive on violence. That's their natural communication language. When they get into a fight, it releases a massive amount of endorphins. That's just like throwing treats in the middle of the fight.

This is the principle most owners cannot get past on their own. Once a household has a few real fights in it, the fights themselves are a self-reinforcing pattern. The dogs aren't fighting because they hate each other. The dogs are fighting because fighting works — produces chemistry, resolves whatever the immediate trigger was, and gets practiced. Over reps, the dogs become — and I use this word literally — addicted to the fight cycle. Looking for the next opportunity to run it.

This is also why management alone never holds long-term. Management — keeping the dogs apart, rotating them, controlling triggers — works for a while. Then somebody forgets to close a door, somebody new visits, the routine breaks. The dogs run the cycle, get the chemistry, and the addiction gets one more rep. Management buys you time. It does not fix the underlying pattern.

Pack chaos is a leadership problem

Here is the deeper diagnostic, and it goes against most of what owners tell themselves in these households.

I want to be careful with my words in this section because two ideas often get tangled together and they shouldn't be. Dog-to-dog social dominance is real. Dogs absolutely do compete for position with each other. They negotiate access to resources, to spaces, to other dogs. Some dogs care about that hierarchy a lot; some don't care at all. That's just canine social structure, and denying it doesn't help anyone. What's *not* real, and what was scientifically disproven well over a decade ago, is the idea that *humans should act like an alpha dog* with their own dogs. Roll the dog. Pin them by the scruff. Stare them down. That framing is what got demolished. Dogs do not experience humans as another dog asserting hierarchy — they experience that kind of treatment as unfair pressure from another species, and it destroys trust.

So drop the alpha framing entirely. You are not your dog's alpha. You are something better than that — you are their *human leader*. That's a different thing, and it operates by different mechanics.

What's actually happening in a chaotic pack is simple. Dogs in a household will work out a hierarchy among themselves if no clear human leadership is in place. In some households that

hierarchy stays settled and quiet — the dogs have figured it out, nobody's contesting it, life is fine. In other households, especially with strong-willed dogs or breeds with high social-dominance drive, the hierarchy keeps getting contested. That's where the fights start. The dogs are trying to settle a question among themselves that, in your home, cannot be allowed to settle on its own — the cost of letting it play out is vet bills, injuries, sometimes a dead dog.

The fix is not for you to insert yourself into their hierarchy as the top dog. The fix is for you to step *above* their hierarchy entirely, as the human leader who dictates the rules of the household. Not by force. Not by dominance posturing. By being the one who reliably controls behavior in the moment — yours and theirs. The dogs are not negotiating a position with you. The dogs are being told that there is no position to negotiate among themselves either, because you control the resources, the spaces, the access, and the social interactions. The hierarchy they were trying to figure out becomes irrelevant, because nothing is theirs to win.

Whoever can dictate and control behavior is in charge. If your dog takes off after another dog and you say "down" and the dog drops and stops — you're in charge. If you can't do that, the dog is.

BRIAN FERGUSON

Read that sentence. The leadership signal is not a posture or a tone or a roll-the-dog-on-their-back ritual. It's a behavioral fact. *Can you dictate behavior in the moment?* If yes, you're in charge and the dogs experience that as a settled household where they don't have to keep working out the hierarchy themselves. If no, you're not in charge, and the dogs will continue to negotiate among themselves — which means more fights.

The level playing field

Here's the principle that most multi-dog households get wrong, and it cascades through everything else. Every dog in the household has to live by the same rules. Same standards. Same expectations. Same crating arrangements when nobody's home. Same gating of resources. Same calm-for-attention requirements.

If five of your six dogs are crated when you leave the house and one is allowed to roam free because she's old, or because she had a bad crate experience years ago, or because she "won't tolerate" it — the other five dogs notice. They read the inconsistency. The dog who's gotten an exception has, in the dogs' shared mental model, *won that fight*. The leadership of the household is now visibly inconsistent, and the rules clearly do not apply to everyone equally. That perception destabilizes everything you're trying to build.

Same thing if one dog gets walked because she pulls hard and you can't manage her with another dog at the same time, while another dog gets corrected for pulling. Same thing if one

dog is allowed on the couch and another isn't. Same thing if the rules for greeting visitors apply to one and not another. Every inequality is read by the other dogs as *the leadership doesn't apply uniformly*, which means the leadership doesn't really exist.

The level playing field doesn't mean every dog gets identical training intensity. The puppy and the senior aren't going to be doing the same drills. But every dog meets the same household standards. Every dog earns access to resources the same way. Every dog gets crated under the same conditions. Every dog runs the same calm-greeting protocol with visitors.

The time cost — and why it's worth it

This chapter requires more time investment than any other in the manual. Plan for around one hundred to one hundred and twenty hours of training work per dog to take a chaotic pack and get them to "controllable no matter what." For two dogs that's roughly two hundred hours. For three dogs, three hundred. Spread across six to twelve months of consistent daily work.

That sounds impossible. The reframe that helps most owners: *you are already spending those hours*. You are spending them rotating dogs, breaking up fights, sleeping badly, doing laundry between flare-ups, scheduling your day around dog management. That energy is going somewhere. The protocol asks you to redirect it — same hours, different purpose. Instead of managing chaos, you're correcting chaos. By the end you have hours back, plus a household that functions.

WHAT YOU MUST HAVE IN PLACE BEFORE THIS PROTOCOL CAN LAND

► BEFORE YOU RUN THIS PROTOCOL

Multi-dog rehab has the deepest foundation requirements in the manual. Without these in place, you'll be running the protocol in name only. Build the foundation across all dogs — to a level appropriate for each — before starting the integration work.

- **Foundation work, individually, for every dog.** Markers loaded, food drive built, leash pressure conditioned, place command solid, recall on a long line. The 30-Day Quick Start Guide is the build for this. Run it for each dog, in isolation from the others, before you start the integration work in this chapter.
- **The ability to crate every dog.** No exceptions. Every dog in the household must be cratable. If any of your dogs cannot be crated currently, the crate build is its own short project that the 30-Day Guide covers — run it before this chapter.

- **Functional impulse control work.** The place-bed kibble drill. The engagement-as-gate pattern. Done individually with each dog before you start having them work in proximity to each other.
- **Honest assessment of bite history.** If your dogs have caused real injury to each other or to a person — punctures with serious tissue damage, bites that required stitches, multiple incidents — this chapter is not the place to start. DM me inside the community before continuing. We need to assemble a more conservative plan with additional safety scaffolding.

The 30-Day Quick Start Guide that came with this manual installs the foundation skills sequentially. Run it for each dog separately — this is one of the cases where you cannot run it for multiple dogs simultaneously, because the dogs need to develop their foundations independently before they can be brought together. That's already a several-week investment up front, before you even start this chapter. There is no shortcut. The protocol below assumes the foundation is solid for every dog.

THE TWO PILLARS APPLIED TO MULTI-DOG AGGRESSION

Pillar One is the household-wide leadership and impulse-control frame. Every dog in the home runs through you for resources, for movement, for greetings, for furniture, for everything. The dogs are not running their own social hierarchy. You are dictating behavior, uniformly, across the entire pack. That frame is the foundation everything else sits on.

Pillar Two is the systematic counter-conditioning of the trigger relationships between specific dogs in the home. We work each pairing separately, at distance, below threshold, paying calm engagement and rewiring the chemistry of being near each other. The pedestal protocol is a key tool here — it gives us a controlled way to have two dogs in proximity while neither has the option to engage with the other.

THE PROTOCOL

PHASE ONE

Reset the household. Stop the practice.

1 | Stop the fights from happening, starting today.

Every fight is a paid rep of the addiction cycle. Until further notice, the dogs do not have unsupervised access to each other. Period. This is the most important thing you do in the entire protocol — stop the practice, immediately, even before you start any training work. Crates, baby gates, separate rooms, two micro-packs in different parts of the house — whatever it takes. The dogs do not interact unsupervised until further notice.

2 | All dogs crated when nobody is home.

Every dog. Same standard. The level playing field starts here. If a dog cannot currently be crated, that's the first thing to fix — pause the rest of the protocol, run the crate build from the 30-Day Guide for that dog, then come back. No exceptions. The 13-year-old dog with mobility issues might be the only one who gets a slightly different setup — a baby-gated room with a cot — but everybody else is in a crate when the humans aren't there.

3 | Resources flow through the human, uniformly.

Meals, toys, bones, affection, furniture access, doorway access, walking out — all gated by you, for every dog, on the same standard. The dog that pushes through the doorway first gets sent back. The dog that demands attention by jumping into your lap gets put on place. The dog that finishes their food first does not get to walk over and supervise the slower eater.

Watch for the small leadership cues most owners miss. The dog who shoves another dog out of the way at the water bowl. The dog who lays down across a doorway and forces the other dog to step over them. The dog who stares the other dog away from a spot. These are inter-dog communications that say *I make decisions here, you move for me*. Every one of them gets interrupted. *"Nope, not your job. Go lay down."* The interrupt itself is the message — to both dogs — that you, not them, control the social dynamic.

4 | Run the foundation work with each dog individually.

Place, sit, down, recall, leash work, the place-bed kibble drill. Each dog separately, in a session where the other dogs are crated or otherwise out of the picture. Build the individual obedience to functional level. The dog who can hold a clean down with food on the floor is the dog who's going to be able to hold a clean down with another household dog walking past, eventually. That second skill is built on the first one. We have to build the first one first.

✓ PHASE ONE CHECKPOINT

The fights have stopped because the practice has stopped. All dogs are crated when humans are not home. Every resource in every dog's life is flowing through the humans on the same standard. Each dog has functional individual obedience — place, down, recall — that holds across non-trigger distractions. You have not yet started the integration work, and that's intentional. **Most pack-chaos rehabs that fail, fail because owners skipped this phase.** The household-wide leadership reset is what makes the integration possible. Without it, every integration attempt is going to collapse into the old wiring.

PHASE TWO

The pedestal protocol — controlled proximity work.

Now we start having the dogs work in proximity to each other, but only on terms we control. The pedestal — an elevated cot, ideally one per dog — is the central tool. Each dog can be tethered or back-tied to a pedestal, holding place, working obedience, getting paid, all while the other dog is doing the same thing on a separate pedestal. The dogs are present to each other but neither has the option to engage. This is where the rewiring happens.

1 | Set up two pedestals at moderate distance.

Far enough apart that both dogs can hold place without going over threshold at the proximity. Could be ten feet, could be twenty, could be across the room. The dog determines the distance — start further than feels necessary and close in over sessions.

2 | Work each dog on their own pedestal — together but separate.

Each dog tethered to their pedestal. You move between them, marking and paying calm holds on each. The dogs are watching each other, present to each other, but neither one has direct access. We are paying the calm — the relaxed body, the elbows down, the engagement back to you despite the other dog being right there. Over reps, the proximity becomes ordinary. The other dog becomes background, not threat.

3 | Watch for the somatic shift on each dog.

The body language tells you the conditioning is landing. Where the dogs used to be wound tight in proximity, they're now relaxing into the pedestal posture. Eyes soft. Mouth loose. Elbows down. Engagement on you instead of locked on the other dog. When you see that shift consistently, you can close the distance to the next rung.

4 | Close the distance gradually.

Twenty feet → fifteen → ten → eight → six. Each rung gets cleaned up — both dogs holding clean, paid pedestal work at the new distance — before the next one. If either dog tightens at the new distance, back up. The pace is set by the more-tense dog. Don't push.

5 | Read who's actually less ready.

Here's a diagnostic that surprises a lot of owners. The dog who's having the hardest time decompressing on the pedestal in proximity — body still tight, can't relax even at distance — that's the dog who's least ready to handle the integration, regardless of which dog has been "the aggressor" in the fights. *Tension is the predictor, not who started it.* Pay attention to which dog is showing the tension and pace your integration work to that dog's signals.

PHASE THREE

Controlled introduction. Structured play, on your terms.

This phase only happens after Phase Two has been clean across multiple sessions at close range. By now the dogs can hold pedestal work within several feet of each other, calm, engaged with you, neither tense. We're now going to start letting them interact — but only on structured terms.

1 | Recall one dog off their pedestal toward the other.

Both dogs pedestaled. The more-confident dog gets recalled toward the other — verbally, on a leash you're holding. The recalled dog approaches, sniffs, returns to their pedestal. The other dog stays in place throughout. Mark and pay calm on both. If the still-pedestaled dog tightens, leash pressure back into position from you, no pay on the recovery.

2 | Reverse it.

Same drill, other direction. The other dog gets recalled, approaches, sniffs, returns. We are building a pattern of *controlled approach, neither dog escalates, both get paid for calm.*

3 | **Release both dogs into supervised play — only when both are clearly settled.**

Both dogs on their pedestals, calm. Use your release word: "free." Both dogs come off their pedestals at the same time. Watch them.

Healthy play looks like loose, bouncy movement. Soft mouths. Frequent breaks. Either dog can disengage and the other allows it. Roles trade — one chases, then the other. If you see clean play like that, let it run for sixty to ninety seconds, then end it on your cue.

Unhealthy play looks like one dog pinning, mounting, pawing on top of the other repeatedly. Stiffness. Hard staring. One dog trying to disengage and the other not allowing it. If you see that, interrupt verbally — *"hey, no, leave him alone, stop"* — and reset both dogs to their pedestals. The play just ended. Try again next session.

4 | **End every play session on your cue, while it's still going well.**

Recall the dog whose recall is most reliable. The other dog usually follows. Both back to pedestals. Pay calm. End the session there.

The lesson the dogs are getting is critical: *play happens on the human's timing. Play starts when the human releases. Play ends when the human recalls. The human controls the social interaction, not the dogs.* That structure is what reshapes the long-term dynamic. It's also what stops the dogs from negotiating their hierarchy with each other — there's no hierarchy to negotiate, because you're the one who starts and ends every interaction.

COMMON WAYS THIS GOES WRONG

Skipping Phase One because it feels too slow

The owner is exhausted, wants results, jumps to Phase Two without doing the household-wide leadership reset and the individual foundation work. The integration sessions don't take. The owner concludes the protocol doesn't work. The protocol works. The foundation wasn't there.

The fix is the same answer as in every other chapter. Build the foundation. Run Phase One in full for the foundation period — usually a month or longer for a multi-dog household — before you touch Phase Two. The work is the work, and skipping it does not save time. It costs more time on the back end than it would have taken to do up front.

Inconsistent rules between dogs

One dog gets crated, another gets a room. One dog is gated off resources, another gets bones at will. One dog has to earn affection, another gets it on demand because "she's the easy one." The dogs read the inconsistency. The leadership signals as inconsistent. The protocol stalls.

The fix is the level playing field. Same standard, every dog. Yes, a senior dog with mobility issues might have small accommodations. No, those accommodations don't extend to the rest of the rules. Every dog earns resources the same way. Every dog gets crated when humans aren't there. Every dog runs the same greeting protocol with visitors. The uniformity is what creates the perception of consistent leadership.

Trying to fix the relationship without addressing the addiction

The owner keeps working on what they can see — managing triggers, separating during meals, hoping the dogs will "remember they used to get along." But every fight that happens during this period has been one more rep of the endorphin-loop addiction. The protocol can't compete with the chemistry until the chemistry stops getting fed.

The fix is non-negotiable management of the dogs' interactions during the rehab period. Until the foundation has been rebuilt and the integration work is going cleanly, the dogs do not have unsupervised access to each other. Crates, gates, separate rooms — whatever it takes. The fights stop, immediately, even before the rest of the protocol starts. Otherwise the addiction keeps getting fed and there's nothing you can do that lands.

Letting dogs negotiate among themselves

The owner sees the dogs working out a small interaction — one dog showing the other a hard look, the other dog deferring — and thinks, *they're figuring it out*. They're not figuring it out. They're laying down another rep of the social-dominance pattern that produces the bigger fights. Every small dog-to-dog negotiation is a brick in the hierarchy you're trying to dismantle. The fix is interrupting all of it. Not in an angry way. Calmly, every time. *Nope. Not your job. Go lay down*. The interrupt itself is the leadership signal.

Releasing into play before either dog is truly settled

The owner sees both dogs holding pedestal for a few seconds, gets excited, releases into play. One of the dogs was actually still tense — tight body, hard eyes, fixed stare on the other dog. The release lights the fuse. Instead of clean play, it's an immediate fight. The owner is shocked. The owner shouldn't be shocked — the body language was telling them.

The fix is the same as the reactivity work. Pay the mental shift, not the body position. Both dogs in pedestal isn't enough. Both dogs in pedestal *and visibly relaxed, eyes soft, body loose, engaged with you* is the standard. Wait for both dogs to be truly settled before any release. If either dog isn't there yet, the release doesn't happen. Try again later.

WHEN THIS IS BEYOND THE PROTOCOL — WHEN TO ESCALATE

ESCALATION TRIGGERS

This chapter has the most situations that should be brought to professional support before continuing. Multi-dog aggression with serious history is not a self-paced rehab project.

- **Bite history with serious tissue damage.** Any bite between household dogs that required vet stitches, or that caused permanent injury, escalates this case. DM me inside the community before running the protocol. We'll add muzzle work, additional safety scaffolding, and a slower integration plan than this chapter covers.
- **Bites to people — especially while breaking up fights.** If a household member has been bitten, even by accident in the chaos of breaking up a dog fight, this is a different category of risk. The handler safety setup needs more than this chapter provides. Bring it to a Q&A call.
- **One dog has actively tried to kill another.** Sustained, focused, refuse-to-disengage attacks. That's predatory or hard-aggressive behavior, not pack chaos. Some of those cases can be rehabbed. Some cannot. The honest conversation about whether the dogs can ever live together, or whether the more humane outcome is rehoming one of them, needs to happen with someone who can assess the dogs in person — not over a manual.
- **Three or more dogs in serious conflict, with the household feeling unmanageable.** The protocol scales but the time investment scales with it. Bring it to a call so we can build a custom plan with realistic timelines and the two-micro-packs prioritization mapped to your specific dogs.

THE 30 / 60 / 90 DAY DIAGNOSTIC CHECKPOINT

Day 30

Phase One is solid. The fights have stopped because the practice has stopped — dogs are managed, crated, separated as required. Every dog has the same household-wide rules applied. Each dog has functional individual obedience built or rebuilt. You have not yet started integration work. The household feels calmer because the chaos cycle has been interrupted.

Day 60

Phase Two is in motion. The dogs work pedestal-to-pedestal at moderate distance, holding clean, both relaxing into proximity. You have closed the distance over multiple sessions. There

have been no fights since the protocol started. Triggers that used to set off conflict are now controlled by the household-wide structure.

Day 90

The dogs work at close pedestal range without tension. Controlled approaches and brief structured play sessions are running cleanly. The household has a working rhythm — meals fed in sequence, calm greetings, clear handler control of every interaction. The dogs are not negotiating among themselves because there is nothing left to negotiate. The work continues — generalization, ongoing maintenance — but the household functions, and you can sleep without one ear cocked for the next fight.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dogs used to get along. Why did this start?

A: *Several common reasons. One dog matured into adolescence or social maturity (around 18–36 months) and started asserting position. A new dog joined the home and the existing pack hierarchy got destabilized. A serious incident — a fight, an injury — happened once, and the chemistry of it has been driving repeats. A change in the household routine or environment shifted the dynamic. Doesn't really matter which one — the protocol is the same. Build leadership, stop practice, rewire chemistry, integrate slowly.*

Q: Do I really have to crate my old dog who has never been in a crate?

A: *For the duration of the rehab, yes. Same standard for every dog or the leadership signal collapses. You can use the largest crate you can fit — a wire pen if needed — and you can build the crate skill as part of the foundation work, but the principle of every dog meeting the same baseline is non-negotiable. Brief exception for dogs in serious medical decline; everyone else is on the same standard.*

Q: My dogs only fight when one of them has a bone. Can I just remove all the bones?

A: *Removing the trigger is part of management — yes, do that for the duration of the rehab. But it's not a fix. The dog who's been guarding the bone has built a belief structure that they're entitled to control resources, and that belief will surface in other contexts the moment a new trigger appears. Run the resource guarding work in Chapter 6 in parallel with this chapter. Both apply.*

Q: My female dog and my male dog get along. The two female dogs are the problem. Is that significant?

A: Yes. Same-sex dog aggression — female-female or male-male — is the most common pattern, especially among intact or strongly-driven dogs. Cross-sex aggression in the home is much rarer. Doesn't change the protocol much, but it does mean the work is going to be hardest with the same-sex pair, and you can expect the cross-sex relationships to stay easier even during the rehab.

Q: How long until I can leave the dogs uncrated together?

A: For most cases, that's a six-month-to-a-year horizon at the earliest. Some cases never get there — the dogs live well together when supervised, but the management structure stays in place permanently. That's not a failure. That's appropriate household design for the dogs you have. The bar isn't "uncrated together when you're at work." The bar is "no more fights, calm coexistence, controllable in the moment." Some households reach the first; many households should plan around the second.

Q: Can I rehome one of the dogs instead?

A: Sometimes that is genuinely the right answer. If the household cannot reasonably do the protocol — if the time isn't there, the management isn't possible, the bite history is severe — placing one of the dogs in a single-dog home can be the most humane outcome. That's not failure. The honest conversation about whether your specific case is workable is one to have with somebody who can assess in person. DM me in the community if you're trying to make that call.

WORKING THIS CHAPTER

Foundation has to be built first, individually, for every dog in the household. The 30-Day Quick Start Guide gets each dog to the baseline. Run it for each dog separately. That's already a multi-week investment before this chapter even starts. Don't skip it.

Phase One is non-negotiable and slower than feels necessary. Most failed multi-dog rehabs are owners who jumped to the integration work without the household-wide leadership reset underneath. The reset is the protocol. The pedestal work is just where it gets visible.

Stop the practice today. Whatever management structure it takes to prevent any fight from happening during the rehab — crates, gates, rotation, two micro-packs in different parts of the house — set it up before you do anything else. Every fight that happens during the rehab is a paid rep of the addiction cycle and undoes work you haven't done yet.

Bring the case to the community. This is the chapter where personalized input matters most. Bring video to the next live Q&A call — the dogs' body language during pedestal work, your handler position, the specific triggers in your house. We'll dial in the specifics. And if anything in the escalation triggers above applies to your case, DM me before continuing.

CHAPTER EIGHT

8

Separation Anxiety

The dog falls apart the moment you walk out the door. Destroys the doorframe, screams for hours, hurts themselves trying to get out. This isn't your dog missing you. This is a chemical dependency you've helped build — and the same way it got built, it can be dismantled.

THE BEHAVIOR, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

You leave the house. Within minutes the dog is in distress. Pacing. Whining. Barking. Some dogs escalate to destruction — door frames chewed through, crate bars bent, rugs torn up, walls scratched until paws bleed. Some dogs vocalize for the entire duration of your absence — neighbors have started leaving notes. Some dogs hurt themselves trying to escape — broken teeth, bloody pads, and in the worst cases, real injuries.

You come home and the relief on the dog's face is immediate. The barking stops. The dog is climbing on you, licking your face, frantic with reunion. You feel the guilt rise. You promise the dog you won't leave again. Some owners have started arranging their entire lives around not leaving the dog alone — taking the dog to work, hiring a sitter for every appointment, declining social events because the dog can't be alone for two hours.

I want to be very direct with you up front about what's happening here, because the framing matters more in this chapter than in any other. This is not your dog loving you so much they can't bear to be away from you. This is your dog in genuine chemical panic, suffering, because the wiring for self-regulation hasn't been built. The dog is not happy in this state. The dog is in distress. And every minute they spend in that distress is rehearsing the panic and making it worse.

The other thing I want to say up front: this is fixable. It takes longer than most other behavior cases — plan for three to six months — but the protocol works, and dogs come out the other side genuinely settled when alone. The work is mostly on you, and the hardest part is going to be the guilt. Let's start with what's actually happening.

WHAT'S ACTUALLY HAPPENING

The chemistry — this is a dependency, not a feeling

Separation anxiety is a chemical dependency on the owner for soothing. That's not a metaphor. The pleasure-and-comfort neurochemistry that produces a sense of belonging and calm — serotonin, dopamine, oxytocin — gets produced two ways in any mammal's brain. One, internally, by the brain regulating itself. Two, externally, through social bonding with another being who triggers it.

Most dogs develop both pathways. They learn to self-produce calming chemistry, and they also experience it through bond with their humans. A dog who can do both is a dog who's regulated whether the human is there or not. The dog with separation anxiety has a different

developmental history. The internal pathway never got built, because the external pathway has been so consistently available that the brain never had to develop the alternative. The owner has become the source of the dog's calm. When the owner leaves, the dog has no route to that chemistry. The brain panics — not because the dog "misses" the owner in some human emotional sense, but because the chemistry the dog needs to regulate is suddenly gone and there's no internal pathway to produce it.

BRIAN-ISM

Separation anxiety is not your dog missing you. It's your dog missing the presence of structure and guidance.

This frame matters because it tells you what the actual fix is. The fix is not "more time with the dog so they feel more secure." The fix is not "more affection so they know they're loved." The fix is not "tire them out with exercise so they sleep through your absence." The fix is the deliberate building of the self-soothing pathway the dog never developed. We're going to teach the dog to produce their own calming chemistry, the same way every emotionally regulated adult animal does — through structured independence, through learning that absence is not an event, and through removing the conditions that have made the dog dependent on you for everything.

It is owner-created. Every time. I am not trying to make you feel bad.

I have to say this clearly because owners hear it as blame and it isn't blame, it's diagnosis. Separation anxiety, as a clinical pattern, is one hundred percent owner-created. Every single case. The dog who has it didn't come with it — the conditions that produced it were built in the relationship between the dog and the household, even though no one in the household had any idea that's what was being built.

The mechanism is simple and almost universal. The owner — usually out of love — over-soothes the dog. Constant affection. Constant access to the human's body. The dog who shadows the owner from room to room and gets allowed to. The dog who sleeps in the bed and gets cuddled the entire time. The dog who whines and gets reassured. The dog who jumps in the lap and gets petted. Every one of those interactions is the owner serving as the dog's self-regulation system. Over time, the dog's brain stops developing the internal version because the external one is so reliably available. By the time the owner leaves the house for the first time, the dog has years of dependency wiring laid down.

You did not do something cruel. You did something kind in a way that backfired. The kind thing now is to start building the other pathway. Some of what you'll have to do — in particular, the parts where you stop responding to the dog's solicitations of attention — is going to feel cold. Hold the line anyway. The kindness is the structure. The structure is what lets the dog finally settle.

Independence is not neglect. It's relief.

BRIAN FERGUSON

Diagnostic — is it actually separation anxiety?

Before you run the protocol, make sure you're treating the right thing. A surprising number of dogs labeled with separation anxiety don't actually have it. They have *too much freedom while alone*, which is a different problem with a different fix.

The diagnostic is simple. For one to two weeks, when you leave the house, crate the dog. Not as the rehab — just as a test. If the dog settles in the crate during your absence — sleeps, rests, no destruction, no excessive vocalization — what you had wasn't separation anxiety. It was an unstructured-freedom problem, and crating during absences is the fix all by itself. Some dogs, given the responsibility of managing the entire house alone, panic about that responsibility. Take away the responsibility — give them a crate where the only job is to rest — and the panic disappears.

If the dog goes into full panic in the crate — pacing, vocalizing for hours, escape attempts, self-injury — the working diagnosis is separation anxiety. Run the protocol below.

The three amplifiers — stop these today

Three things owners do that pour gasoline on separation anxiety. Stop all three immediately, before you start any other part of the protocol. Just stopping these alone gets you measurable progress in many cases.

One: Emotional departures. "It's okay, mommy will be back soon, don't be sad, I love you, I'll be back..." — what feels like reassurance to you reads to the dog as a long anxious ritual conducted right before you walk out the door. The dog cannot parse the words. The dog reads the tone, the prolonged farewell, the emotional intensity. The association the dog's brain builds is unmistakable: *walking out the door is a high-anxiety event*. The ritual itself becomes part of what triggers the panic. From now on, your departures are short, calm, and unceremonial. Crate, treat, leave. No goodbye.

Two: Emotional reunions. "Hi baby! I missed you! Oh I love you, who's a good girl, oh I'm so sorry I was gone..." — same mechanism, opposite direction. The dog learns that absence

was a Very Big Deal because the return is a Very Big Deal. Calm-state-of-mind during your absence is never reinforced; the explosion of reunion is. From now on, your returns are quiet. Walk in, calmly, ignore the dog for the first few minutes, let them settle. When they're calm, then quiet acknowledgment. The reunion is a non-event.

Three: Free-roaming during absences. The dog has the run of the whole house when you're gone. They're standing watch over an environment they have no tools to manage. Every sound is theirs to investigate. Every shadow, every car door, every mail truck is theirs to assess. Anxiety, at root, is the experience of having to manage a world you don't have the tools to manage. The free-roaming dog has the world thrown at them and no leadership available to defer to. Crate the dog. The crate eliminates the management responsibility. The dog has nothing to do except rest. Anxiety has nothing to fire on. As I tell my members all the time: *crating during absences alone solves about ninety percent of the problem.*

WHAT YOU MUST HAVE IN PLACE BEFORE THIS PROTOCOL CAN LAND

► BEFORE YOU RUN THIS PROTOCOL

Separation anxiety rehab requires a specific foundation. The protocol depends on the dog being able to hold place, settle in a crate, and respond to handler structure. Without those, you are running the protocol in name only.

- **A clean place command.** The dog goes to a designated cot on cue, downs, holds for at least sixty seconds across moderate distraction. Place is one of the central tools in this chapter — it's how we build forced separation while still in the house.
- **A working crate skill.** The dog can be in the crate without panicking. If the crate itself is currently a panic trigger, the crate build is the first thing to fix — covered in the 30-Day Quick Start Guide. Run the crate work first.
- **Clear markers and basic obedience.** The dog responds to your communication. Without a clean "good" / clicker / reward loop, you can't build the calm-state reinforcement the protocol depends on.
- **Honest assessment of severity.** If your dog is causing serious self-injury during absences — broken teeth, bloody paws, real damage — this is past the self-help threshold. DM me inside the community before continuing. Severe cases sometimes benefit from veterinary support alongside the behavioral work, and that conversation has to happen with someone who knows your case.

Foundation builds happen in the 30-Day Quick Start Guide that came with this manual. If your foundation isn't yet there, run that first. There is no shortcut on this one — separation anxiety rehab requires the dog to be able to hold structure when you're not there, and the only way to build that is with the foundation skills first.

THE TWO PILLARS APPLIED TO SEPARATION ANXIETY

Pillar One is the deliberate building of the dog's independence — while you're still in the house. Forced separation, place work that the dog holds without you reinforcing every second, free-shape work that builds the dog's problem-solving wiring, removal of the constant-contact patterns that have created the dependency. You cannot teach a dog to be calm while you're gone if they cannot be calm while you're there. The independence has to be built in your presence first, and then the absence becomes survivable.

Pillar Two is the rewiring of what departures and returns *predict*. Right now, your departure predicts panic; your return predicts explosion of reunion. We're going to neutralize both. Departures become brief, calm, unceremonial events. Returns become quiet acknowledgments after the dog has settled. Over reps, the dog's brain stops registering departure as a high-anxiety predictor and stops registering return as a peak-chemistry event. Comings and goings become ordinary. Ordinary doesn't fire the panic.

THE PROTOCOL

PHASE ONE

Independence work — built while you're home.

1 | Stop being the dog's source of constant chemistry.

Starting today, the patterns of constant contact change. The dog who shadows you from room to room gets sent to place when you move into a new room. Not always — but often enough that following you everywhere stops being a successful default. The dog who climbs into your lap unbidden gets calmly redirected to their cot. The dog who whines for petting doesn't get petting until they've offered calm. Affection still flows in the household, generously — but on your timing, not the dog's demand. Calm produces affection. Demanding does not.

Be honest with yourself about how often you're providing chemistry. The owner who has the dog touching them for six hours a night while watching TV is providing six hours of dependency-building. We are not going cold turkey on affection — we're shifting the pattern from "constant contact" to "frequent calm contact at the human's discretion."

2 | Practice forced separation while you're in the house.

Several times a day, send the dog to place, settle them in, and then go about your business in the same room or another room. Don't engage with the dog. Read a book. Work on the laptop. Watch TV. The dog is not getting interaction. They're learning that you can be present and not engaged with them — which is the building block of being absent and not engaged with them.

Start with five minutes. Build to fifteen. Build to thirty. Build to an hour. The dog should be able to hold a calm place hold for an hour while you're nearby and not interacting. That skill is what makes absence survivable.

3 | Add crate-while-you're-home practice.

Same drill but with the crate instead of place. The dog goes in the crate, the door closes, you stay in the house but don't engage. Twenty minutes. Forty minutes. An hour. The dog learns that the crate door closing does not mean you're leaving — sometimes you're right here, you're just not available to them. Once the crate is reliably a calm space while you're home, the crate becomes a calm space when you're gone.

4 | Build self-discovery work — free-shape.

Free-shape sessions, where the dog has to figure out a behavior on their own without being lured or shown, build the cognitive muscle of independent problem-solving. Every free-shape session is a rep of *handler is not going to show me the answer; I have to figure it out*. That's the same cognitive pathway the dog uses to self-regulate emotionally — the pattern of "I have to produce my own answer" for the body and the brain. Skill transfers across domains. Run short free-shape sessions multiple times a week.

✓ PHASE ONE CHECKPOINT

The dog holds a calm place for an hour while you're in the house and not interacting. The dog settles in the crate with the door closed for at least an hour while you're home. The dog has stopped shadowing you constantly and accepts being on their own cot when you're in another room. The constant-contact patterns have been replaced by intermittent-calm-contact patterns. **Do not move into Phase Two until this is solid.** The independence has to be built in your presence first.

PHASE TWO

Neutralize the departures and returns. Practice short absences.

1 | From now on, every departure follows the same script.

Crate the dog calmly. Drop a high-value treat or chew in the crate as you close the door — a frozen kong, a bully stick, something the dog likes. No verbal goodbye. No "I'll be right back." No "be a good girl." Walk to the door. Walk out. Close the door behind you. That's it.

The lack of ritual is the point. The dog's brain has been registering a long, anxiety-laden pattern as the predictor of absence. We're replacing the pattern with a neutral one. Crate, treat, leave. Repeated this way for weeks, the departure becomes ordinary, and ordinary doesn't fire the panic chemistry.

2 | **Run very short absences. Build the duration ladder.**

The first session might be: crate, treat, leave, walk to the mailbox, come back. Total absence: ninety seconds. The dog might not even register that you left. That's the goal — start at a duration so short the panic doesn't have time to fire.

Build up. Two minutes. Five. Ten. Twenty. The pace is set by the dog. If you come home and the crate is calm — dog resting, no shredded crate pad, no vocalization audible from outside — you can extend the next session. If you come home to evidence of distress — pacing, slobber on the bars, anything destroyed — back up. The next session is shorter than the one that didn't go cleanly.

3 | **From now on, every return follows the same script.**

You walk in. You do not greet the dog immediately. You take your shoes off. Put your bag down. Take care of one or two things in the house. Wait for the dog to settle. Then, calmly — no high voice, no big affection — let the dog out of the crate. Brief acknowledgment. Then move into your normal evening.

The lack of reunion explosion is the second half of the neutralization. If the return is a non-event, the absence stops being a Big Deal. Both ends have to be quiet for either end to land.

4 | **Climb the duration ladder over weeks, not days.**

This is slow work. We are rewiring chemistry that has been laid down over years, and we have a small number of reps per day to do it — most owners only leave the house a few times a day, and only some of those count as training reps. Plan for three to six months of consistent practice to see substantial relief.

Critically, do not skip rungs. If the dog is solid at twenty minutes, the next training rep is twenty-five or thirty, not three hours. The duration ladder is the same as the threshold ladder in the reactivity work — you climb it slowly, and you back up if it stops landing.

COMMON WAYS THIS GOES WRONG

The guilt

The single biggest reason separation anxiety rehab fails. The owner has been told what to do, intellectually agrees, but cannot execute. They give the long emotional goodbye anyway. They explode at the reunion anyway. They let the dog back into the bed because *they missed me*,

look how happy they are. Every emotional reunion erases days of work. Every emotional departure plants the next panic.

The fix is to recognize the guilt as the saboteur and address it directly, sometimes before the protocol can even begin. The dog is suffering in the current pattern. What you experience as kindness — the long goodbyes, the rapturous reunions, the constant access — is producing a dog who panics every time you walk out the door. The genuinely kind act is the structure that makes the dog not have to feel that anymore. Sit with that until it lands. If you can't get past the guilt, the protocol can't run.

Skipping Phase One because it doesn't seem related to the absence

The owner reads the chapter and thinks, *I want to fix the leaving-the-house problem, not change how I sit on the couch.* They skip Phase One, jump to Phase Two, build the absence ladder, and the dog doesn't improve much. The reason: the underlying chemistry hasn't been addressed. The dog still has zero independent self-soothing wiring, because the in-house dependency patterns are still active. The Phase Two ladder can't compete with the dependency that's getting fed every other minute of the day.

The fix is to do Phase One in full for the foundation period. The independence work in your presence is the foundation. Without it, the absence work has nothing to stand on.

Going too long, too fast

The dog handles fifteen minutes cleanly. The owner gets excited, decides to test forty-five. The dog goes over threshold. Now the rep was a panic rehearsal — the dog spent thirty minutes panicking, building the pattern back up. Setbacks are real, and they take longer to recover from than the gains they erase.

The fix is to climb the ladder slowly. The pace is set by the dog. If the dog is solid at fifteen, the next rep is twenty. If the dog is solid at twenty, the next rep is thirty. Patience wins this protocol. The owners who succeed are the ones who can tolerate the slow build.

Re-introducing the constant-contact patterns once the dog "seems better"

The dog has been doing well for a couple of months. The owner relaxes the protocol. The dog is back on the couch, back in the bed, shadowing the owner from room to room, getting petted on demand. Three weeks later, the panic returns at the next absence, and the owner doesn't understand why. The dependency wiring rebuilds whenever the constant-contact patterns return. The structure is permanent, not a one-time project.

The fix is to keep the structure as the household default. The dog can have plenty of affection, plenty of contact, plenty of time on the couch — but the patterns of *handler initiates, calm*

earns it, dog has independent space stay in place. The structure is what the dog has come to rely on. Don't take it away because they "look fine."

Not actually crating during real absences

The owner does the protocol perfectly during practice sessions, then leaves the dog free in the house when going to work because *"the protocol is going well, I think she'll be okay."* The dog isn't okay. Without the crate, the dog has the whole house to manage and no structure to defer to. The panic returns. The destruction returns. The owner concludes the protocol failed. The protocol didn't fail — the management piece got dropped at exactly the moment it mattered most.

The fix is to keep the crate as the absence default until the dog has demonstrated reliable calm in the crate at the duration of your real absences. That's months of work for most cases. The crate stays in place. Eventually, when the dog has internalized the calm-when-alone state, you can experiment with un-crated absences in controlled small doses. But that's a Phase Three move, and most owners aren't there yet at the six-month mark.

WHEN THIS IS BEYOND THE PROTOCOL — WHEN TO ESCALATE

ESCALATION TRIGGERS

Most separation anxiety cases work cleanly through this protocol with the foundation in place and the household discipline to run it. A few situations need additional support before continuing.

- **Self-injury during panic.** Broken teeth, bloody paws, real damage to the dog's body during episodes. This is past the self-help threshold. Severe cases sometimes benefit from veterinary support — a conversation with your vet about anxiolytic medication during the rehab can make the protocol possible to run. DM me in the community before continuing.
- **Dog attempting escape that puts them at real risk.** Crates being broken out of, doors being broken through, attempts to jump from windows. Both safety scaffolding and a customized rehab plan are needed. Bring it to a Q&A call.
- **Severe noise-related neighbor complaints with a hard timeline.** Eviction warnings, HOA citations, court-mandated quiet windows. Don't try to wait out a six-month protocol if you have thirty days. Bring it to a call so we can build an emergency-paced plan that combines aggressive management with the rehab work.
- **Combined separation anxiety and severe generalized anxiety.** The dog who is anxious all the time, not just when you leave. This is a bigger case than this chapter alone covers. Combined work across general-anxiety and separation-specific protocols is needed. DM in the community.

THE 30 / 60 / 90 DAY DIAGNOSTIC CHECKPOINT

Day 30

Phase One is solid. The constant-contact patterns have been replaced. The dog holds place for an hour while you're nearby and not interacting. The dog settles in the crate with the door closed for at least an hour while you're home. The three amplifiers — emotional departures, emotional reunions, free-roaming during absences — have been cut entirely.

Day 60

Phase Two is in motion. The duration ladder has been climbed slowly. The dog tolerates absences of an hour or more without panic. The departure script and return script are running cleanly. You haven't seen destruction in weeks. The neighbors have stopped getting calls.

Day 90

The dog can be alone for several hours, crated, calm. The structure is the household norm now — independent space for the dog, calm-earns-affection, neutralized comings and goings.

You're starting to see the dog actively choose to settle on their own cot rather than always being near you. The work continues — generalization to longer absences, occasional un-crated practice — but the foundation has held and the dog is in a different chemical state than they were three months ago.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog has always been like this — it's not something I caused.

A: *I hear that often. The pathways to separation anxiety can include experiences before you got the dog — early weaning, shelter time, prior traumatic absences. Doesn't change the protocol. The dog still has a chemical dependency that wasn't met with the building of the alternative pathway. The fix is the same regardless of who started the pattern. The work begins with you.*

Q: Won't crating be cruel for a dog who's already anxious?

A: *It feels that way to most owners initially. It is the opposite of cruel for most cases. The crate eliminates the management responsibility — the dog has nothing to do except rest. Anxiety is the experience of having to manage a world without the tools to manage it; the crate removes the world. For most separation-anxious dogs, properly conditioned crating is the single biggest stress reducer in the protocol. It feels harsh from the outside. It is genuinely kinder than free-roaming panic.*

Q: My dog is fine when my partner is home but panics when I leave specifically. What's that about?

A: *The dependency is on you specifically — you're the source of the chemistry, your partner isn't. Same protocol applies. The work is yours to do. The dog can build the internal pathway only if the external dependency on you stops being the default.*

Q: Should I get a second dog to keep him company?

A: *Almost universally, no. A second dog rarely solves separation anxiety because the dependency is on the human, not on company in general. The first dog still panics when you leave even with another dog there. And now you have two dogs to manage. If your dog has separation anxiety, fix that before considering a second dog — bringing another dog into a household with active separation anxiety can also create separation anxiety in the new dog through the modeling effect.*

Q: What about anti-anxiety medication?

A: *For severe cases, that's a real conversation to have with your vet. Medication doesn't replace the behavioral protocol — it can lower the panic floor enough that the protocol becomes runnable. The dog who is in catastrophic panic the moment you leave often cannot learn anything during that state, and medication paired with the*

rehab work can be the path through. That's a vet conversation, not a manual conversation. Bring it up with them and bring the conversation back to me in a Q&A call if you want.

Q: How long does this really take?

A: *Three to six months for visible relief in most cases. Slower for severe ones. The pace is gated by the small number of training reps per day — most owners only leave the house a few times daily, and only some of those count as protocol reps. Patience wins this protocol. The dogs who recover are not the ones with the most intense effort; they're the ones whose owners can sustain the structure for the duration of the rebuild.*

WORKING THIS CHAPTER

If your foundation isn't yet built: a clean place command, a working crate skill, basic obedience that holds. The 30-Day Quick Start Guide installs all of these. If your dog cannot be in the crate without panicking, that's a separate build that has to happen before this chapter — covered in the 30-Day Guide. Run that first.

The guilt is the saboteur. Recognize it now, before you start. The protocol asks you to do things that will feel cold — short goodbyes, quiet returns, sending the dog to place when they want to be in your lap. Hold the line. The kindness is the structure. The dog is suffering in the current pattern. Your job is to stop the suffering by doing the harder thing.

Patience, not intensity, wins this protocol. Three to six months. Most owners get a couple of weeks in, see partial improvement, and back off the structure because the dog "seems okay now." The dog isn't okay yet. Stay the course. The work compounds slowly until one day you realize you've been gone four hours and didn't worry about the dog the whole time.

If anything in the escalation triggers above applies, DM me before continuing. Severe separation anxiety with self-injury or escape attempts is past the self-help threshold. We'll get safety scaffolding in place and customize the plan for your specific case. Otherwise, bring questions to the next live Q&A call inside the Real Dog Rehab community — separation anxiety is a chapter where the slow build benefits from regular check-ins, and the calls are the place for that.

AFTER THE TOOLKIT

Where to Go from Here

You've finished the toolkit. Or you're carrying it with you as a reference. Either way, here's how to keep the work moving and how to use the community to keep refining it.

If you've worked through the chapters in this manual that apply to your dog, you know already that this isn't a short project. The protocols take the time they take, and most of you reading this will still be in the middle of the work for several months after first reading the chapters that matter to you. That's normal and expected. The manual is meant to be lived with, referenced repeatedly, returned to as new questions come up.

A few things I want you to take with you as you keep doing the work.

RUN THE DIAGNOSTIC QUESTION ON EVERY BEHAVIOR

When something new comes up — a behavior you didn't expect, a regression in something you thought was solid, a moment that confused you — the first thing to run is the diagnostic question. *What advantage is the dog creating, or what discomfort is the dog avoiding, with this behavior?* Once you can answer that question, the path forward almost always becomes clear. Most of the cases I see in the community where members are stuck are stuck because they haven't named the motivator underneath the surface behavior.

THE TWO PILLARS APPLY TO BEHAVIORS I HAVEN'T COVERED

The two-pillar structure isn't specific to the eight behaviors in this manual. It's how I think about every behavior modification problem. Build the incompatible behavior, bulletproof it off-trigger; rewire the chemistry of the trigger through threshold-based counter-conditioning. That shape applies to behaviors I didn't have room for in this manual — counter surfing, refusing to come inside, fear of the vet clinic, scavenging on walks, dozens of others. If you find yourself with a problem this manual doesn't cover, the framework still works. Run the diagnostic, identify the incompatible behavior, build it off-trigger, rewire the chemistry. The shape holds.

BRING THE HARDER CASES TO THE COMMUNITY

The Q&A calls are where the protocols in this manual get tuned to specific dogs. Bring video. Bring questions. The members who get the most out of the community are the ones who show up to the calls regularly — not just when they're stuck, but as part of how they work the protocol. The calls are also where you'll see other members' dogs, which is one of the most valuable things — watching another handler work through a moment your dog is also working through teaches you faster than any reading.

For the urgent stuff — bite incidents, cases that don't fit the protocol, cases where one of the escalation triggers in a chapter applies — DM me directly inside the community. I'd rather you flag those sooner than later.

A REMINDER ABOUT WHAT DOESN'T GO AWAY

Some of the behaviors in this manual get fully resolved with the protocol. Pulling on leash, recall failure, jumping on people — these typically resolve to a clean baseline once the protocol holds.

Other behaviors don't get fully resolved. They get reduced to a manageable baseline that the household structure maintains. Resource guarding, severe reactivity, multi-dog aggression — these typically resolve to a place where the dog functions well within the right structure but the underlying tendency remains. That's not failure. That's appropriate household design around the dog you have. The household-wide leadership frame, the resource-gating, the management of high-trigger contexts — those become permanent features of how you live with the dog. The work pays off in years of calm coexistence, not in a one-time cure.

And separation anxiety, the deepest of the chapters, is somewhere in between — it can be largely resolved with the structure in place, but the structure has to stay in place. Drop the structure and the chemistry rebuilds. The work is real and lasting, but it's a lifestyle, not a project.

THE WORK IS THE WORK. KEEP DOING IT.

The dogs that come out the other side of these protocols — calm, controllable, settled, capable of being part of your life without conflict — are the dogs whose owners stayed with the work. Not the most intense effort. Not the fastest. The ones who kept showing up, kept holding the structure, kept paying attention to the dog in front of them.

That's you, if you're reading this. Keep going. The work compounds.

— *Brian*

REFERENCE

Equipment Quick-Reference

The tools referenced across the protocols in this manual, what they do, and what to look for when buying.

SLIP LEAD

A six-foot, three-eighths inch diameter slip lead is the primary leash for the protocols in this manual. The slip rides high on the neck, just behind the ears, where the dog's perception of pressure is most precise. It applies clean directional pressure when needed and releases cleanly when the dog gives the right answer. The slip is a communication tool, not a containment tool.

What to look for: solid construction, three-eighths inch diameter (a quarter inch is too thin; a half inch is too thick for a teaching tool), a stopper to keep the loop from sliding off, leather or quality nylon. Avoid the cheap thin-rope versions sold in pet stores — they don't release cleanly.

LONG LINE

The long line is used in the recall protocol (Chapter 3) and any time you're working a dog at distance without full off-leash reliability. Twenty to fifty feet, depending on the environment. Light enough to drag without inhibiting movement. Cotton or biothane. Not a flexi-leash — those don't allow the dog to run freely or the handler to take up slack quickly.

What to look for: biothane is easier to clean and doesn't get heavy when wet. Cotton is gentler on the hands. Either works. Buy two — they wear out, especially the working ends, and having a backup matters.

PLACE BED (COT)

An elevated cot, raised three to six inches off the ground, with mesh or fabric stretched over a frame. The elevation matters — a place bed isn't just any cushion on the floor. The defined edges and slightly raised surface give the dog a clear sense of "in place" versus "out of place." That clarity is what makes the place command teachable.

What to look for: chew-resistant materials. A frame the dog cannot tip over. Several brands make these. Size up — the dog should be able to lie comfortably with a few inches of margin around them.

CRATE

Used across multiple chapters — Jumping (Chapter 2) for management during arrivals, Multi-Dog (Chapter 7) for the level-playing-field, Separation Anxiety (Chapter 8) as the central rehab tool. Wire crates work for most dogs. Plastic airline-style crates work for dogs who settle better in enclosed spaces. For severe separation anxiety with escape attempts, an aluminum or heavy-duty crate may be needed.

What to look for: size such that the dog can stand up, turn around, and lie down comfortably — but not significantly larger. Too-large crates allow the dog to soil one end and rest in the other, which undermines the structure. For wire crates, sturdy latches and a removable tray for cleaning. For plastic crates, ventilation on multiple sides.

MARKER (CLICKER OR VERBAL)

Every protocol in this manual relies on a clean marker. Most members do well with either a clicker or a verbal marker like "yes" or "good." Some prefer the clicker for sharpness; some prefer verbal for hands-free training. Either works as long as it's consistent — the marker has to mean the same thing every time.

What to look for, if going with a clicker: a button-style clicker with a quiet click, not the loud metal box style. Some dogs are sound-sensitive and the box clicker can be too sharp.

BARK COLLAR — THE BARKLESS PRO FROM E-COLLAR TECHNOLOGIES

For the yard-and-fence barking work in Chapter Four. This is the only specific product I recommend by name in this manual, because the difference between a quality bark collar and a cheap one is not subtle, and the cheap ones cause real harm.

The Barkless Pro has two features that make it the right tool. First, it detects vibration in the dog's vocal cords matched to sound — meaning in a multi-dog household, one dog's bark cannot trigger another dog's collar. Second, it runs a learning mode that starts every correction at level one and ramps gradually, so the dog learns at the lowest possible level for them.

Where to source: order through Real Dog Rehab — DM me inside the community for the link and the current pricing. We get them at a working trainer's rate and pass the savings on to members. Do not order generic bark collars from third-party sites. The differences in quality matter.

MUZZLE

For the Resource Guarding (Chapter 6) and Multi-Dog Aggression (Chapter 7) chapters, when there is any bite history. A properly conditioned muzzle is a safety tool, not a punishment, and it lets you run protocols that would otherwise be too risky during the early reps.

What to look for: a basket muzzle, not a fabric "grooming" muzzle. The basket allows the dog to pant, drink water, and take small treats through the gaps — which means the muzzle is wearable for extended sessions and the dog can be marked and paid through it. Brands vary; the right size is more important than the brand. The muzzle should sit so the dog has clearance from the nose to the front of the basket and cannot get the muzzle close enough to a person or another dog to make contact.

Conditioning the muzzle is its own short build that the 30-Day Quick Start Guide covers. Don't strap a muzzle on a dog who hasn't been conditioned to it — that adds stress to whatever protocol you're running.

E-COLLAR (FOR OFF-LEASH RECALL WORK)

Referenced in Chapter Three (Recall) as the layer that comes after a clean foundation when graduating to true off-leash reliability. The E-collar in my methodology is not a punishment tool — it's a motivational gas pedal that lets the recall cue stay enforceable at distance. The work to build that layer correctly is its own protocol, beyond the scope of this manual, and it lives in the E-Collar as a Gas Pedal track inside the community.

If you're considering an E-collar, do not buy one and start using it without the foundation work in place. Consequence before understanding is abuse — that principle applies particularly hard to E-collar work. DM me inside the community before you start that layer.

REFERENCE

Glossary

*Terms used across the chapters, defined the way I use them
in the methodology.*

ALWAYS OR NEVER

Brian's clarity rule. Dogs cannot live in the gray area — a behavior is either always allowed or never allowed. "Sometimes when I feel like it" is incoherent to a dog and produces a stressed, conflicted animal. Pick a rule and apply it consistently.

BULLETPROOFING

Phase Three of the obedience build. The process of making a behavior rock-solid through duration, distance, and distraction work. The dog learns to actively fight to maintain position when something tries to pull them out of it. Without bulletproofing, behaviors hold under low-distraction conditions and fall apart under real-world distractions.

COUNTER-CONDITIONING

The Pillar Two work. Changing the dog's emotional and chemical response to a trigger by pairing the trigger with something that produces opposite chemistry. The trigger that used to predict bad things now predicts paychecks. Done at distance, below threshold, over many reps.

ENGAGEMENT-AS-GATE

The principle that the dog accesses every resource — food, toys, affection, freedom — through engagement with the handler. The dog learns that fixation on the resource doesn't produce the resource; engagement with the handler does. Foundation for impulse control and most of the behavior work in this manual.

FOOD DRIVE

A dog's working motivation for food. Built deliberately by treating food as a finite resource — one meal a day, ten minutes to eat, food disappears for twenty-four hours if uneaten. Real food drive means the dog will work for kibble across distracting environments. Without food drive, almost every protocol in this manual stalls.

FORCED SEPARATION

Practiced independence — the dog being on their own cot or in their crate while the handler is in the same house but not engaging. The foundation skill for separation anxiety rehab. A dog that cannot be calm independently when you're home cannot be calm independently when you're gone.

FREE-SHAPE

A training method where the dog discovers a behavior on their own, without being lured or physically prompted. The dog tries variations, gets marked and paid for the right approximation, and figures out the puzzle through self-discovery. Builds independent problem-solving and produces stronger learning than lure-based training.

FUNCTIONAL OBEDIENCE

Obedience that holds across non-trigger distractions in multiple environments. Not just "the dog does it in the kitchen" — the dog holds the cue with food on the floor, with another person walking by, in the yard, in the front yard. The bar before any behavior modification protocol can run.

INCOMPATIBLE BEHAVIOR

A trained behavior that is, by its own mechanics, impossible to perform simultaneously with the unwanted behavior. A dog properly holding a down on place cannot also be lunging at the door. Pillar One of every protocol in this manual is the incompatible behavior, bulletproofed off-trigger.

LAND OF ALWAYS AND NEVER

Same as "always or never." Brian's framing of the dog's experience of rules. The land of "sometimes" stresses dogs out. Black-and-white rules let them relax into a known structure.

LEVEL PLAYING FIELD

The multi-dog household principle. Every dog meets the same standards — same crating arrangements, same resource gating, same calm-for-attention requirements. Inequality in the rules is read by the dogs as inconsistent leadership, which destabilizes the entire pack.

LOADED MARKER

A marker word or clicker that the dog has been classically conditioned to mean food is coming. The marker bridges the moment the dog does the right thing with the moment the food arrives. Without a loaded marker, training timing collapses.

MANAGEMENT VERSUS TRAINING

Management is what you do to prevent the dog from rehearsing a behavior — crates, gates, leashes, separation. Training is what changes the behavior. Both are required. Management buys the runway for training to happen. Neither is sufficient on its own.

NEGATIVE PUNISHMENT (-P)

One of the four operant quadrants. We remove something from the dog and the behavior becomes less likely to happen again. Dog jumps on guest, you turn and walk out — the social interaction the dog was getting is now gone. The dog has voted: *losing access to that landed in the discomfort column.*

NEGATIVE REINFORCEMENT (-R)

One of the four operant quadrants. We remove something from the dog and the behavior becomes more likely to happen again. Light leash pressure on. Dog moves into position. Pressure off. Over reps the dog moves into position faster when pressure starts. The foundation of every leash-trained dog.

PAY THE MENTAL SHIFT

The reactivity-rehab discipline of marking and rewarding only when the dog mentally disengages from the trigger and re-engages with the handler — not just when the body is in the

cued position. Body in position is not enough; mind re-engaged is the marker.

PILLAR ONE

Build the incompatible behavior, bulletproof it off-trigger. The first half of every protocol in this manual. The dog gets paid hundreds of reps of the right answer in environments where the trigger isn't present, before the trigger ever enters the picture.

PILLAR TWO

Change the emotional connection to the cue. Counter-condition the chemistry of the trigger so it predicts something good rather than something bad. Done at distance, below threshold, over weeks or months depending on the case.

PLACE

A trained behavior where the dog goes to a designated cot, downs, and holds until released. One of the most useful behaviors in the manual — used in jumping, barking, reactivity, resource guarding, multi-dog, and separation anxiety chapters.

POSITIVE PUNISHMENT (+P)

One of the four operant quadrants. We add something to the dog and the behavior becomes less likely to happen again. Dog hits the counter, finds a sizzling pan, counter-jumping diminishes over the next several days. The dog has voted: *that landed in the discomfort column hard*.

POSITIVE REINFORCEMENT (+R)

One of the four operant quadrants. We add something to the dog and the behavior becomes more likely to happen again. Dog sits, gets chicken, sit shows up faster on the next cue. The engine of every behavior in this manual is built on +R.

PRESSURE AS LANGUAGE

The reframe of leash pressure from "tug-of-war containment" to "two-way communication." Pressure on means a directional cue; pressure off when the dog gives the right answer means the cue was understood. Negative reinforcement applied as conversation rather than punishment.

REHEARSAL (OF BEHAVIOR)

Every time a dog runs a behavior, the brain logs the rep and the behavior pattern strengthens. Behaviors practiced grow in strength — desired or not. Reactive walks rehearse reactivity; jumping greetings rehearse jumping. Stopping the rehearsal is the first step in dismantling any unwanted pattern.

SOMATIC SHIFT

The visible physical change in a dog's body when they decompress and disengage from a trigger — eyes soften, body loosens, breathing settles, sometimes an audible sigh. The marker target in counter-conditioning work. Pay the somatic shift, not the body position.

THRESHOLD

The distance at which the dog begins to respond to their arousal in the presence of a trigger. Different for every dog and every context. The number-one rule of threshold work: start outside threshold and close the distance over reps. Working over threshold rehearses the bad pattern and sets the protocol back.

TWO MOTIVATORS

Brian's foundational principle of dog behavior. All behavior is driven by either creating an advantage (producing dopamine, serotonin, or other pleasure chemistry) or avoiding discomfort (physical, psychological, or environmental). The diagnostic question runs from this: *what advantage is this creating, or what discomfort is this avoiding?*

TWO PILLARS

The structural shape of every protocol in this manual. Pillar One: build the incompatible behavior, bulletproof off-trigger. Pillar Two: change the emotional connection to the trigger through threshold-based counter-conditioning. Every chapter applies the two-pillar shape to a specific behavior.

WAIT-OUT-THE-BARK

The barking-rehab protocol where the dog is back-tied on place, a trigger is presented (visitor, gate, sound), and the handler does nothing while the dog burns through the bark. When the dog finally settles into a calm down with a somatic shift, mark, pay, the trigger walks away. Sessions one through three typically drop from forty-five minutes down to under a minute.

WHAT DID THE DOG LEARN IN THIS MOMENT?

The diagnostic question that runs alongside every interaction with the dog. Every interaction teaches something. Asking the question during, rather than after, is what separates good handlers from great ones.

REFERENCE

Quick-Reference Index by Behavior

When something specific comes up, this index points you to the chapter and protocol that addresses it.

AGGRESSION

Toward another household dog → Chapter 7 (Multi-Dog Household Aggression). Over a resource → Chapter 6 (Resource Guarding). Toward strangers on walks → Chapter 5 (Leash Reactivity). Bite history with broken skin → DM Brian inside the community before continuing any protocol.

BARKING

At the doorbell or visitors → Chapter 4 (Track A) or Chapter 2 (Jumping). At the fence or in the yard → Chapter 4 (Track C). At the handler for attention or food → Chapter 4 (Track B). When alone → Chapter 8 (Separation Anxiety).

COUNTER SURFING

Not a dedicated chapter. Apply the framework: Pillar One (build a paid incompatible behavior — usually place) and Pillar Two (the counter itself becomes a non-rewarding location through management — clear counters during the rehab build). The same general structure as Chapter 6 resource guarding, with the resource being whatever's accessible from the counter.

DESTRUCTIVE BEHAVIOR WHEN ALONE

Chapter 8 (Separation Anxiety) — first verify the diagnostic by crating during absences. If the dog settles in the crate, the issue was unstructured freedom, not separation anxiety, and crating is the fix. If the dog panics in the crate, run the full protocol.

DOOR RUSHING

For visitors at the door → Chapter 2 (Jumping on People), Phase Two (door variables) and Phase Three (calm-for-attention). For going outside (rushing through the door to get out) → apply the same engagement-as-gate principle from Chapter 6, Phase One.

FENCE REACTIVITY

Chapter 4 (Nuisance Barking, Track C) for the bark collar approach if the dog is in the yard alone. Chapter 5 (Leash Reactivity) framing also applies — the fence is a controlled-distance trigger and the threshold work in Chapter 5 can be adapted to fenceline counter-conditioning when the handler is present.

JUMPING

On guests → Chapter 2 (Jumping on People), full protocol. On the handler when coming home → Chapter 2, with the handler as the visitor. On children → Chapter 2 with extra safety attention (manage with crate or gate during the rehab).

LEASH REACTIVITY

Chapter 5 (Leash Reactivity), full ninety-day protocol. Pair with Chapter 1 (Pulling on the Leash) if the dog also pulls heavily, leading with the foundation built in Chapter 1.

MOUTHING AND NIPPING

Not a dedicated chapter. For mouthing during play → manage with toys-as-redirect, run impulse control work from the foundation. For nipping during arrivals or greetings → Chapter 2 (Jumping). For nipping with broken skin or pressure that's leaving marks, DM in the community.

MULTI-DOG CONFLICTS

Chapter 7 (Multi-Dog Household Aggression), full protocol. If conflict is specifically over resources (food, toys, bones) → run Chapter 6 (Resource Guarding) in parallel.

PULLING ON LEASH

Chapter 1 (Pulling on the Leash), full protocol. If pulling is paired with reactivity (the dog pulls to get to other dogs or triggers) → also Chapter 5, with foundation work led by Chapter

1.

RECALL FAILURE

Chapter 3 (Recall Failure), full protocol. The two non-negotiable rules: every recall is paid more than not, and you never issue a recall you cannot enforce.

RESOURCE GUARDING

Chapter 6 (Resource Guarding), full protocol. If guarding is between two household dogs → run Chapter 7 in parallel.

SEPARATION ANXIETY

Chapter 8 (Separation Anxiety), full protocol. First verify the diagnostic by crating during absences for one to two weeks.

WHINING AND DEMAND BARKING

Chapter 4 (Track B, demand barking). Apply the principle that the resource the dog is whining for never arrives during the whine.